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THE ECONOMIC TIMES

BENNETT, COLEMAN & CO. LTD. | ESTD. 1838 VOL. 42 NO. 213 | BENGALURU | 18 PAGES | ₹4.00 ONLY (₹12.00 WITH ET WEALTH) MONDAY, 7 SEPTEMBER 2026

Online sales are expected at a record ₹1.55 lakh crore during this year's festive season sale events, up 25-29% on-year, as per Datum Intelligence ▶ P 1

▶ PSU Insurers Eye ₹7,200-Crore Windfall from Long-held NSE Stakes ▶ India to Push for Stronger Ties in AI, Deep Tech & Semicon at BRICS Meet: P 1


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MONDAY, 7 SEPTEMBER 2026

The AAP govt in Punjab is facing a big challenge from its own employees five months ahead of state polls as they intensify their agitation ▶ Page 3

▶ India, China Hold Corps Commander Meet in Arunachal for 1st Time ▶ UN-backed World Map must Show J&K, Ladakh as Per India's Official Map, says MEA: P 2

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NOT FOR RELEASE, PUBLICATION OR DISTRIBUTION DIRECTLY OR INDIRECTLY, OUTSIDE INDIA.
Initial public offer of equity shares on the main board of BSE Limited ("BSE") and National Stock Exchange of India Limited ("NSE", and together with BSE, the "Stock Exchanges") in compliance with Chapter II of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Issue of Capital and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2018, as amended ("SEBI ICDR Regulations").

(Please scan this QR Code to view the Red Herring Prospectus, Abridged Prospectus and Corrigendum cum Price Band Advertisement)

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REDEVELOPING HOMES
REBUILDING COMMUNITIES

PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED
(TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)

Our Company was originally incorporated as "Pranav Constructions Private Limited", a private limited company under the provisions of the Companies Act, 1956, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation dated July 31, 2003, issued by the Registrar of Companies, Maharashtra at Mumbai. The name of our Company was subsequently changed to "Pranav Constructions Limited", upon conversion of the Company from a private limited to a public limited company, pursuant to a Board resolution dated June 1, 2024, and a Shareholders resolution dated June 5, 2024, and a fresh certificate of incorporation was issued on July 29, 2024, by the Registrar of Companies, Central Processing Centre. For details of the changes in the name and the registered and corporate office of our Company, see *"History and Certain Corporate Matters"* on page 240 of the red herring prospectus dated August 31, 2026 (**"RHP"**) filed with the RoC read with Corrigendum to the RHP dated September 1, 2026.

Registered and Corporate Office: Unit No. 1001, 10th Floor, DLH Park, Near MTNL, S.V. Road, Goregaon (West), Mumbai – 400 104;
Contact Person: Ritu Jain, Company Secretary and Compliance Officer; **Telephone:** +91 22 6276 9939; **E-mail:** compliance.officer@pranavconstructions.com; **Website:** www.pranavconstructions.com; **Corporate Identity Number:** U70101MH2003PLC141547

OUR PROMOTERS: PRANAV KIRAN ASHAR AND RAVI RAMALINGAM

INITIAL PUBLIC OFFER OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED (OUR "COMPANY" OR THE "COMPANY" OR THE "ISSUER") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE (INCLUDING A PREMIUM OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE) (THE "OFFER PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹[●] MILLION (THE "OFFER") COMPRISING A FRESH ISSUE OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES BY OUR COMPANY AGGREGATING UP TO ₹3,156.00 MILLION (THE "FRESH ISSUE") AND AN OFFER FOR SALE OF UP TO 2,856,869 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH BY BIOURJA INDIA INFRA PRIVATE LIMITED AGGREGATING UP TO ₹[●] MILLION (SUCH OFFER FOR SALE OF EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH BY THE SELLING SHAREHOLDER, THE "OFFER FOR SALE"). THE OFFER SHALL CONSTITUTE [●]% OF THE POST-OFFER PAID UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY.

DETAILS OF THE SELLING SHAREHOLDER, OFFER FOR SALE AND WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION

NAME OF THE SELLING SHAREHOLDER	TYPE	MAXIMUM NUMBER OF OFFERED SHARES	WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION# PER EQUITY SHARE (₹)
BioUrja India Infra Private Limited	Investor Selling Shareholder	Up to 2,856,869 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each aggregating up to ₹[●] million.	42.55

#*As certified by Agrawal Jain & Gupta, Chartered Accountants, Independent Chartered Accountants of our Company, by way of their certificate dated August 31, 2026.*

PRICE BAND: ₹118 TO ₹124 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH.
THE FLOOR PRICE IS 11.80 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES AND THE CAP PRICE IS 12.40 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES.
BIDS CAN BE MADE FOR A MINIMUM OF 120 EQUITY SHARES BEARING FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH AND IN MULTIPLES OF 120 EQUITY SHARES THEREAFTER.
THE PRICE TO EARNINGS RATIO ("P/E") BASED ON DILUTED EPS FOR FISCAL 2026 AT THE LOWER END OF THE PRICE BAND (i.e FLOOR PRICE) IS 14.43 TIMES AND AT THE UPPER END OF THE PRICE BAND (i.e CAP PRICE) IS 15.16 TIMES AS COMPARED TO THE AVERAGE INDUSTRY PEER GROUP P/E RATIO OF 113.46 TIMES FOR FISCAL 2026.
WEIGHTED AVERAGE RETURN ON NET WORTH FOR LAST THREE FINANCIAL YEARS IS 43.44%.

The details of the Fresh Issue, Offer for Sale and the post Offer market capitalization of the Company, each at the Floor Price and the Cap Price, are given below:

Particulars	At Floor Price of ₹118 each		At Cap Price of ₹124 each	
	Upto nos. of Equity Shares of Face Value ₹10 each	Upto amount (₹ in Million)	Upto nos. of Equity Shares of Face Value ₹10 each	Upto amount (₹ in Million)
Fresh Issue	26,745,762	3,156.00	25,451,612	3,156.00
Offer For Sale	2,856,869	337.11	2,856,869	354.25
Total Offer Size	**29,602,631**	**3,493.11**	**28,308,481**	**3,510.25**
Post Offer Market Capitalisation of Company	113,916,932	13,442.20	112,622,782	13,965.23

BID / OFFER PERIOD	BID/OFFER OPENS TODAY
	BID/OFFER CLOSING DATE WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 09, 2026(1)

(1)*UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 pm on the Bid/Offer Closing Date.*

We are a real estate company with a total of 1,864 units and 34 MCGM – Redevelopment projects (completed and under construction) launched between CY 17 – Q1 CY 26. We are amongst the redevelopment companies based out of Mumbai predominantly undertaking redevelopment projects in the Western Suburbs focusing on Economical, Mid and Mass, and Aspirational homes *(Source: C&W Report).*

THE OFFER IS BEING MADE THROUGH THE BOOK BUILDING PROCESS IN ACCORDANCE WITH REGULATION 6(1) OF THE SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS.
THE EQUITY SHARES OF THE COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARDS OF BSE LIMITED (BSE) AND NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED (NSE). NSE SHALL BE THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE.
• QIB PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 40% OF THE OFFER • NON-INSTITUTIONAL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 15% OF THE OFFER • RETAIL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 45% OF THE OFFER

IN MAKING AN INVESTMENT DECISION, POTENTIAL INVESTORS MUST RELY ONLY ON THE INFORMATION INCLUDED IN THE RHP AND THE TERMS OF THE OFFER, INCLUDING THE RISKS INVOLVED AND NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION ABOUT THE OFFER AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER. IN RELATION TO PRICE BAND, POTENTIAL INVESTORS SHOULD ONLY REFER TO THIS PRICE BAND ADVERTISEMENT FOR THE OFFER AND SHOULD NOT RELY ON ANY MEDIA ARTICLES/ REPORTS IN RELATION TO THE VALUATION OF THE COMPANY AS THESE ARE NOT ENDORSED, PUBLISHED OR CONFIRMED EITHER BY THE COMPANY OR THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS TO THE OFFER ("BRLMs").

IN ACCORDANCE WITH THE RECOMMENDATION OF THE COMMITTEE OF INDEPENDENT DIRECTORS OF OUR COMPANY, PURSUANT TO THEIR RESOLUTION DATED SEPTEMBER 01, 2026, THE ABOVE PROVIDED PRICE BAND IS JUSTIFIED BASED ON QUANTITATIVE FACTORS/ KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS ("KPIS") DISCLOSED IN THE *"BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE"* SECTION BEGINNING FROM PAGE 124 OF THE RHP VIS-A-VIS THE WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION ("WACA") OF PRIMARY AND SECONDARY TRANSACTION(S), AS APPLICABLE, AS DISCLOSED IN THE *"BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE"* SECTION BEGINNING FROM PAGE 124 OF THE RHP.

Risk to Investors
For details, refer to section titled *"Risk Factors"* on page 18 of the RHP.

1. **Geographic concentration:** Our Redevelopment activities are geographically concentrated in the MCGM Region, which has accounted for 99.70%, 99.69% and 99.50% of our revenue from operations for Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024, respectively.

Particulars	Consolidated		
	Fiscal 2026	Fiscal 2025	Fiscal 2024
Revenue from operations (in ₹ million)	7,615.96	6,362.72	4,474.83
Revenue from operations as a percentage of total income (%)	99.70%	99.69%	99.50%

2. **Risk of completion of construction:** An inability to complete our Under-construction Redevelopment Projects and Upcoming Redevelopment Projects by their respective expected completion dates or in achieving milestones as mentioned in the agreement may subject us to RERA mandated penalties, interest payments and cancellation liabilities. Such delays could also lead to customer dissatisfaction, negative publicity, litigation, loss of buyer confidence, revocation of approvals, and failure to realize expected project economics.
3. **Risk of timely delivery:** Rapid escalation in property prices lead to significant challenges, particularly for economical and mid & mass groups. This scenario drastically reduces housing affordability, which in turn diminishes overall demand and can result in a slowdown of market activity. Our Company's operations are concentrated on the construction of Economical, Mid and Mass and Aspirational homes, escalation in property prices may impact the purchasing power of our customers, curtail our ability to sell units, and may have an adverse impact on our business and revenue from operations.
4. **Supplier concentration and absence of agreements:** We do not enter into agreements for supply of construction materials for our Redevelopment Projects and depend on a limited number of suppliers for construction materials. As of Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024, our top 10 suppliers contributed to 61.78%, 69.80% and 52.50% of the total material costs, respectively. If, for any reason, our suppliers of construction materials curtail or discontinue their delivery of such construction materials to us in the quantities we need, or we are unable to source from alternative suppliers on commercially acceptable terms or if we are unable to source from alternative suppliers, our Redevelopment Project schedule could be disrupted, and our business and results of operations could be adversely affected.
5. **Concentration of contractors:** Our Company avails services of independent contractors for construction of our Redevelopment Projects based on work contracts. We depend on a limited number of third party contractors to construct our Redevelopment Projects and if a contractor fails to perform its obligations satisfactorily or within the prescribed time periods with regard to a Redevelopment Project, or terminates its arrangement with us, we may be unable to develop the Redevelopment Project within the intended timeframe and within the anticipated budget. The table below provides the percentage of amount paid to our top 10 contractors for the periods indicated:

Particulars	Consolidated		
	Fiscal 2026	Fiscal 2025	Fiscal 2024
Total amount paid to contractors (in ₹ million)	673.74	626.96	347.68
Top five contractors as a % of total amount paid to contractors	32.29%	37.43%	30.60%
Top 10 contractors as a % of total amount paid to contractors	47.10%	56.41%	46.92%

6. **Acquisition of Redevelopment Projects:** We may not be able to successfully identify and acquire Redevelopment Projects in the future, which may have an adverse impact on our business and the growth of our Company.
7. **Irregularities in the title or use of land of Redevelopment Projects:** We have entered into Redevelopment agreements with Co-operative Housing Societies to acquire Redevelopment rights which may entail risks pertaining to irregularities in the title or use of land for which we have acquired Redevelopment rights which could have an adverse impact on our business operations and financial performance.
8. **Financial risk:** Our business requires significant expenditure for Redevelopment Projects and is dependent on the availability of financing, which may not be available on terms acceptable to us in a timely manner or at all. Our inability to obtain funding on reasonable terms, or at all, could affect our ability to construct our Redevelopment Projects and would have an adverse effect on our business and results of operations. The table below provides brief details of our borrowings for the periods indicated:

(in ₹ million)

Particulars	Consolidated		
	As at March 31, 2026	As at March 31, 2025	As at March 31, 2024
Secured borrowings	2,348.39	1,528.95	563.43
Unsecured borrowings	236.04	436.02	429.92
Total borrowings	**2,584.43**	**1,964.97**	**993.35**

9. **Penalty risk under the Redevelopment agreements:** We are subject to penalty clauses under the Redevelopment agreements entered into with Co-operative Housing Societies for any delay in the completion or defects in construction of the Redevelopment Projects. Any inability to complete these constructions in a timely manner or at all, may result in termination of Redevelopment agreement by the Co-operative Housing Societies and may result in penalties. We have not faced any penalties in the past. Further, we are required to pay displacement compensation to the members of the Co-operative Housing Societies we re-develop. In cases of delay in construction of our Redevelopment Projects, our Company may be required to pay displacement compensation to the members for such extended period which may affect the overall profitability of the Redevelopment Projects. Any displacement compensation for the extended period, if paid, may affect the overall profitability of the Redevelopment Project and therefore adversely affect our business, results of operation and financial condition. Further, any delays in completing our Redevelopment Projects as scheduled could result in dissatisfaction among the Co-operative Housing Societies, resulting in negative publicity impacting our brand name and goodwill, consumer litigation and lack of confidence among future customers for our Redevelopment Projects.
10. We have experienced negative cash flows in Fiscal 2026 and Fiscal 2025, primarily due to the inherent nature of real estate development and redevelopment. The following table sets forth certain information relating to our cash flows for the years indicated:

(in ₹ million)

Particulars	Consolidated		
	Fiscal 2026	Fiscal 2025	Fiscal 2024
Net cash inflow/(outflow) from operating activities	(411.94)	(926.01)	54.62

11. Details of weighted average cost of acquisition of Equity Shares transacted in one year, 18 months and three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus:

Period	Weighted average cost of acquisition per Equity Share (in ₹)*	Cap Price is 'x' times the weighted average cost of acquisition*	Range of acquisition price per Equity Share: lowest price – highest price (in ₹)*
Last one year preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	240.00	0.52	240.00 - 240.00
Last 18 months preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	240.00	0.52	240.00 - 240.00
Last three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	10.37	11.96	Nil – 4,130.00

**As certified by Agrawal Jain & Gupta, Chartered Accountants, Independent Chartered Accountants by way of their certificate dated September 01, 2026.*

12. The weighted average return on net worth for the last three Fiscals is 43.44%.
13. The details of revenue from operations, EPS, price/earnings, net asset value, return on net worth for our Company

Continued on next page...

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and our peer group are set out hereunder:

Name of Company	Latest financial year	Face Value (₹ per share)	Closing Price on July 23, 2026 (₹)	Revenue from Operations (in ₹ million)	EPS (₹ per share)		NAV (₹ per share)	P/E	RONW (%)
					Basic	Diluted			
Pranav Constructions Limited	Consolidated	10	NA	7,615.96	8.18	8.18	28.30	NA	33.78
Keystone Realtors Limited	Consolidated	10	402.80	26,345.40	6.25	6.21	229.29	64.86	3.34
Godrej Properties Limited	Consolidated	5	2,042.20	51,314.30	61.43	61.42	642.58	33.25	9.97
Lodha Developers Limited *(Formerly known as Macrotech Developers Limited)*	Consolidated	10	1,146.60	1,66,762.00	34.34	34.25	234.55	33.48	15.71
Suraj Estate Developers Limited	Consolidated	5	193.95	5,558.62	19.51	19.51	207.87	9.94	9.53
Kolte-Patil Developers Limited	Consolidated	10	388.65	7,349.60	(4.51)	(4.51)	135.84	NA	(3.73)
Arkade Developers Limited	Consolidated	10	139.95	8,164.02	0.29	0.29	47.51	482.59	0.60
Kalpataru Limited	Consolidated	10	269.60	34,356.20	4.76	4.76	198.04	56.64	2.45

Notes:

(i) All the financial information for the Company mentioned above is based on the Restated Financial information, for the financial year ended March 31, 2026.

(ii) All the financial information for listed industry peer mentioned above is sourced from the audited financial statements of the relevant company for Fiscal 2026 as available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges.

(iii) The industry P/E ratio mentioned above is for the Financial Year ended March 31, 2026. P/E ratio has been computed based on the closing market price of equity shares on NSE/BSE on July 23, 2026, divided by the Diluted EPS for the year ended March 31, 2026.

(iv) For listed peers, Net Asset Value (NAV) is computed as equity attributable to owners (total equity) divided by the number of equity shares outstanding as on March 31, 2026.

(v) For listed peers, Return on Net Worth for equity shareholders (RONW) (%) = Profit for the year divided by total average equity.

(vi) EBITDA is calculated as PBT+ Interest+ Depreciation and Amortizations+ Finance cost.

14. Weighted average cost of acquisition compared to Floor Price and Cap Price:

Types of transactions	Weighted average cost of acquisition (₹ per Equity Share)	Floor price (i.e., ₹118)	Cap price (i.e., ₹124)
- Based on primary transactions	NA	NA	NA
- Based on secondary transactions	240.00	0.49 times	0.52 times

Note: As certified by Agrawal Jain & Gupta, Chartered Accountants, Independent Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated September 01, 2026.

15. The Price/Earning ("P/E") ratio based on diluted EPS for latest full financial year 2026 for the issuer at the upper end of the Price band is as high as 15.16 as compared to the average industry peer group P/E ratio of 113.46.

16. The average cost of acquisition of equity shares for the Investor Selling Shareholder in IPO is ₹42.55 and offer price at the upper end of the price band is ₹124.

17. The BRLMs associated with the Offer have handled 7 public issues in the past 3 years out of which 3 issues closed below the issue price on listing date.

Name of the BRLMs	Total Issues	Issues Closed below Offer Price
Centrum Broking Limited *(as successor to the merchant banking business of Centrum Capital Limited)*	4	3
PNB Investment Services Limited	3	0
Total	**7**	**3**

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION FOR INVESTORS:

1. The Company has not undertaken any pre-IPO placement.
2. The Promoters or members of the Promoter Group have not undertaken any transaction of shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company from the date of Draft Red Herring Prospectus till date.

BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE

The *"Basis for Offer Price"* on page 124 of the RHP has been updated with the above Price Band. Please refer to the websites of the BRLMs: www.centrumbroking.com and www.pnbisl.com for the *"Basis for Offer Price"* updated with the above price band.
You may scan the QR code for accessing the website of Centrum Broking Limited *(as successor to the Merchant Banking Business of Centrum Capital Limited)*.

AN INDICATIVE TIMETABLE IN RESPECT OF THE OFFER IS SET OUT BELOW:

Submission of Bids (other than Bids from Anchor Investors):

Bid/ Offer Period (except the Bid/ Offer Closing Date)	
Submission and Revision in Bids	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 5.00 p.m. Indian Standard Time ("**IST**")
Bid/ Offer Closing Date*	
Submission of Electronic Applications (Online ASBA through 3-in-1 accounts) – For RIBs, other than QIBs and NIIs	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST
Submission of Electronic Applications (Bank ASBA through Online channels like Internet Banking, Mobile Banking and Syndicate UPI ASBA applications where Bid Amount is upto ₹500,000)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 4.00 p.m. IST
Submission of Electronic Applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual Applications)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 3.00 p.m. IST
Submission of Physical Applications (Bank ASBA)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 1.00 p.m. IST
Submission of Physical Applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual Applications where Bid Amount is more than ₹500,000)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 12.00 p.m. IST
Modification/ Revision/cancellation of Bids	
Upward Revision of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders categories#	Only between 10.00 a.m. on Bid/Offer Opening Date and up to 4.00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Offer Closing Date
Upward or downward Revision of Bids or cancellation of Bids by RIBs	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST on Bid/Offer Closing Date

** UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 05:00 p.m. on Bid/ Offer Closing Date.*

 # QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders can neither revise their bids downwards nor cancel/withdraw their bids.

Bid / Offer Programme:

BID/OFFER OPENS ON	MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 07, 2026(1)
BID/OFFER CLOSES ON	WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 09, 2026(2)(3)

(1) Our Company in consultation with the BRLMs, may consider participation by Anchor Investors.

(2) Our Company may consider closing the Bid/Offer Period for QIBs one day prior to the Bid/Offer Closing Date in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations

(3) UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 pm IST on Bid/ Offer Closing Date, i.e. Wednesday, September 09, 2026

Bid / Offer Programme:

Event	Indicative Date
Finalisation of Basis of Allotment with the Designated Stock Exchange	On or about Thursday, September 10, 2026
Initiation of refunds (if any, for Anchor Investors)/unblocking of funds from ASBA Account*	On or about Friday, September 11, 2026
Credit of Equity Shares to dematerialized accounts of Allottees	On or about Friday, September 11, 2026
Commencement of trading of the Equity Shares on the Stock Exchanges	On or about Tuesday, September 15, 2026

** In case of any delay in unblocking of amounts in the ASBA Accounts (including amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism) exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date for cancelled / withdrawn / deleted ASBA Forms, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher from the date on which the request for cancellation/ withdrawal/ deletion is placed in the Stock Exchanges bidding platform until the date on which the amounts are unblocked (ii) any blocking of multiple amounts for the same ASBA Form (for amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism), the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the total cumulative blocked amount except the original application amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such multiple amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iii) any blocking of amounts more than the Bid Amount, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the difference in amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such excess amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iv) any delay in unblocking of non-allotted/partially allotted Bids, exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher for the entire duration of delay exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date by the SCSB responsible for causing such delay in unblocking. The BRLMs shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix the liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking. The Bidder shall be compensated in the manner specified in the SEBI ICDR Master Circular in case of delays in resolving investor grievances in relation to unblocking/ unblocking of funds, which for the avoidance of doubt, shall be deemed to be incorporated in the deemed agreement of the Company with the SCSBs, to the extent applicable.*

On the Bid/ Offer Closing Date, the Bids shall be uploaded until:

(i) 4.00 p.m. IST in case of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders, and

(ii) until 5.00 p.m. IST or such extended time as permitted by the Stock Exchanges, in case of Bids by RIBs.

On Bid/Offer Closing Date, extension of time may be granted by Stock Exchanges only for uploading Bids received RIBs, after taking into account the total number of Bids received and as reported by the BRLMs to the Stock Exchanges.

UPI-Now available in ASBA for Retail Individual Investors and Non Institutional Investor applying in public issues where the application amount is up to ₹ 500,000, applying through Registered Brokers, Syndicate, CDPs & RTAs. Retail Individual Investors and Non-Institutional Investors also have the option to submit the application directly to the ASBA Bank (SCSBs) or to use the facility of linked online trading, demat and bank account. Investors are required to ensure that the bank account used for bidding is linked to their PAN. Bidders must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with CBDT notification dated February 13, 2020 and press release dated June 25, 2021 read with press release dated September 17, 2021, CBDT Circular No. 3 of 2023 dated March 28, 2023, and any subsequent press release in this regard.

*ASBA has to be availed by all the investors except Anchor Investors. UPI may be availed by (i) Retail Individual Investors in the Retail Category; (ii) Non-Institutional Investors with an application size of up to ₹ 500,000 in the Non-Institutional Portion. For details on the ASBA and UPI process, please refer to the details given in the Bid Cum Application Form and Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to the section **"Offer Procedure"** on page 416 of the RHP. The process is also available on the website of Association of Investment Bankers of India ("**AIBI**") and Stock Exchanges and in the General Information Document. The Bid Cum Application Form and the Abridged Prospectus can be downloaded from the websites of the Stock Exchanges and can be obtained from the list of banks that is displayed on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFpi=yes&intmId=35 and https://www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFpi=yes &intmId=43, respectively as updated from time to time. For the list of UPI apps and banks live on IPO, please refer to the link: www.sebi.gov.in. UPI Bidders Bidding using the UPI Mechanism may apply through the SCSBs and mobile applications whose names appear on the website of SEBI, as updated from time to time. Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited and HDFC Bank Limited have been appointed as the Sponsor Banks for the Offer, in accordance with the requirements of SEBI circular dated November 1, 2018 as amended. For Offer related queries, please contact the BRLMs on their respective email IDs as mentioned below. For UPI related queries, investors can contact NPCI at the toll free number: 18001201740 and mail Id: ipo.upi@npci.org.in.*

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD PLATFORMS OF THE STOCK EXCHANGES.

In case of any revision in the Price Band, the Bid/Offer Period will be extended by at least three additional Working Days after such revision of the Price Band subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding a total of 10 Working Days. In case of force majeure, banking strike or similar circumstances, our Company may, in consultation with the Book Running Lead Managers, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid/Offer Period for a minimum of One Working Day, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. Any revision in the Price Band and the revised Bid/Offer Period, if applicable, will be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice, and also by indicating the change on the respective websites of the Book Running Lead Managers and at the terminals of the other members of the Syndicate and by intimation to the other Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Bank(s), as applicable.

This is an Offer in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) of the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Rules, 1957, as amended ("**SCRR**"), read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI ICDR Regulations. The Offer is being made through the Book Building Process in terms of Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, wherein in terms of Regulation 32(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, not more than 40% of the Offer shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Qualified Institutional Buyers ("**QIBs**", and such portion, the "QIB Portion") provided that our Company in consultation with the BRLMs, may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors on a discretionary basis in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations ("**Anchor Investor Portion**"). 40% of the Anchor Investor Portion shall be reserved for (i) 33.33% for domestic Mutual Funds, and (ii) 6.67% for Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, subject to valid Bids being received from the domestic Mutual Funds, Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, as applicable, at or above the Anchor Investor Allocation Price, subject to valid Bids being received from domestic Mutual Funds at or above the price at which allotment is made to the Anchor Investor ("**Anchor Investor Allocation Price**"). In the event of under-subscription in (ii) above, the allocation may be made to domestic Mutual Funds. In the event of under-subscription or non-allocation in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the Net QIB Portion. Further, 5% of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis only to Mutual Funds and the remainder of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to all QIB Bidders (other than Anchor Investors) including Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. Further, not less than 15% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Bidders out of which (a) one-third of such portion shall be reserved for applicants with application size of more than ₹0.20 million and up to ₹1.00 million; and (b) two-third of such portion shall be reserved for applicants with application size of more than ₹1.00 million, provided that the unsubscribed portion in either of such sub-categories may be allocated to applicants in the other sub-category of Non-Institutional Bidders subject to valid bids being received at or above the Offer Price and not less than 45% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to Retail Individual Bidders ("**RIBs**") in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received from them at or above the Offer Price. All potential Bidders (except Anchor Investors) are required to mandatorily utilise the Application Supported by Blocked Amount ("**ASBA**") process by providing details of their respective bank accounts (including UPI ID for UPI Bidders using UPI Mechanism) (as defined hereinafter) in which the Bid amount will be blocked by the SCSBs or the Sponsor Banks, as applicable, to participate in the Offer. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Anchor Investor Portion of the Offer through the ASBA process. For details, see ***"Offer Procedure"*** on page 416 of the RHP.

Bidders/Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN and the Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through UPI Mechanism) are correctly filled in the Bid cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID available (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/Applicants should ensure that the beneficiary account provided in the Bid cum Application Form is active. Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorized the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Offer, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic Details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other correspondence(s) related to the Offer. Bidders/Applicants are advised to update any changes to their Demographic Details as available in the records of the Depository Participant to ensure accuracy of records. Any delay resulting from failure to update the Demographic Details would be at the Bidders/Applicants' sole risk.

Investors must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with the notification issued by Central Board of Direct Taxes notification dated February 13, 2020 and read with press releases dated June 25, 2021, September 17, 2021 and March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press releases in this regard.

Contents of the Memorandum of Association of our Company as Regards its Objects: For information on the main objects of our Company, please see **"*History and Certain Corporate Matters - Main objects of our Company*"** on page 240 of the RHP. The Memorandum of Association of our Company is a material document for inspection in relation to the Offer. For further details, see **"*Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection*"** on page 461 of the RHP.

Liability of the Members of our Company: Limited by shares.

Amount of Share Capital of our Company and Capital Structure: As on the date of the RHP, the authorised share capital of our Company is ₹1,190,000,000 divided into 119,000,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each. The issued, subscribed and paid-up Equity share capital of our Company is ₹871,711,700 divided into 87,171,170 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each. For details of the capital structure of the Company, see **"*Capital Structure*"** beginning on page 76 of the RHP.

Names of the Initial Signatories to the Memorandum of Association of the Company and the Number of Equity Shares Subscribed by them: The initial signatories of the Memorandum of Association of the Company are as follows: 4,900 Equity Shares allotted to Pranav Kiran Ashar and 5,100 Equity Shares allotted to Kiran Dharamsey Ashar. For details of the share capital history of our Company please see **"*Capital Structure*"** beginning on page 76 of the RHP.

Listing: The Equity Shares to be offered through the Red Herring Prospectus are proposed to be listed on the Stock Exchanges. Our Company has received 'in-principle' approvals from the BSE and the NSE for the listing of the Equity Shares pursuant to their letters each dated May 28, 2025. For the purpose of the Offer, NSE is the Designated Stock Exchange. A signed copy of the Red Herring Prospectus and the Prospectus will be filed with the RoC in accordance with Section 26(4) and 32 of the Companies Act, 2013, respectively. For details of the material contracts and documents that will be available for inspection from the date of the Red Herring Prospectus up to the Bid/Offer Closing Date, see ***"Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection"*** on page 461 of the RHP.

Disclaimer Clause of Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"): SEBI only gives its observations on the offer documents and this does not constitute approval of either the Offer or the specified securities stated in the Offer Documents. The investors are advised to refer to page 396 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of SEBI.

Disclaimer Clause of BSE: It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by BSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the RHP has been cleared or approved by BSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the RHP. The investors are advised to refer to the page 399 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of BSE.

Disclaimer Clause of NSE (the Designated Stock Exchange): It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by NSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the Offer Document has been cleared or approved by NSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the Offer Document. The investors are advised to refer to page 399 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of NSE.

General Risks: Investment in equity and equity-related securities involve a degree of risk and investors should not invest any funds in the Offer unless they can afford to take the risk of losing their entire investment. Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Offer. For taking an investment decision, investors must rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer, including the risks involved. The Equity Shares in the Offer have not been recommended or approved by the SEBI, nor does SEBI guarantee the accuracy or adequacy of the contents of the Red Herring Prospectus. Specific attention of the investors is invited to ***"Risk Factors"*** on page 18 of the RHP.

BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS		REGISTRAR TO THE OFFER	COMPANY SECRETARY AND COMPLIANCE OFFICER
Centrum Broking Limited ***(as successor to the merchant banking business of Centrum Capital Limited)*** Level 9, Centrum House, C.S.T. Road, Vidyanagari Marg Kalina, Santacruz (East), Mumbai – 400 098 Maharashtra, India. **Telephone:** +91 22 4215 9000; **E-mail:** pcpl.ipo@centrum.co.in **Investor Grievance E-mail:** investor.grievances@centrum.co.in **Website:** www.centrumbroking.com **Contact Person:** Sooraj Bhatia / Tarun Parmani **SEBI Registration No.:** INM000013420	(A wholly owned subsidiary of Punjab National Bank) **PNB Investment Services Limited** PNB Pragati Towers, 2nd Floor, Plot No. C-9, G-Block Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai – 400 051 **Telephone:** +91 22 6917 4200 **E-mail:** project.9realms@pnbisl.com **Website:** www.pnbisl.com **Investor grievance e-mail:** complaints@pnbisl.com **Contact person:** Taher Engineer/ Omkar Nage **SEBI registration No.:** INM000011617	**KFin Technologies Limited** Selenium Tower B, Plot No. 31 and 32, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Serilingampally Hyderabad-500 032, Telangana, India **Telephone:** +91 6716 2222/18003094001 **E-mail:** pcpl.ipo@kfintech.com **Investor Grievance e-mail:** einward.ris@kfintech.com **Website:** www.kfintech.com **Contact Person:** M Murali Krishna **SEBI Registration No.:** INR000000221	**Ritu Jain** **PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED** Unit No. 1001, 10th Floor, DLH Park Near MTNL, S.V. Road, Goregaon (West), Mumbai – 400 104 **Telephone:** +91 22 6276 9939 **E-mail:** compliance.officer@pranavconstructions.com **Website:** www.pranavconstructions.com Investors may contact the Company Secretary and Compliance Officer or the Registrar to the Offer in case of any pre-Offer or post-Offer related grievances including non-receipt of letters of Allotment, non-credit of Allotted Equity Shares in the respective beneficiary account, non-receipt of refund orders or non-receipt of funds by electronic mode, etc. For all Offer related queries and for redressal of complaints, investors may also write to the BRLMs.

AVAILABILITY OF THE RHP: Investors are advised to refer to the RHP and the ***"Risk Factors"*** beginning on page 18 of the RHP before applying in the Offer. A copy of the RHP will be made available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in and is available on the websites of the BRLMs, Centrum Broking Limited *(as successor to the merchant banking business of Centrum Capital Limited)* at www.centrumbroking.com and PNB Investment Services Limited at www.pnbisl.com and at the website of the Company, Pranav Constructions Limited at www.pranavconstructions.com and the websites of the Stock Exchanges, for BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and for National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com.

AVAILABILITY OF THE ABRIDGED PROSPECTUS: A copy of the Abridged Prospectus shall be available on the website of the Company, the BRLMs and the Registrar to the Offer at: www.pranavconstructions.com, www.centrumbroking.com, www.pnbisl.com and www.kfintech.com, respectively.

AVAILABILITY OF BID CUM APPLICATION FORM: Bid cum Application Form can be obtained from the Registered Office of our Company, **PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED**: Telephone: +91 22 6276 9939; **BRLMs:** Centrum Broking Limited *(as successor to the merchant banking business of Centrum Capital Limited)*, Telephone: +91 22 4215 9000; PNB Investment Services Limited, Telephone: +91 22 6917 4200 and **Syndicate Members:** Centrum Broking Limited, Telephone: +91 22 4215 9000, Registered Brokers, SCSBs, Designated RTA Locations and Designated CDP Locations for participating in the Offer. Bid cum Application Forms will also be available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and at all the Designated Branches of SCSBs, the list of which is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges and SEBI.

SUB-SYNDICATE MEMBERS: Anand Rathi Share & Stock Brokers Limited, Axis Capital Limited, HDFC Securities Limited, ICICI Securities Limited, IDBI Capital Markets & Securities Limited, IIFL Capital Services Limited, JM Financial Services Limited, Keynote Capitals Limited, KJMC Capital Market Services Limited, Kotak Securities Limited, LKP Securities Limited, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Limited, Nuvama Wealth and Investment Limited, Prabhudas Lilladher Private Limited, Pravin Ratilal Share And Stock Brokers Limited, SBICAP Securities Limited, Sharekhan Limited, SMC Global Securities Limited, Asit C. Mehta Investment Intermediates Limited, RR Equity Brokers Private Limited, Yes Securities (India) Limited, and Zerodha Broking Limited.

ESCROW COLLECTION BANK: Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited. | **PUBLIC OFFER ACCOUNT BANK:** HDFC Bank Limited.

REFUND BANK: Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited. | **SPONSOR BANKS:** Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited and HDFC Bank Limited.

UPI: UPI Bidders can also Bid through UPI Mechanism.

All capitalised terms used herein and not specifically defined shall have the same meaning as ascribed to them in the RHP.

For **PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED**
On behalf of the Board of Directors
Sd/-
Ritu Jain
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer

Place: Mumbai, Maharashtra
Date: September 04, 2026

PRANAV CONSTRUCTIONS LIMITED is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offer of its Equity Shares and has filed a RHP dated August 31, 2026 with the RoC read with Corrigendum to the RHP dated September 1, 2026. The RHP is made available on the website of the SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in as well as on the website of the BRLMs i.e., Centrum Broking Limited *(as successor to the merchant banking business of Centrum Capital Limited)* at www.centrumbroking.com and PNB Investment Services Limited at www.pnbisl.com, the website of the NSE at www.nseindia.com and the website of the BSE at www.bseindia.com and the website of the Company at www.pranavconstructions.com. Any potential investor should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risks, please see the section ***"Risk Factors"*** beginning on page 18 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP for making any investment decision and must rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer.

The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been, and will not be, registered under the U.S. Securities Act and may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer are being offered and sold only outside the United States in "offshore transactions" as defined in and in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act (**"Regulation S"**) and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur.

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Beverage Cos Step up Bottle Use Amid Shortage of Cans
BRANDS: CREATING DESIRE ▸▸ 9

Finmin Secures $1-billion IFC Funding for MSMEs
ECONOMY: MACRO, MICRO & MORE ▸▸ 13

Foreign Tourist Arrivals Seen Flat This Year
BRANDS: CREATING DESIRE ▸▸ 9

PURE POLITICS

India, China Corps Commanders Meet in Arunachal for 1st Time

India and China held their first meeting at the Corps Commander level in Arunachal Pradesh on Sunday, amid reports of a troop buildup and border tensions along the Line of Actual Control. The talks were held at the Wacha-Damai meeting point on the Indian side of the border. ▸▸ 2

India Calls for Correct J&K and Ladakh Depiction in UN Map ▸▸ 2

AAP on Back Foot in Punjab as Govt Worker Agitation Intensifies

The AAP government in Punjab is facing an intensifying challenge from a politically key constituency – its own employees – five months before assembly polls. The agitation by government staff and pensioners over pending DA arrears, old pension scheme rollout and other demands is gathering steam. **Nidhi Sharma** reports. ▸▸ 3

ET CORNER OFFICE CONVERSATION

Frontier Tech, a New Mega and the Big India Bet

In the first of this special podcast series, Anirban Chowdhury speaks to JP Morgan's global chair of investment banking, Anu Aiyengar, about the deal-making rebound, AI's impact on investment banking and India's case for global capital.

THE ECONOMIC TIMES WORLD LEADERS FORUM

ALL ABOUT AI, DEEPTECH & CHIPS

India Set to Pitch Tech Synergy for Cementing BRICS

Focus is on countering AI monopoly, sharing compute infra and exporting DPI stack

Subhayan Chakraborty

New Delhi: India will push for closer research ties and greater government-to-government partnership across artificial intelligence, advanced computing, quantum technologies and semiconductor materials at the upcoming BRICS summit, officials said. The focus on these frontier technologies comes at a time when nations seek to counter growing AI monopolies and de-risk global semiconductor supply chains.

India is keen to complete three major multilateral projects under its chairmanship of the 11-country bloc.

The global research advanced infrastructure network (GRAIN) initiative will offer researchers from member states federated, or shared, access to high-performance computing systems and supercomputers, an official said. "Work is ongoing to operationalise the science and research repository, a unified digital portal where member nations share datasets and capabilities specifically targeting advanced materials engineering and functional nanostructures," the person added.

Connecting chip design and deeptech startups across members via the proposed Startup Innovation Fund and Incubator Network is another target area. "In all these areas, we have aimed to mirror the success of our domestic policies," another official said. "Other nations are keen to establish frameworks similar to AIkosh — our national, centralised platform for non-personal datasets — and AI models, or our onboarding of over 38,000 high-performance graphics processing units in our common AI compute facility under the IndiaAI Mission."

The event — only the second summit featuring the 10 new partner nations, including Malaysia, Nigeria and Vietnam — will have a major focus on ramping up cooperation in digital payments systems.

www.economictimes.com

Summit Notes

India aims to complete three multilateral projects while it has the chair

AI-led materials discovery targets clean energy, aerospace, electronics

Members showing interest in India's digital public infrastructure

THE AGENDA

- **Resilient global** semiconductor supply chains
- **Digital** payments cooperation
- **Shared** framework for responsible AI
- **AI safety, bias and data** protection prioritised
- **Working groups** drawing up tech work programmes
- **GRAIN initiative will enable** shared supercomputing access
- **Startup fund, incubator** network to connect deeptech firms

INNOPROM EXPO TO BE HELD AHEAD OF BRICS MEET

Moscow Seeks Mfg via Tech Transfer

Russian industrial majors are seeking to expand their presence in India through advanced technology transfers as they look to boost manufacturing under the Make in India initiative. ▸▸ www.economictimes.com

PROFIT BONANZA ON THE CARDS

NSE IPO has a Cover Story with a ₹7,200-cr Headline

Five PSU insurers likely to book bonanza gains on long-term holdings

Big Gains to Cover

Five PSU insurers selling **1.6% of NSE's equity in IPO**

NSE offering 148 m shares, **equivalent to ~6% of equity**

Sale offers PSU insurers major value-unlocking opportunity

Stand to realise over **1,120x** their acquisition cost from shares sold

Current unlisted mkt **prices at ₹1,800 a share**

WHO SELLS WHAT	Million
General Insurance Corp	10.7
New India Assurance	10.4
National Insurance	6.0
United India Insurance	6.0
Oriental Insurance	5.0

Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: Five public sector insurance firms are set for a windfall pegged at about ₹7,200 crore from the sale of 40 million National Stock Exchange shares in the bourse's proposed IPO, according to the draft prospectus, based on an assumed valuation of ₹1,800 a share.

General Insurance Corporation of India will lead the pack, followed by New India Assurance, National Insurance, United India and Oriental Insurance. They acquired the shares for ₹6.8 crore and are poised to book hefty gains in the second quarter from the IPO.

LIC, NSE's largest shareholder with a 10.72%, is not divesting. The five insurers' combined stake — totalling 165 million shares — will fall from about 6.7% to 5.1%.

General Insurance Corp, National Insurance, New India, Oriental Insurance and United India were among the earliest investors in the exchange, which opened in 1994 and is India's biggest by trading volume. The proposed IPO, expected later this month, is entirely an offer for sale of up to 148.91 million shares, which would mean that NSE itself will not receive proceeds from the issue.

The actual sums that the insurers get will depend on the offer price, which has not yet been finalised.

Better Solvency Ratios Seen ▸▸ 8

Grey Mkt Premium for NSE Soars on IPO Nod

The grey market premium for NSE's IPO rose to ₹250-280/share after Sebi approval on Friday, from ₹150-180 in the day, said brokers. **Ravindra Sonavane** reports. ▸▸ 7

INDIANS PREFER NAVRATRI-DIWALI PERIOD FOR PRODUCT UPGRADES

Ecomm Cos See Big Spending Carnival this Festive Season

Online sales may rise 25-29%; qcomm likely to account for 16% share in 2026

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Ecommerce marketplaces and online retailers are expected to sell a record Rs 1.50-1.55 lakh crore worth of goods during this year's festive season sale events, up 25-29% from around Rs 1.20 lakh crore in 2025, according to data from market research firm Datum Intelligence.

The projection of robust growth in gross merchandise value (GMV), which excludes discounts and returns from total sales at online marketplaces, comes when brands are grappling with increasing raw material and packaging costs amid geopolitical uncertainties.

Quick commerce is expected to account for 16%, or Rs 24,000 crore, of festive spending this year, as consumers increasingly shift from planned purchases to instant delivery, show the data shared with ET.

These platforms recorded Rs 14,000 crore of GMV in 2025.

"Almost 46% of sales are expected to happen in the first week of the ecommerce sales. This is, however, lower than last year's first-week share (48%) because we expect sales to be more distributed across channels and events," said Satish Meena, founder of Datum Intelligence.

Smartphones may Top Charts ▸▸ 8

Festive Fireworks

SALES (₹ CR)

Year	Total Online GMV**	Qcommerce GMV**
2023	81,000	
2024	96,000	7,920
2025	1,20,000	14,080
2026*	1,50,000-1,55,000	23,760

*Forecast for Oct 9-Nov 8

**GMV refers to total value of goods sold online over a period

GMV share estimates by category for '26 (%)

Mobile	Lifestyle	Appliances	Electronics	Homeware	Grocery	Books & general merchandise	Personal care
29.8	15.5	13.6	11.6	11.4	9.5	4.9	3.7

Source: Datum Intelligence

AIFs Red-Flag Draft Rules on Foreign Control

Indian private equity and venture capital funds have forewarned the government and financial regulators that changing the definition of 'foreign control' for these local funds could significantly hurt capital inflow, reports **Sugata Ghosh**. Their urgent plea requesting status quo on regulations stems from the draft FEMA (Foreign Investment) Rules. ▸▸ 8

ICAI Mulls PE Investment in Non-audit Biz

The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India is weighing allowing PE investment in non-audit business of accounting firms with a clear split between the assurance and non-assurance practices, its president Prasanna Kumar D said. An ICAI committee working on the proposal is studying global models. **Twesh Mishra** reports. ▸▸ 13

B2B Cos Using Fresh Capital to Repay Debt

India's VC-backed B2B companies are increasingly having to manage debt amassed during their high-growth years, with Zetwerk setting aside most of its IPO fresh issue to repay borrowings, Infra. Market refinancing debt as leverage rises, and Udaan restructuring creditor claims after a bond default. **Nikhil Patwardhan** reports. ▸▸ 10

NEW CHIEF TO ADDRESS OPERATIONAL GAPS

Gebremariam Takes Control at Air India

New CEO will pilot airline in high-pressure zone with eye on safety, profitability & reliability

Kala Vijayraghavan & Arindam Majumder

Mumbai | New Delhi: Tewolde Gebremariam will take charge of Air India on Monday, replacing former chief executive Campbell Wilson at a time when the airline is under pressure to improve safety and operational reliability and stem losses, people aware of the development said.

While the former chief of Ethiopian Airlines will not be officially designated CEO and accountable manager yet because his security clearance is pending, Air India chairman N Chandrasekaran is expected to introduce him to employees at a town hall on Monday, marking the beginning of operational charge, the people said. Gebremariam's security clearance is expected by month-end.

Air India did not comment.

Chandrasekaran and former Air India chairman and managing director Pradeep Singh Kharola, who have been guiding Gebremariam since he joined the Tata airline early last month, will continue to work closely with him in the initial few months, officials close to the matter said.

www.economictimes.com

LARGEST SPACETECH FUNDING IN INDIA

Pixxel Bags $100 million from Temasek, Others

Co eyes venture debt for satellite mfg, constellation biz

Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: Satellite imaging startup Pixxel raised $100 million (around ₹945 crore) in the largest funding round in India's spacetech sector, co-led by Singapore sovereign wealth fund Temasek and UK-based space investor Seraphim.

Indian asset management firm 360 One Asset and Seoul-based IMM Investment also participated in the funding, along with existing backers Radical Ventures and GrowX Ventures as the sector attracts a rush of risk capital.

People familiar with the matter said Pixxel was likely valued at $400-450 million (₹3,780-4,250 crore). The company didn't disclose the terms.

The investment was in fresh shares, with the entire proceeds going to the seven-year-old startup, founder and chief executive Awais Ahmed told ET. The company is also exploring raising venture debt, as it looks to scale its satellite manufacturing and constellation businesses, he said.

Pixxel will likely need another funding round to hit the $1 billion valuation, Ahmed said, but declined to disclose the firm's current valuation.

Clients in Farm, Oil & Gas Sectors ▸▸ 8

Sky is the Limit

Company	Total funding ($ million)
Pixxel	195
Skyroot Aerospace	155
Agnikul Cosmos	76
Digantara	67
Bellatrix Aerospace	34
Ethereal Exploration Guild (EtherealX)	28

Source: Tracxn

Content Creators Chart New Path to Monetisation

Tighter margins in commissioning models push producers toward YouTube to build & own IP, commercialise it

Javed Farooqui

Mumbai: India's content business is entering a new phase as tightening margins across television and streaming push creators and production houses to look beyond traditional commissioning models and build and monetise their own intellectual property, with YouTube emerging as a key destination for premium, long-form originals.

Ekta Kapoor's Balaji Telefilms partnered with YouTube to launch five long-form fiction shows, following the video-sharing platform's collaboration with Aamir Khan on the 2025 film *Sitaare Zameen Par*. YouTube is also in talks with other production houses for exclusive programming. Producers see the model as a way to experiment with formats while retaining IP and monetisation rights, signalling a broader shift in India's content economy. Applause Entertainment and Swastik Productions also launched YouTube-led offerings.

Balaji Telefilms' tieup with YouTube is an early example of this shift. The companies are launching five premium original shows spanning 200 episodes, including *Haq Se Season 2*, *Phir Pyar Ki Yeh Kahani Suno* and *Kehne Ko Humsafar Hai* Season 4, with other projects under development.

Addressing a Gap ▸▸ 8

Changing Tack

75 million+ connected TV viewers above 18 years of age

YouTube is becoming a new home for TV-scale content as CTV expands

207 million CTV viewers up 3x since 2022

Connected TV accelerating move to digital distribution

11 million Pay TV subscriptions lost in 2025

Creators are increasingly bypassing traditional commissioning routes

IP retention better than one-off commissions

As content margins tighten, producers want to
- Own asset
- Build audience
- Monetise across multiple windows

Source: YouTube, The Trade Desk-WPP Media-Ormax, FICCI-EY

AMID REPORTS OF TROOP BUILDUP & LAC TENSIONS

India-China Corps Commanders Meet in Arunachal for First Time

Practice for such senior military leadership to hold talks started after 2020 Ladakh standoff

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: India and China held their first meeting at the Corps Commander level in Arunachal Pradesh on Sunday, amid reports of a troop buildup and border tensions along the Line of Actual Control (LAC).

The talks were held at the Wacha-Damai border meeting point near LAC. The two military commanders met on the Indian side of the border, at the point that is located close to Kibithu. The Indian side was led by Lt Gen Girish Kalia, the 3 Corps Commander.

Talks held at Wacha-Damai border meeting point near LAC

Corps Commander-level talks have never been held in Arunachal in the past. The practice for such senior military leadership to meet started after the 2020 standoff in Ladakh which included a bloody clash that left soldiers dead on both sides.

Sr officers meet on Indian side of border, at the point that is located close to Kibithu

The meeting also comes after boundary delimitation and border management talks between national security adviser Ajit Doval and Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi in Beijing on August 26.

During the top-level talks, it was decided that besides Ladakh, two additional meeting points would be established for Corps Commander-level talks between the two sides, including the one in Arunachal that was used on Sunday. It was also decided at the talks to set up two additional channels for border military hotlines in the eastern (Arunachal) and middle (Uttarakhand) sectors.

While regular meetings do take place between Indian and Chinese troops deployed at forward positions all along the border to sort out local issues such as perceived transgressions, wandering of people or cattle across the border and patrolling disagreements, talks at such senior levels are held to discuss larger and pressing issues.

It may be noted that Army chief Gen Dhiraj Seth recently visited the 3 Corps headquarters at Rangapahar to take an assessment of the ground situation as well as preparedness of troops deployed on the Chinese frontier.

Hydropower project site in Arunachal's Lower Dibang Valley district

PTI

AFTER VOTING FOR UNGA RESOLUTION AIMED AT CORRECTING WORLD MAP

UN-Backed World Map Must Depict J&K and Ladakh As Per India's Official Map: MEA

'Any inaccurate or misleading depiction is unacceptable'

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: India on Sunday said a UN-initiated proposed world map must depict Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh in accordance with the country's official map, and any "inaccurate" or "misleading" representation will be unacceptable.

The statement came two days after it voted in favour of a UN General Assembly resolution, aimed at correcting the world map to promote a more accurate representation of continental landmasses.

The resolution titled — Correct the Map: Rebalancing Global Cartographic Representation and Promoting Equitable Representation of the World's Regions, Particularly Africa — was adopted on September 4.

External affairs ministry spokesman Randhir Jaiswal said India highlighted that the resolution does not constitute endorsement of any specific map, projection or depiction of national boundaries.

"India voted in favour of the resolution and also made an explanation of vote stressing on the underlying principle of promoting equal-area cartographic representation," he said.

Jaiswal was responding to a media query on the issue.

MEA: Our position on sovereignty and territorial integrity is clear, consistent and non-negotiable

"India's sovereign territory, including the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, must be depicted in accordance with India's official map. Any inaccurate or misleading depiction is unacceptable," he said.

"Our position on India's sovereignty and territorial integrity is clear, consistent and non-negotiable," he noted. Jaiswal said the purpose of the UN resolution is "to encourage the use of equal-area map projections that preserve the relative sizes of continental landmasses."

'More Threats from Provinces Than Pak Neighbours'

CM OF PAK'S PUNJAB

LAHORE: Pakistan's Punjab CM Maryam Nawaz said her province faces a greater security threat from its adjoining provinces than from neighbouring countries. "Terrorism enters Punjab through its provincial borders. The unfortunate thing is that the threat Punjab, a province of 130 million, faces comes less from my neighbouring countries and more from my neighbouring provinces," CM Maryam Nawaz said at an event in Lahore. – PTI

DECISIONS TAKEN AT DOVAL-WANG YI BORDER MANAGEMENT TALKS IN BEIJING

Besides Ladakh, two additional meeting points will be established for Corps Commander-level talks, including the one in Arunachal; India and China to set up two additional channels for border military hotlines in the eastern (Arunachal) and middle (Uttarakhand) sectors

At a relief camp

AFP

1,344 NEPAL FLASH FLOODS DEATH TOLL

Rescuers Continue Search; Identifying Dead A Challenge

Press Trust Of India

Kathmandu: Rescuers in Nepal continued searching for those missing, as authorities faced continuing difficulties in identifying the dead, 11 days after devastating floods struck large parts of the country.

The death toll stood at 1,344, while **nearly 5,000 people, including 589 foreign nationals, remained missing**, according to Nepal Police. Around 13,400 people have been rescued so far.

At least 43 people were killed on the Chinese side, while more than 500 people remained missing in Tibet, according to Chinese media reports.

Nepal Police collecting DNA samples from relatives of missing people

Identifying the dead has emerged as a major challenge. The police have said that bodies carried far from the disaster sites and those that remained in water and mud have made identification particularly difficult.

Nepal Police has begun collecting DNA samples from relatives of missing people to help identify unclaimed bodies and human remains. Relatives can provide samples through the Nepal Police Hospital in Kathmandu or their nearest district police office. Over 1,000 unidentified bodies have been buried after DNA samples were collected to facilitate their identification in future, officials said.

Nepali Woman Found Alive Days After Family Began Mourning Rites

BETRAWATI: Believing she had perished, the family of Chandika Kumari Shrestha started the ritual of mourning the elderly woman's death. Ten days later, rescuers found her alive inside her collapsed home in Betrawati village, where she survived in a narrow pocket of air amid water and mud. –REUTERS

China Opens Up Gyirong to Media

GYIRONG: One of the most haunting reminders of the flash floods is a video showing a massive wall of mud, rocks and debris engulfing a well-built immigration post in seconds. China on Sunday, for the first time, opened up its devastated Gyirong County in Tibet, the site of the destroyed immigration post, to PTI and select foreign media.

Core disaster-hit area at Gyirong Port in Shigatse

AP

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

1-Day Judicial Custody for Swatantra Bhardwaj

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Sunday remanded Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj to one-day judicial custody in connection with the alleged assault on the father of a student activist during a protest at Jantar Mantar, among other charges. Bhardwaj was produced through video-conferencing before duty magistrate Anjali Singh, who sent him to judicial custody. On Saturday, Bhardwaj was produced at the residence of additional sessions judge Saurabh Pratap Singh Laler, who allowed the Delhi Police's plea seeking one-day custodial interrogation of the accused. Bhardwaj was shown his viral videos and questioned by multiple police teams during his remand, officials said on Sunday. He was asked more than 100 questions during his remand, a police source said, adding that while he answered some of those, he did not respond to several others. **The sources said Bhardwaj showed no sign of remorse during his questioning.** – PTI

PM-SHRI Call After Cabinet Panel Report: Kerala Min

KOZHIKODE: General education minister N Shamsudheen on Sunday said the Kerala government would take a decision on implementing the PM-SHRI scheme only after receiving the report of a special Cabinet sub-committee examining the matter. The previous LDF government had signed an agreement with the Centre to implement the Prime Minister's Schools for Rising India scheme in the state. However, its implementation was later put on hold following opposition from within the ruling front. After coming to power, the UDF government, which had opposed the scheme, appointed a special Cabinet sub-committee to examine the matter. Responding to reporters' queries, Shamsudheen said there were **differences between the Centre and the state over implementation of the scheme.** "The previous government signed it and gave an assurance to the Centre that we would implement it. That is the background before us. So, we are considering what should be done in such a situation," he said. – PTI

AFTER THE COMPLETION OF SPECIAL INTENSIVE REVISION

Manipur Voter Rolls: Women Continue to Outnumber Men

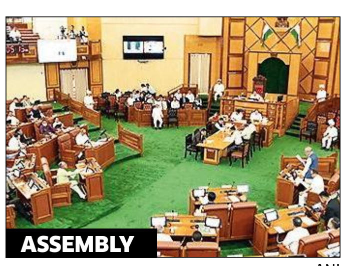
'Gender ratio of 1,056 is significantly higher than national average'

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: In Manipur's final electoral rolls released on Sunday, women voters continued to outnumber men after the completion of the special intensive revision throughout the state.

Chief electoral officer Arun Kumar Sinha said in Imphal that with July 1, 2026, as the qualifying date, Manipur has a total of 19,60,620 registered voters, comprising 10,06,962 women, 9,53,350 men, and 308 third-gender electors. The gender ratio of 1,056 in the final electoral rolls is significantly higher than the national average, he said.

The final electoral rolls of all 60 assembly constituencies of Manipur were published by the concerned electoral registration officers.



ASSEMBLY

ANI

TOTAL: 19,60,620

19,60,620 registered voters – 10,06,962 women, 9,53,350 men & 308 3rd-gender electors

UKNA CAMP DESTROYED IN ARMY-ASSAM RIFLES JOINT OPERATION

2 Militants Killed, 2 Others Injured in Manipur Gunfight

United Kuki National Army not a signatory to Suspension of Ops pact

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: Two militants belonging to the United Kuki National Army (UKNA) were killed and two others injured in a gunfight with a joint team of the Army and Assam Rifles in Manipur's Churachandpur district.

A senior official said the operation was launched at Phaibong village in Henglep subdivision as there was intelligence that UKNA members were camping in the area. "Security forces began surveillance over the camp. UKNA cadres resorted to indiscriminate firing."

Assam Rifles stated on X, "In a joint operation based on specific intelligence input on 29 Aug 2026 night in Phaibong village, Henglep sub-division, Churachandpur, forces established surveillance over a UKNA camp. Commenced tactical closing in at 5 am on September 2."

The camp was destroyed following the search operation. UKNA is not a signatory to the Suspension of Operations (SoO) agreement involving the Centre, the Manipur government and several Kuki and Zomi armed groups.

IEDs neutralised in Jiribam – ANI

Himalaya is All Eyes and Ears

Every disaster raises a simple but pertinent question: Who is to blame for the cataclysm? If the terrible event is Himalayan, then the scale of accusation should also be ginormous. Otherwise, the charge will not reach the intended audience. Whenever a politician levels an allegation, the target is not the one who is held responsible for the tribulations, but the poor voter — whose strength lies in his finger.

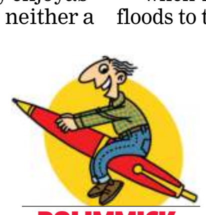
A politician knows that finger-pointing is an easier game than lifting a finger. Hence, if one cannot understand and stop Himalayan blunders, then one can effortlessly make Himalayan allegations. Mind it, this game is truly enjoyable. Why? Because it costs neither a cent nor reputation. The onus is on the victim to prove (disprove) charges. What a play!

One can only speculate what thoughts occupied the Nepalese foreign minister's mind — Gen Zers, Millennials or Gen Xers — when he linked the deadly flash floods to the actions of other countries. Was he thinking about the three as one unit or the whispers of criticism at home? Or was he just thinking aloud?

Whatever it was, the mountains, the rocks, the trees, the glaciers and the rivers should consider themselves lucky that the blame-gamers spared them. Nobody asked why they went down the slope with such force, and no one dared to demand compensation from them.

The Himalaya — abode (alaya) of snow (him) — is all eyes and ears to everything happening within its empire. Intruders must watch out!

Pravir Kumar



POLIMMICK

DELHI BUILDING COLLAPSE

5 Students Dead, Many Trapped

NEW DELHI: An around 30-year-old five-storey building housing a boys' hostel in a congested bylane in Satya Niketan near Delhi University's South Campus collapsed on Sunday afternoon, leaving five students dead and many trapped. Locals claimed that there could be between 30 and 50 people in the building at the time. Authorities, however, gave no figure for those trapped. Repair work was underway in the basement of the five-floor structure, which was used as a paying guest accommodation, when it collapsed at around 1.30 pm, a senior officer said. Several vehicles also came under the rubble as the structure crashed. The AIIMS trauma centre received 10 patients, of whom four were brought dead, and one later succumbed to injuries. Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday ordered a magisterial probe into the incident. – PTI

PHOTO JUNCTION

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AAP on Back Foot in Punjab as State Govt Employees Escalate Stir

Nidhi Sharma

New Delhi: Five months before Punjab assembly elections, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government is facing an intensifying challenge from an unlikely but politically crucial constituency — its own employees.

The statewide agitation by government employees and pensioners over pending Dearness Allowance (DA) arrears, implementation of the Old Pension Scheme (OPS) and other service-related demands is gathering momentum.

Punjab government employees have decided to intensify their protests over the next two months, with the joint coordination committee (JCC) of employees and pensioners giving a call to gherao residences of seven ministers on September 11 and 12.

This will be followed by a statewide maha rally on October 10 at Sangrur, which is chief minister Bhagwant Mann's home turf.

"The government is employing delaying tactics in implementing the Punjab and Haryana HC order (on pending DA payment). They want to use funds to roll out freebies but not give employees their due," alleged Sukhchain Singh Khehra, convenor of Sanjha Mulazam Manch, an umbrella organisation of government employee unions.

IN JOBS, LEGISLATURE

Siddu Seeks 75% Quota for Dalits, OBCs & Minorities

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Congress Working Committee (CWC) member and former Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah on Sunday called for 75% reservation for Dalits, backward classes and minorities in government jobs and the Lok Sabha and state Assembly, based on their population share.

Reservation based on caste population was necessary to build an equitable society, he said speaking at the silver jubilee celebrations of the Karnataka State Backward Castes Federation in Bengaluru.

"Everyone should get reservation according to their caste numbers. Only then can an equal society be built," he said.

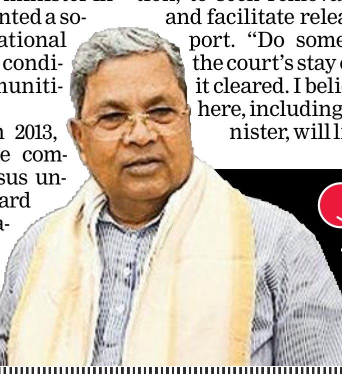
Ahinda, an acronym for minorities, OBCs and Dalits, has been a key constituency associated with Siddaramaiah's political base.

Siddaramaiah said the lack of caste-wise data had weakened the state's case in courts on reservation-related matters. Recalling his tenure as deputy chief minister in 1996, he said he had wanted a socioeconomic and educational survey to assess the condition of different communities.

As chief minister in 2013, Siddaramaiah said, he commissioned a caste census under the then backward classes commission headed by H Kantharaj. The report was subsequently rejected. He said another report prepared under the backward classes commission during his current tenure as chief minister has also not been made public because of a court order.

Siddaramaiah said he had asked KM Ramachandrappa, president of the Backward Castes Federation, to seek removal of the stay and facilitate release of the report. "Do something about the court's stay order and get it cleared. I believe everyone here, including the chief minister, will listen to me. It must be implemented," he said.

Siddaramaiah said he belonged to a backward caste and had spent his political career fighting social inequality and seeking equal opportunities for disadvantaged communities. He said he would continue to support the cause of social justice and fight against caste-based inequality. "I will be with you and fight until you get justice, until you get equal opportunities, until the caste system is abolished in society," Siddaramaiah said.



Everyone should get reservation according to their caste numbers. Only then can an equal society be built

SIDDARAMAIAH
CWC Member & ex-CM of Karnataka

CENSUS 2027

Revise Caste Data Format: Stalin

CHENNAI: DMK president and former Tamil Nadu chief minister MK Stalin on Sunday urged the Union government to revise the proposed method for collecting caste information during Census 2027, warning that an open-ended system could produce unreliable data and defeat the purpose of the exercise. Stalin objected to the plan that would allow enumerators to manually enter caste names without choosing them from a standardised list, contending that variations in spelling, local terminology and the classification of communities could create inconsistencies on a massive scale. **—IANS**

CLOSE AIDE OF CM

Jharkhand Edu Minister Sudivya Kumar Dies of Cardiac Arrest

Kumar also held portfolios of tourism, arts & culture, & sports & youth affairs

Ranchi: Jharkhand higher andtechnical education minister Sudivya Kumar died of cardiac arrest early Sunday, officials said. Kumar, 56, was admitted to a private hospital in his hometown Giridih around 2.30 am, and doctors declared him dead around 4 am, they said.

Kumar, 56, is survived by his wife Shweta Sharma, two daughters and a son

The JMM legislator also held portfolios of urban development, tourism, arts and culture, and sports and youth affairs.

He is survived by his wife Shweta Sharma, two daughters and a son.

A close aide of chief minister Hemant Soren, he played a key role in managing several political crises for the JMM-led government, including last month's students' protests in Ranchi.

Soren, Assembly Speaker Rabindra Nath Mahato, and Congress leader Rajesh Thakur were among the leaders who expressed grief over Kumar's death. — PTI

ALLEGED DIVERSION AND LAYERING OF FUNDS

ED Moves to Seek Cayman Data in TMC Fund Probe

Around ₹160 cr moved from TMC accounts to Carewell Aviation & related entity during Apr 2023-Jun 2026: ED

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) is in the process of reaching out to authorities in the Cayman Islands through a letter rogatory (LR) to obtain details of funds and financial transactions involving a Cayman Islands-based entity that has come under scrutiny in its money laundering investigation into the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and aviation company Carewell Aviation, people in the know told **ET**.

The proposed judicial request is aimed at obtaining information that is not readily available to ED sleuths, including details of the Cayman-based entity, its beneficial owners, bank accounts and the source and ultimate destination of funds allegedly transferred through the offshore jurisdiction, people quoted above added. The development assumes significance as the ED has already identified a Cayman Islands link in the financing of an Agusta helicopter acquired by a Carewell group entity. According to the agency's findings made public in July, an unsecured loan of US$1.7 million, or around ₹14-16 crore at the prevailing exchange rate, was arranged in 2023 from a Cayman Islands-based entity for the purchase of the helicopter.

The federal agency will now seek documentary and financial records from the jurisdiction to establish the complete money trail and determine the actual beneficial purpose of the offshore transaction.

According to people quoted above, the probe aims to identify persons or entities that controlled or benefited from the Cayman-based company, the circumstances under which the loan was sanctioned, the source of funds, the originating accounts, and the manner in which money was transferred into the aviation-financing structure. TMC has strongly denied all allegations of money laundering and financial irregularities alleging that the agency's actions are politically motivated. The LR request could also seek banking records, incorporation and ownership documents, transaction statements, correspondence relating to the loan and information concerning any onward movement of funds, sources added.

The Cayman Islands component forms part of a wider ED investigation into the alleged diversion and layering of TMC funds through Carewell Aviation. The agency has alleged that around ₹160 crore was transferred from TMC bank accounts to Carewell Aviation and a related entity, largely between April 2023 and June 2026. Carewell routed ₹82.96 crore to another newly-incorporated related entity for acquisition of an Embraer Legacy 600 aircraft and an Agusta helicopter. The ED has alleged that the aircraft and helicopter, acquired using funds originating from the party's corpus, were subsequently leased back to TMC. It has described the arrangement as "dubious" and said the investigation was aimed at determining the actual beneficial purpose of the transactions.

KC-390 Can Meet India's Transport Needs, Says Embraer

Aircraft offers right mix of capability, capacity & cost under MoD's 60-aircraft tender: Brazilian aerospace major

Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury

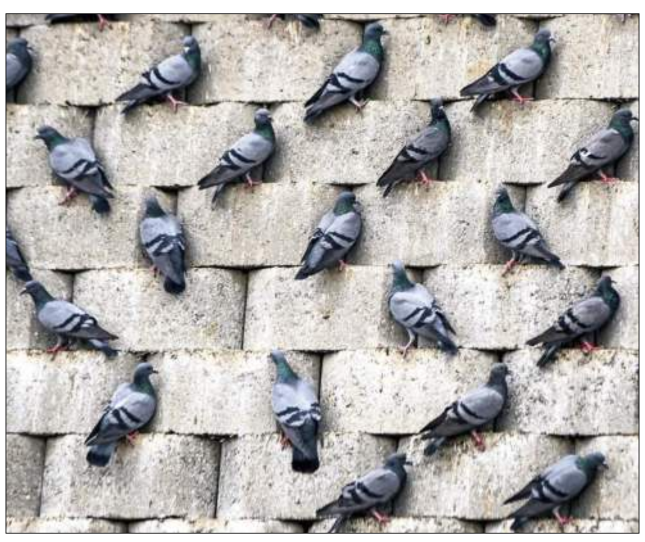
New Delhi: Brazilian aerospace major Embraer is confident its KC-390 Millennium can meet all the requirements under the ministry of defence's (MoD) request for proposals issued in August for 60 medium transport aircraft, Frederico Lemos, chief commercial officer at Embraer Defence & Security, told **ET**.

Lemos, who was in Delhi recently for discussions with the MoD, said the KC-390 Millennium offers the best option for India in terms of capacity, capabilities and cost, and can meet the requirements of the Indian military.

With two jet engines and the ability to fly at an altitude of 35,000-36,000 feet, the KC-390 Millennium stands out, Lemos said. The aircraft can also operate across India's varied terrain and topography, he said. "This is the most modern technology available in any military transport aircraft as on date and will serve India's needs for the next few decades," Lemos said. Embraer has partnered with Mahindra Group to manufacture the KC-390 Millennium and establish local maintenance, repair and overhaul capabilities in India if the aircraft is selected by the IAF. If Embraer wins the order, India would become the only country outside Brazil to produce the aircraft.

Embraer plans to build an ecosystem around the programme, starting with the export of a few aircraft in fly-away condition and moving to technology transfer, training of Indian specialists and deployment of Brazilian specialists. The company said this would strengthen the Make in India initiative.

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY



PERFECTLY PERCHED Pigeons perch on a wall amid hazy weather in Ahmedabad on Sunday

B'desh Hindu Leader Gets Bail

Dhaka: Bangladesh's High Court on Sunday granted bail to jailed Hindu rights leader Chinmoy Krishna Das in two more cases, but his release is unlikely as he faces charges in other cases, local media reported. Das was granted bail in two cases last month involving vandalism, attack and obstruction of government duty. Das was arrested in November 2024 on sedition charges for allegedly disrespecting the national flag. —PTI

B'day Cake Lands 6 Cops in a Soup

Maharajganj (UP): Six policemen posted at a police outpost here were suspended after a video surfaced online purportedly showing a man with no links to the chowki cutting a birthday cake inside premises. They have been suspended for alleged indiscipline and negligence of duty, police said. The video showed that when the man was cutting the cake, policemen, including the sub-inspector, were nearby. —PTI

Shah Unveils 3-Yr Roadmap for Drug-free India

Rahul Tripathi

New Delhi: Union home minister Amit Shah on Sunday said that a three-year roadmap — from July 2026 to July 2029 — has been prepared to ensure a drug-free India. "A decision has been taken to achieve all targets in a time-bound manner. We are advancing the fight against drugs as one of the biggest national battles of the country. To make this mission successful, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) and all state governments are working together," Shah said at a press conference in Goa.

He said that 2026 to 2029 has been declared as 'mission mode'. Timelines have been fixed, different ministries have been made accountable, measurable outcomes have been decided, and quarterly reviews along with outcome-based accountability will be ensured. He said this roadmap is based on four pillars. First: intelligence and operation-based enforcement; second: precursor and synthetic drugs control; third: demand and harm reduction; and fourth: capacity building and coordination.

Shah added, "All these pillars together will prepare dossiers of drug kingpins, coordinate on backward-forward linkages, and tighten the noose through financial investigation of every case involving commercial quantities. BSF, CISF, Indian Coast Guard, Customs and DRI will carry out risk-based profiling and instal scanners at land borders, ports, airports and cargo for sharper surveillance. The CBI, Ministry of External Affairs and Interpol will bring back the fugitives. The Enforcement Directorate, Financial Intelligence Unit and the banking system will track the money trail."

Shah said narcotics is a crime that can destroy future generations. He said earnings from narcotics are also used for terrorism.

PROMINENT BOLLYWOOD PERSONALITIES EXPECTED TO ATTEND 4-DAY EVENT

135 Films, 40 Countries: J&K Hosts First Int'l Film Festival From Today

Our effort is to reassert our connection with Bollywood & films: DIPR joint director Bukhari

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: The J&K government is hosting a first-of-its-kind four-day international film festival in Srinagar from Monday, during which around 135 local, national and international films will be screened and participants from several countries are expected to attend.

REPRESENTATIVE PHOTO

Preparations for the inaugural IFFJK-2026 themed 'Rang-e-Cinema' (colours of cinema), will be hosted at SKICC in Srinagar while some programmes will be held in Jammu, the famous ski resort of Gulmarg and Srinagar's only multiplex, Inox. Around 135 films from 40 countries will be featured at the festival and prominent names from Bollywood are expected to be present. Officials informed that Ramesh Sippy of Sholay fame, famous singer Palak Muchhal and Pankaj Tripathi would be among the guests. International filmmakers are expected from Spain, Japan, Germany, Mexico, Jordan, France and Canada.

"Our guests have started arriving... We feel that this event should feature local cultural themes, including flowers and their natural beauty as part of our decoration," said Shreya Singhal, director of DIPR. Besides films, the festival will include panel discussions, masterclasses and conversations about films and film making. "Our effort is to reassert our connection with Bollywood and films. This is a well-intentioned effort of the government to promote film tourism," said Shahnawaz Bukhari, joint director DIPR.

Gig Worker Social Security likely to Bring Uneven Burden

PTI

New Delhi: As India moves to operationalise social security contributions for gig and platform workers, a seemingly small design choice could carry outsized consequences for different segments of the platform economy: whether aggregators should contribute based on annual turnover or on a percentage of individual worker payouts.

A contribution mechanism for gig-worker social security that is linked to individual transactions rather than an aggregator's turnover could create a sharply uneven financial burden across the platform economy, hitting businesses built on high transaction volumes but low-ticket sizes especially hard, analysts and industry sources said.

Contribution mechanism linked to individual transactions could create a sharply uneven financial burden across platforms

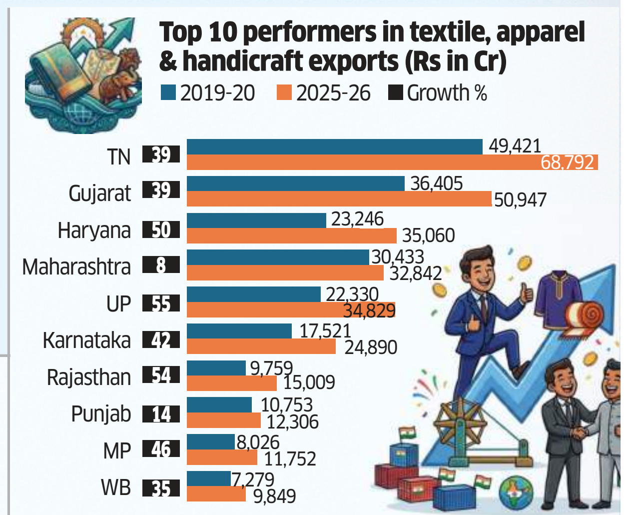
The Code on Social Security, 2020 requires aggregators to contribute to a Social Security Fund for gig and platform workers. Under the rules, a gig worker becomes eligible for benefits after 90 days of engagement with a single aggregator, or 120 days across multiple aggregators, in a financial year. Aggregators are required to assess and deposit their contributions annually.

The Ministry of Labour and Employment is pushing to standardise contributions on a per-transaction or payout-linked basis. That choice of methodology matters because it can produce materially different outcomes across platform businesses, depending on their transaction volumes, ticket sizes, business models and overall turnover. A comparison of the two approaches shows a payout-linked mechanism can place a heavier burden on high-frequency businesses such as ride-hailing, both at the aggregate platform level and in terms of the contribution generated from individual workers' earnings, analysts said.

ET GRAPHICS

THE WHOLE NINE YARDS: India's exports of textiles and apparel, including handicrafts, registered a compound annual growth rate of 4.5% between 2019-20 and 2025-26, increasing from ₹2.49 lakh crore to ₹3.25 lakh crore

No Dispute on Growth Here: It's 4.5%



Top ten textile & garment exporting districts, including handicrafts, during 2025-26. Export Value (Rs in Cr)

		38,677 TIRUPPUR
21,095 GAUTAM BUDDHA NAGAR	16,205 BENGALURU URBAN	15,104 GURUGRAM
12,479 MUMBAI	11,448 PANIPAT	10,478 SURAT
9,366 AHMEDABAD	7,099 LUDHIANA	6,321 THANE

No of MSMEs in textile sector: **36 lakh** as on March 31, 2026

No of MSMEs registered from April 1, 2023 to March 31, 2026: **24.73 lakh**

MSMEs shut in 3 years: **7,894** (0.32% of registered)

16 FTAs including India-UK are in force & FTA with EU concluded. India has signed an FTA with New Zealand. These agreements provide an opportunity for the Indian textiles and apparel sector an opportunity to increase exports and diversify markets. These measures have helped the competitiveness of MSMEs.

Q India's garments sector is looking better with correction in US tariffs, UK CETA and Europe free trade agreement in the works. Overall, the negative overhang is gone. We will do much better if manufacturers move into newer areas of the country where land and labour are cheaper and available in plenty.

SIVA GANAPATHI, Managing Director, Gokaldas Exports

Text: K.R. Balasubramanyam

Source: MoS (Textiles) Pabitra Margherita's reply to Lok Sabha

Fake Rabies Jab Batch Wasn't Exported: Immunologicals

Teena Thacker

New Delhi: Indian Immunologicals has confirmed that no part of the counterfeit Abhayrab rabies vaccine batch seized from an unlicensed residential premises in Delhi was exported to any other country, reassuring international health authorities who had previously raised alerts over fake batches of the widely used vaccine reaching travellers.

The confirmation came after the Delhi Police arrested four people, following the seizure of fake Abhayrab vials carrying Batch No. KE25012 from Delhi.

The drug regulatory authority affirmed that they, along with the law enforcement agencies, are maintaining strict and continuous surveillance against the illegal manufacture, distribution and supply of misbranded and spurious drugs, with coordinated action being undertaken to identify and disrupt unauthorised drug supply networks and safeguard the quality and safety of medicines available to the public.

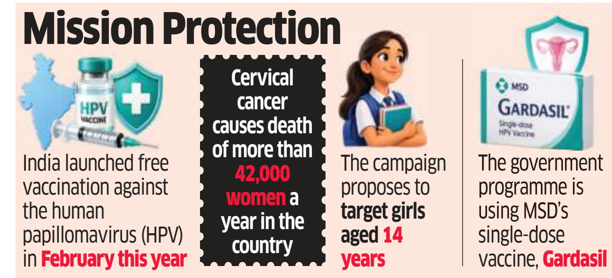
"The Crime Branch of Delhi Police has been undertaking continuous surveillance to identify criminal activities related to the manufacture and distribution of misbranded and spurious drugs. The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) works in close coordination with Delhi Police and other enforcement agencies whenever leads relating to such criminal activity emerge," it said in a notice.

Through a communication dated 27 August 2026, the DCGI directed the State Drugs Controllers to alert their inspectorate staff and maintain strict vigilance over the movement, distribution and availability of the vaccine batch.

ALLEGES VIOLATION OF BODILY AUTONOMY, TRANSPARENCY & ACCOUNTABILITY

PIL Challenges Constitutionality of HPV Vaccination Programme

Aims to suspend rollout in schools until legally compliant consent protocol is established



Teena Thacker

New Delhi: A public interest litigation (PIL) has been filed before the Supreme Court challenging the manner in which India's nationwide Human Papillomavirus Vaccination (HPV) Programme is being implemented, alleging that it violates constitutional guarantees of informed consent, bodily autonomy, transparency, and accountability.

The PIL has sought for suspension of the school-based component of the HPV vaccination programme until a legally compliant informed consent protocol is established. It has been filed by the Universal Health Organisation and is likely to be heard this week.

It seeks judicial intervention to ensure that India's nationwide HPV programme is implemented in a manner consistent with the constitutional guarantees of informed consent, bodily autonomy, transparency and accountability. It challenges the legality and constitutional validity of the nationwide HPV programme as presently implemented.

It alleges the programme has been introduced without a lawful informed-consent framework, adequate disclosure of risks and available alternatives, a transparent adverse-event reporting mechanism and any vaccine injury compensation scheme, thereby violating the constitutional rights of parents and minor children under Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution.

According to the petition, the present implementation suffers from serious constitutional and procedural deficiencies, including the absence of a legally compliant informed consent mechanism, inadequate disclosure of risks and alternatives to parents, lack of publicly accessible.

The petition also refers to the Parliamentary Standing Committee's 72nd Report of 2013, which examined alleged irregularities in an earlier HPV demonstration project conducted by PATH, arguing that similar concerns regarding informed consent must not be allowed to recur during the present nationwide rollout.

It has also sought the constitution of an independent expert committee to examine epidemiological data, vaccine safety, consent practices, and available alternatives; the establishment of a real-time public AEFI surveillance dashboard, the notification of a national vaccine injury compensation scheme; and the formulation of a comprehensive vaccine consent framework governing vaccination of minors in India.

Women Make Up Less Than 10% of CPSE Workforce: Data

PTI

New Delhi: Even as the political blame game over the delay in implementing the one-third quota for women in the legislature continues, experts and policymakers rue another glass ceiling that remains unbroken—the abysmally low proportion of women employees in government-run enterprises. The latest available government data shows that women constitute less than 10% of the workforce in central public sector enterprises (CPSEs), and not even one in 10 manage to reach a supervisory role.

While still a far cry from adequate representation, in the private sector, nearly one-fourth of women hold managerial positions. Their proportion goes up to about one-third when it comes to entry-level roles, as per various surveys.

Overall, the female LFPR (Labour Force Participation Rate) in the country stands at little over 34%, though it has fallen from 40% at the end of financial year 2024-25, according to the government data.

The latest Public Enterprises Survey showed that women constituted 9.8% of total employees in CPSEs at the end of FY 2024-25. The number decreased to 76,685 in FY2024-25 from 77,625 in FY2023-24. This number has remained below 10% for several years.

The survey, released by the government, further said 32.4% of total women in CPSEs were present at managerial/executive level, while only 8.7% were at supervisory level and 58.9% in worker categories. The women's representation at the supervisory level has fallen to 9% in 2023-24 from 10.08% in 2022-23.

YSR Congress Party MP Dr Gumma Thanuja Rani said the low representation of women in government-owned enterprises was a matter of concern.

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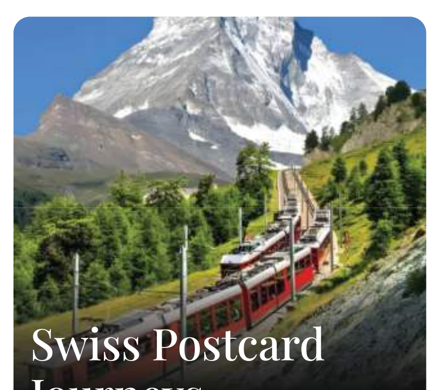

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Ahead of the Curve in Managing Inflation

RBI will drain excess liquidity to stop overheating

Headline inflation has been ticking up in recent months, and is above the 4% RBI target. Price pressures are largely from volatile food and fuel components due to an erratic monsoon and oil supply disruption from West Asia. Wholesale price inflation is approaching 10% as global supply chain disruptions feed into input costs. But core inflation, minus food and fuel, is relatively stable and within RBI's comfort zone. Interest rate and liquidity management tend to look through episodic spikes in food and fuel inflation, unless these feed into a generalised phenomenon. RBI projects inflation for 2026-27 at 5%, with a peak in Q3 within its 6% tolerance band. The stance of RBI's monetary policy committee will be informed by resilient economic growth as well as the unfolding inflation scenario.

A surge in dollar inflows through the special FCNR(B) scheme shouldn't add to inflationary pressure. RBI actively manages liquidity to accommodate forex flows. It will drain excess liquidity to prevent the economy from overheating. The excess liquidity with banks on account of bulging dollar deposits will be drained through enhanced sales of gilts by RBI. Stabilising effects of the dollar inflow on the rupee also contribute to lowering of imported inflation. This is well within RBI's playbook after having conducted a series of dollar mopping-up exercises over the decades. Sterilising domestic liquidity from these surges is a part of that exercise. The premature close of the special FCNR(B) scheme indicates the vigil the central bank is keeping on liquidity.

RBI is unlikely to be behind the curve in managing inflation, after having had to explain its inability to control it within the mandated band following the Ukraine conflict. If India maintains its economic momentum, there is a likelihood the interest rate upcycle could be advanced. However, on current indications, growth is losing steam as inflation remains within manageable limits. RBI is known for trying to minimise the growth sacrifice as it maintains price stability.

An Old Geopolitical Distortion Corrected

The UN's decision to adopt 'Equal Earth projection' is an important corrective. For centuries, the Mercator projection — designed for 16th-c. navigation — has warped the world's proportions, inflating Europe and North America while shrinking Africa, Latin America and South Asia. Greenland, absurdly, has loomed as large as Africa, though Africa is 14× bigger. Such distortions aren't innocent — they reinforce colonial hierarchies, embedding a world view in which the 'global south' appears peripheral, diminished and less consequential.

The Equal Earth projection, developed in 2018, restores proportionality. Africa regains its true immensity, Latin America stretches to its rightful breadth, and Europe shrinks to scale.

By urging its adoption in education, media and official use, the UN is correcting a centuries-long misrepresentation that has seeped into politics, economics and culture. Representation matters. Just as parliaments, films and textbooks shape identity, maps are mirrors of self-perception. A continent consistently drawn smaller than it is risks internalising inferiority, much like the old, symbolically-loaded description of Africa as the 'dark continent'. Perception bleeds into aid, investment and diplomacy.

Such symbolism is profound. In classrooms, the new map will recalibrate how billions imagine the world. Over time, such subtle shifts in perception can influence policy, trade and respect. The US' lone opposition — Serbia, Estonia, Georgia, Lithuania, Moldova and Ukraine abstained — was telling. Washington argued the UN should focus on 'pressing issues'. But maps are not neutral. To dismiss reform is to defend distortion. Equal Earth projection reminds us that every act of representation shapes dignity and power.

JUST IN JEST

When Penguin chickened out, someone else turned the right page

Harper Plays It Smartly by the Book

Publishing, like politics, thrives on making bets. Penguin Random House India made the wrong bet by overthinking the consequences of publishing a book written by someone no longer in the establishment — or, more importantly, someone it thought the establishment doesn't much care for. After the publishing house with a flightless bird logo dumped Sonia Gandhi's forthcoming memoir, 'Belonging: A Journey of Love' — for reasons we all kind of know — HarperCollins India picked up what every non-illiterate Sonia supporter and critic alike would want to pick up in November. Here, we have to commend HarperCollins for rushing in where the Antarctic bird was too petrified to tread. Probable result: Harper laughing its way to the bank.

Frankly, the book promises everything: romance in Cambridge, saris in Delhi, an assassination in the garden, and the perennial question of how an Italian girl became the longest-serving president of the Indian National Congress. It should be part-soap opera, part-statecraft, and wholly irresistible. Sonia G may no longer be in the thick of things. But her story is, well in non-publishing circles is called, irresistible. This is one publisher understanding that the only constituency that matters is the cash register. Penguin RH may have been loyal to the crown. But Harper has been admirably loyal to the bottom line.

To meet the 100 GW target, clarify the risks private investors will bear and what they will earn

Money Clear About Nuclear

Ravi Madhavan, Tom Nguyen & K Ramanathan

Fundamental economics

As consultations on the draft SHANTI (Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India) rules wrap up, the focus must shift to financing, the single factor that determines whether reactors get built. The core hurdles are familiar: massive upfront capital, decade-long timelines, and complex supply chain risks spanning fuel enrichment, manufacturing and regulatory approvals.

Because capital costs dominate the final price of electricity, budget overruns are make-or-break. As setbacks from Westinghouse's bankruptcy to delays at Britain's 3.2 GW nuclear power station Hinkley Point C demonstrate, the central threat isn't legal liability but cost overruns landing on balance sheets that cannot absorb them. The decisive question, then, is simple: who carries the financial hit when costs inevitably surge?

Here, the contracting problem sharpens. Nobody can write a complete contract covering a 12-yr build, using first-of-a-kind technology. Too many contingencies, too long a horizon, too little precedent. So, the question reduces to which party has both the balance sheet to absorb overruns, and the horizon to wait for returns. That party is the residual risk holder, and naming it is the heart of financial design.

For six decades, India's answer has been that overruns will be absorbed by the exchequer rather than by investors. This worked — 24 operable reactors, indigenous PHWR (pressurised heavy-water reactor) capability, Kalpakkam fast breeder. But a single risk absorber that is also fiscally constrained produces slow, sequential deployment — roughly 9 GW in six decades.

The central threat isn't legal liability, but cost overruns landing on balance sheets that cannot absorb them. So, who carries the financial hit when costs inevitably surge?

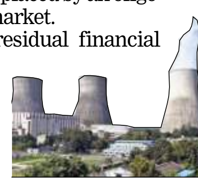
Reaching the 100 GW target by 2047 will require an estimated ₹25 lakh cr. The treasury cannot absorb the cost overruns for an expansion of this scale on its own. Private participation is, therefore, not just about bringing in modern technology or operational efficiency, but also about bringing in extra corporate balance sheets to share the financial risk. The crucial, unanswered question is precisely which of those risks private investors will be expected to carry.

Read the Bharat Small Reactor (BSR) tender carefully. Private firms were asked to finance and build 220 MW units under Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited's (NPCIL) control and supervision. Private capital holds the asset risk, the state retains operational control.

For a lender, this is a difficult structure because project finance depends on step-in rights, and a lender cannot foreclose on a reactor it is not licensed to operate. Security, therefore, falls back on sponsor balance sheets with full recourse. Two things follow:

❶ Eligible field narrows to few conglomerates able to carry that recourse. So, a state monopoly is replaced by an oligopoly, rather than a market.

❷ Party bearing residual financial risk has limited control over operational decisions that generate it. The risk does not disappear. It's priced into tariff demands and lands on discoms and consumers.



Reaching the 100 GW target by 2047 needs ₹25 lakh cr. Private participation isn't just about bringing in modern tech or operational efficiency, but also extra corporate balance sheets to share financial risk

Instruments for financing reactors are well-understood: regulated asset base treatment, which lets an owner service debt during construction, credit enhancement for discoms entering multi-decade PPAs and green bond eligibility. As of now, India's sovereign green bond framework explicitly excludes nuclear power. It would be desirable to have this amended by the finance ministry.

The capital stack is also not separate from technology and market choices. India is running 3 tracks with incompatible risk profiles under one framework. PHWR is proven technology and genuinely bankable, but constrained by the ownership-control mismatch. Indigenous small modular reactors (SMRs), with ₹20,000 cr allocated and 5 units targeted by 2033, have no operating reference plant. Large imported reactors depend on export credit agencies and come with geopolitical exposure.

Market choice matters, too. A grid-connected reactor's financing rests on discom credit. A captive reactor serving industrial heat or data centre load has an investment-grade offtaker that happens to be its own sponsor, dissolving the counterparty problem, provided the operational control issue is addressed. It is the closest Indian analogue to what is unlocking American SMRs.

India cannot build its nuclear strategy in a bubble, as rising global demand is driving up capital costs and straining a limited supply chain for heavy forgings, pressure vessels and certified welders. Next-generation SMRs face additional bottlenecks, with many designs relying on high-assay low-enriched uranium (HALEU), a fuel severely constrained in both availability and production capacity. Also, because international suppliers prioritise bulk, multi-reactor orders, piecemeal financing will push Indian projects to the back of global order books.

To overcome these barriers and attract investors, India needs targeted policy support. This includes viability gap grants to cover initial shortfalls, extended loan terms, preferential tax treatments, and an official green taxonomy to unlock sustainable global capital. Finally, temporary cost-plus tariffs must be used to guarantee fair developer returns and buffer against unexpected cost spikes.

India has strong, proven capabilities across the entire nuclear value chain. Moving to the next level requires a clear financing strategy. Evaluating any risk-informed model comes down to two questions:

❶ What exact risks are private investors being asked to absorb?

❷ What financial reward will they demand in return?

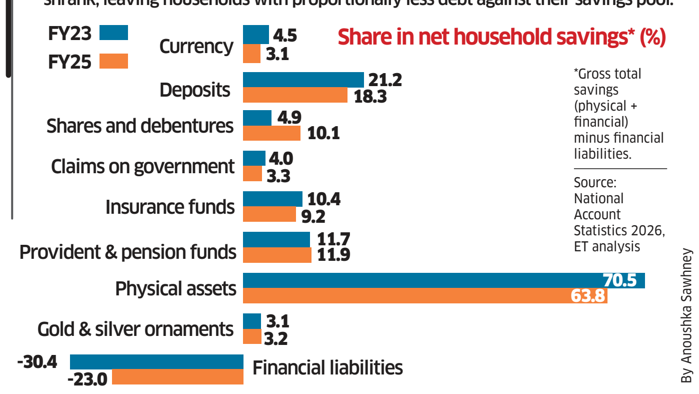
Madhavan is professor of strategic management, University of Pittsburgh School of Business, US, Nguyen is former executive vice-president, Westinghouse, and Ramanathan is distinguished fellow emeritus, electricity and renewables division, TERI

ChatGPT SHAIRI OF THE DAY

There was a naaraaz phupha who'd frown,
At every wedding or lunch in town.
'The salt's too much!' he'd declare,
'Why's nobody here?' with a glare,
Then leave — because the economy WASN'T down!

THE GREAT HOUSEHOLD SAVINGS SHIFT

India's households together owned ₹68.5 lakh crore in net savings at the end of FY25, growing 14% a year since FY23, data released by the government last week showed. Physical assets (such as land) remain the largest single component, but their share fell sharply from 70.5% to 63.8%, as households moved towards financial instruments instead. Shares and debentures more than doubled their share of the mix (10.1%), driven by a three times jump in the mutual funds component. Financial liabilities also shrank, leaving households with proportionally less debt against their savings pool.



Share in net household savings* (%)

	FY23	FY25
Currency	4.5	3.1
Deposits	21.2	18.3
Shares and debentures	4.9	10.1
Claims on government	4.0	3.3
Insurance funds	10.4	9.2
Provident & pension funds	11.7	11.9
Physical assets	70.5	63.8
Gold & silver ornaments	3.1	3.2
Financial liabilities	-30.4	-23.0

*Gross total savings (physical + financial) minus financial liabilities.

Source: National Account Statistics 2026, ET analysis

By Anoushka Sawhney

MEME'S THE WORD

Summer of Summitry

Seema Sirohi

Summitry can serve many ends, especially when crowd cover becomes useful to signal a policy shift. The SCO gathering in Kyrgyzstan was one such. It gave India an opportunity to register opposition to the US-Israel war on Iran in the company of others.

Did it constitute course correction, or was it the usual playing of all sides to minimise damage? Was it heartfelt to the extent anything can be in politics? Or was geopolitics forcing Delhi to create certain optics and imagery?

It's not clear, but Delhi periodically finds it necessary to burnish its 'global south credentials' while pursuing other goals, especially when the cost is low and dividend reasonable. This was a good time to create some distance from Washington and its needless war. Consider the toll the Iran war has taken on India's economy, trade, fertiliser imports and lives of seafarers caught in the crossfire.

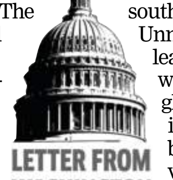
In July, the US bombed Iran's Chabahar port, destroying a civilian control tower and endangering India's strategic investment of $120 mn and more. Some saw the bombing as Washington thumbing its nose at Delhi. The port was meant to provide India access to Afghanistan and Central Asia. But its future now is unknown. Given the current difficulties in India's relations with the US, and Israel's indefensible actions in the region, the war against Iran seems less and less like a project worth defending.

So far, there's no outburst in the White House like last year when an SCO summit photo of Modi, Putin and Xi triggered Trump. The Trump regime has been briefed on both SCO and the upcoming BRICS summit in Delhi to explain the context. But none of that guarantees presidential calm. Fortunately, there's no talk by US analysts of Russia-India-China, or RIC (remember that?), coming together.

The Bishkek Declaration didn't name the US or Israel, but reiterated 'SCO's previously stated position condemning military strikes' on Iran. It called for a political and diplomatic solution. The statement then linked 'peace and stability in the Middle East' to a comprehensive and just settlement of the Palestinian question, an impossible idea in today's Israel.

Realists will dismiss the statement as 'full of sound and fury, signifying nothing', while others will see the need to reiterate principles if only to keep hope alive. India signed the statement, joining all 10 SCO member states, including Russia, China, Pakistan, Iran and others. In June last year, India had stayed aloof from an SCO statement issued in the immediate aftermath of US-Israel attacks on Iran's nuclear facilities. Delhi did go on to sign the Tianjin Declaration two-and-a-half months later that condemned the US and Israel for 'gross violation of international law'. By then, it had experienced enough of Trump's second avatar.

India's signature in Bishkek is part of the continuum that some see as 'progress' in correcting the pro-US tilt. Whether summit declarations matter in the grand scheme of things is a different question altogether. But, sometimes, they do help in blunting diplomatic opprobrium.



LETTER FROM WASHINGTON

India's decision is rooted in several realities, not the least of which is its self-declared leadership of the 'global south'. As Russia expert Nandan Unnikrishnan said, 'If we claim leadership of the global south, we have to act like a leader of the global south. Perceptions are important.' The most recent blow to the image was Modi's visit to Israel just before the war started. India came to be seen by many as part of the US-Israel-UAE axis.

An additional reason for course correction is the upcoming BRICS summit where India needs a joint statement acceptable to all. Some SCO members are also in BRICS, making for easier diplomatic give-and-take. With Xi, Putin and Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian attending, it will be interesting to see how much understanding is shown for the host's common minimum programme.

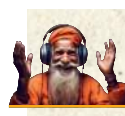
India would definitely not want the final declaration to be anti-West. China definitely would — it can feel the reins of the world in its hands. China looms large over both SCO and BRICS, dwarfing others and relentlessly pushing its foreign policy goals. Russia and India see it in real time. As for the US, its China policy depends on the day and issue at hand.

It's not a secret that Indian foreign policy is currently faced with questions for which it doesn't have ready answers, especially with regard to the US in its current 'destroyer' phase. Debates on whether India's pro-US tilt harmed other relationships (Russia, China) are intense.

There's understanding that answers (technology, investment, machinery) won't come from China. Denial is Beijing's first strategy. Russia is stretched thin by its war on Ukraine. Here's the big dilemma: India knows China and Russia are not the solution to its developmental problems. But how much can it trust the Americans?

How not to get shanghaied by the US

MELODY FOR MONDAY



Hey Bulldog

The Beatles

Among the Beatles' late-period curios, 'Hey Bulldog' from their 1969 soundtrack album, Yellow Submarine, stands out as a snarling paradox: a chunky rock riff welded to lyrics embedded to philosophy. John Lennon, in one of his most underrated vocal performances, growls through a piano-driven groove that is all muscle and swagger. Yet, beneath the bark lie mind-probing questions of identity, perception and truth.

'Some kind of happiness is measured out in miles,' Lennon sings, a line that could sit comfortably in a Kierkegaard essay. The lyric teeters between nonsense and profundity. The bulldog itself becomes a metaphor — part-comic mascot, part-existential cipher — snarling at the absurdities of modern life.

Musically, the track is pure grit. Paul McCartney's bass locks into George Harrison's guitar, while Lennon's piano pounds with percussive urgency. The band sounds loose, playful, yet ferocious, as if revelling in the tension between garage rock and sly wit. The outro, with Lennon and McCartney barking and laughing, undercuts the seriousness with anarchic joy.

'Hey Bulldog' is both joke and meditation: a song that proves philosophy need not be cloaked in solemnity. Sometimes, it can ride a riff, grin through its teeth, and bite hard.

THE SPEAKING TREE

That Elusive Horizon

NARAYANI GANESH

When you are at sea, literally, say, on a ship or sailboat, you see the horizon. You feel just a few knots more and you can reach out and touch it. But the closer you think you get to the horizon, the farther away it seems. The earth is spherical and the elusive horizon is but a natural fact. Yet, you want to reach for it. Perhaps the thought that you can arrive there keeps you going, metaphorically. You know you can never get all your chores done, you know you may never complete your plan to declutter your home and workplace, your mind space as well as your computer and phone spaces, but you keep trying, anyway. Even if the pace is slow sometimes and at other times, reasonably fast. Never mind.

So long as you are making the effort to do any of the above things, all is good. Something is better than nothing. The pile of pre-digital days' unread newspaper and magazine cuttings — waiting to be sorted — are still yellowing in that old suitcase. Clothes that don't fit any more still occupy valuable storage space. Your laptop is groaning with too many files. Your mind is crowded with a zillion thoughts that vie for prime space. Relax. It will get done, one thing at a time. Keep your goals small and doable. Small steps, big results, is what I keep reminding myself. Even if I happen to die without achieving all of the above, so be it. At least, I tried — to lessen the burden of those who will have to clean up after me.

Chat Room

Pavement Not For Walking...

Apropos 'Why Footpaths in This Country Are Not Paved with the Best of Intentions' by Palash Krishna Mehrotra (Sep 6), the Supreme Court judgment has moved the footpath from the margins of municipal housekeeping to the centre of constitutional rights. So, the next task for the government must be to move it from judgment to habit, budget, design and enforcement, as a nation battling diabetes, hypertension, obesity, stress and road deaths cannot treat walking as an afterthought. The proportion of encroachment-free footpaths must become a barometer of whether elected governments value citizens' fundamental rights in every ward and on every major road.

Pradeep Kumar
Surat

...We're Corrupt To an Asafault

This refers to the Edit, 'Curing Our Broken, Disturbing Roads' (Sep 5). Deplorable condition of roads in India can also be traced to the strong nexus between the contracting agencies and executing authorities, supported by protecting politicians and supervising bureaucracy. Factors like preference for the lowest bidder, the 'build-damage-rebuild at higher cost' cycle, political influence, poor inspection and public apathy, despite repetitive inconvenience, harm and deaths from poor road maintenance, have added to the malaise. Since a system is as good as the persons who operate it, it is for consideration whether AI-based machine control (AI-MC) will be able to rein in the erring human interface.

Y G Chouksey
Pune

If It's Broken, We Consider Missold

Apropos 'Curb Misselling, Not Agents' by Sriram Kalyanaraman (Sep 5), mis-selling of financial products damages public confidence and unfairly affects customers who may not understand complex policies. Penalising agents alone, however, will not address the structural incentives behind the problem. Insurers and banks must be held responsible for unrealistic sales targets, inadequate disclosures and misleading assurances. Customers should receive a clear summary of charges, exclusions and surrender conditions before committing money. Regulators can strengthen audit systems and impose swift penalties for repeated violations. Agents also need better training and professional standards.

S M Jeeva
Chennai

Letters to the editor may be addressed to
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SMART INVESTING
RBI's Liquidity Test may Set Future Course

A BULLISH FEELING August demat additions hit 3.27 million as IPO cheer and strong small- and mid-caps revive retail interest; unique investors estimated at around 135 million

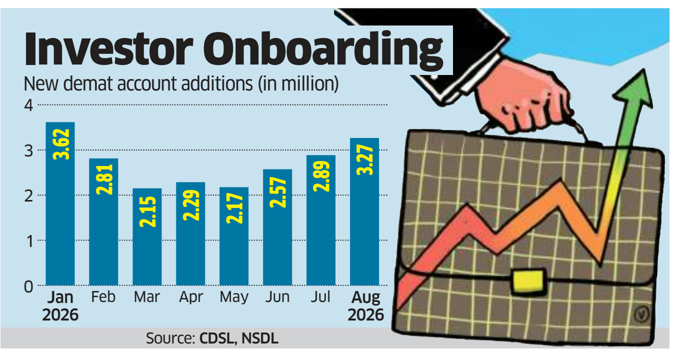
India Chases IPO Gold, Demat Additions Hit a 7-Month High

Ravindra Sonavane

Mumbai: New demat account additions rose to a seven-month high in August, marking the third consecutive month of growth after a prolonged period of moderation between January 2025 and May 2026, as robust IPO activity drew more investors to the markets.

NSDL and CDSL together added nearly 3.27 million demat accounts in August, the highest monthly addition since January 2026. The total number of demat accounts stood at 237.7 million at the end of the month.

The figure does not represent the number of unique investors, as individuals can hold multiple demat accounts. The number of unique investors is estimated at around 135 million.



Source: CDSL, NSDL

"Buoyancy in IPO markets is one of the reasons for the sharp jump in new demat accounts. Strong small- and midcaps have also raised investor return expectations from IPO debuts," said Sriram Velayudhan, senior VP, IIFL Capital Services.

The pickup came amid weakness in the benchmark indices, with the Sensex falling 1.5% and the Nifty declining 1.2% in August. However, segments of the market that tend to see stronger retail participation remained buoyant. The BSE MidCap 150 gained 1.6%, the BSE SmallCap 250 rose 2.4% and the BSE Microcap 250 jumped 6.2% during the month.

Robust primary market activity was a key factor driving new account additions, experts said. August was the busiest month for IPO and offer-for-sale (OFS) activity in 2026, with 23 IPOs raising ₹22,448 crore and two OFS transactions raising ₹31,660 crore.

With Jio and NSE expected to launch their IPOs in the coming months, market participants expect the pace of demat additions to pick up further.

NSE Grey Market Premium Soars on Sebi's IPO Approval

GMP rises from ₹180 to ₹280; Listing expected by Sept-end

Ravindra Sonavane

Mumbai: The capital market regulator's approval for National Stock Exchange's much-awaited initial public offering has set the unofficial grey market abuzz. The grey market premium (GMP), the amount investors are willing to pay over the expected IPO issue price before listing, jumped to ₹250-280 per share soon after the regulatory nod on Friday evening, from around ₹150-180 earlier in the day, according to grey market brokers.

The company has yet to announce the IPO price or date, but traders expect the issue to hit the market towards the end of September. In the unlisted market, NSE shares were trading at around ₹1,975 apiece on Friday.

Market Math

Estimated NSE IPO size: ₹**30,000 crore**

Implied Market cap: ₹**5-5.25 lakh crore**

Unlisted market price: ₹**1,975 apiece** (Friday)

2026 performance: Shares traded flat in unlisted market

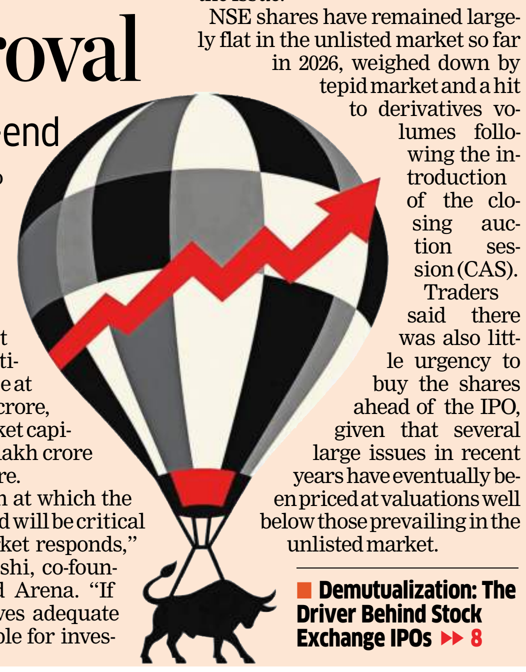
The unlisted price is the price at which a company's existing shares change hands before listing, while the GMP is the premium investors are willing to pay over the IPO price, or expected issue price, for shares in the run-up to the listing.

Grey market participants estimate the IPO size at around ₹30,000 crore, implying a market capitalisation of ₹5 lakh crore to ₹5.25 lakh crore.

"The valuation at which the offering is priced will be critical to how the market responds," said Manan Doshi, co-founder of Unlisted Arena. "If the pricing leaves adequate value on the table for investors, it could significantly enhance investor participation and create strong positive sentiment around the issue."

NSE shares have remained largely flat in the unlisted market so far in 2026, weighed down by tepid market and a hit to derivatives volumes following the introduction of the closing auction session (CAS).

Traders said there was also little urgency to buy the shares ahead of the IPO, given that several large issues in recent years have eventually been priced at valuations well below those prevailing in the unlisted market.



Demutualization: The Driver Behind Stock Exchange IPOs ▸▸ 8

12 MAINBOARD, 4 SME ISSUES LINE UP THIS WEEK

Fresh Offer Flow to Help Cos Raise Over ₹7,000 crore

Primary Market This Week (Figures in ₹cr)

Mainboard IPOs	Opening	Closing	Issue Amount
Pranav Constructions	07-Sep-26	09-Sep-26	351.0
Kanohar Electricals	08-Sep-26	10-Sep-26	1,055.7
Prasol Chemicals	08-Sep-26	10-Sep-26	500.0
Glass Wall Systems (India)	08-Sep-26	10-Sep-26	427.9
Asset Reconstruction (India)	09-Sep-26	11-Sep-26	733.0
Rentomojo	09-Sep-26	11-Sep-26	1,255.6
Karamtara Engineering	09-Sep-26	11-Sep-26	875.0
LCC Projects	09-Sep-26	11-Sep-26	427.1
Steamhouse India	09-Sep-26	11-Sep-26	414.0
Manipal Payment & Identity	09-Sep-26	11-Sep-26	805.0
Veegaland Developers	10-Sep-26	15-Sep-26	210.0
Manika Plastech	11-Sep-26	16-Sep-26	NA
Total			**7,054.3**
SME IPOs			
Apana Logistics	07-Sep-26	09-Sep-26	32.4
Amtech Esters	09-Sep-26	11-Sep-26	17.0
Vinod Texworld	09-Sep-26	11-Sep-26	40.7
Infrax Renewable	09-Sep-26	11-Sep-26	45.9
Total			**136.0**

Source: NSE, BSE

Our Bureau

Mumbai: India's primary market is set for yet another busy week, with 16 companies, including 12 mainboard and four SMEs, looking to raise more than ₹7,190 crore as they seek to ride the ongoing IPO wave.

The mainboard IPOs lined up for the week from September 7 to 11 are Pranav Constructions, Glass Wall Systems India, Prasol Chemicals, Kanohar Electricals, Manipal Payment & Identity Solutions, Steamhouse India, LCC Projects, Karamtara Engineering, Rentomojo, Asset Reconstruction Co India, Veegaland Developers and Manika Plastech.

In the SME segment, Apana Logistics, Infrax Renewable, Vinod Texworld and Amtech Esters will launch their IPOs.

AUGUST MOMENTUM

IPO fundraising also remained robust in August, with 23 mainboard issues raising around ₹22,456 crore

IPO fundraising has remained robust so far in September, with 14 mainboard issues raising around ₹7,640 crore. This follows a strong August, when 23 mainboard IPOs raised around ₹22,456 crore. In the SME segment, seven IPOs have raised ₹260 crore so far in September, compared with 23 issues that raised around ₹1,159 crore in August.

WEALTH MANAGEMENT

What Makes Independent Advisers So Rare in India

Kayezad E Adajania

Every investor eventually hits the same wall: the SIP is running, the goals are vague, questions pile up on how much to save and where to put it. Most Indians turn to someone who sells a mutual fund and, in the process, tells them which one to buy. Very few pay a fee to someone whose only job is to plan the whole picture, with no product to sell.

Two Mumbai-based professionals who left the mutual fund industry around the same time show why that gap persists. Nikhil Kamat spent two decadesat DSP Mutual Fund before setting up his own distribution business this July, targeting the retail investor most advisers ignore. Himanshu Pandya lost his job at Franklin Templeton in 2020 and became a fee-only Registered Investment Adviser (RIA), charging clients directly instead of earning commissions.

The numbers tell the scarcity story. Sebi's website shows 1,039 RIAs held a valid licence as of end-August, against 3.41 lakh mutual fund distributors registered with AMFI as of March 2026. Individual RIAs serve just 7,754 clients, a 0.41% share of all clients advised, managing assets under advice of ₹9,847 crore.

The dispute comes down to one word: advice. Distributors are allowed to guide clients on goal-based investing, so long as it is tied to a mutual fund. RIAs say, the moment a distributor discusses a client's retirement corpus or education fund by name, that's financial planning, whatever product wrapper it comes in, and ought to carry the compliance as an RIA does.

For More Pick Up Today's The Economic Times wealth

30-DAY VRRR Strong participation today would signal some success in the central bank's liquidity management efforts

RBI's Liquidity Test may Set Future Course

Joel Rebello

Mumbai: The outcome of the 30-day variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auction to absorb ₹7 lakh crore will be a key determinant of how the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) manages the record ₹10.5 lakh crore of liquidity generated by the FCNR(B) scheme.

Market participants said the central bank may have to deploy additional tools, such as a sell-buy dollar swaps and bond sales through open market operations (OMOs), along with more VRRRs to sterilise the large liquidity injection.

Strong participation in the VRRR auction to be conducted on Monday would indicate that the RBI's effort to maintain neutral liquidity has achieved some success, they said.

"The easiest thing for the RBI to do is to allow all the $36 billion forward dollar positions to mature within a year," said Emkay Global economist Madhavi Arora. "Extinguishing those positions using the current dollar inflows will also help absorb the rupee liquidity generated because of the FCNR inflows."

Arora expects the central bank to use a blend of tools, including bond sales through OMOs and sell-buy dollar swaps to suck out rupees from the banking system.

Market participants said the bank may need dollar swaps and bond sales alongside more VRRRs to sterilise the liquidity

She said the RBI's liquidity management has been called upon because the total inflows from the special schemes at $136 billion is significantly more than the initially expected $80-90 billion. This means about $50 billion (about ₹5 lakh crore) of extra liquidity is generated, she noted.

OMO of bonds is not a straightforward option for the RBI as extra supply of bonds could push yields higher and make the government borrowing programme more expensive.

Arora said the central bank may choose to sell bonds in the three to five-year maturity, targeting the exact tenure for which liquidity is generated through the FCNR scheme.

Bankers said more VRRR auctions will also be needed to ensure that excess liquidity is managed for the medium term.

"We could see more auctions depending on how this one goes. The RBI has previously done a 90-day VRRR auction, which cannot be ruled out in the current circumstance," said Alok Singh, head treasury at CSB Bank. "Overall, it is fair to assume that more reverse repo auctions are likely."

For the first time, the RBI has given participants in Monday's auction an option for the premature withdrawal of the amount lent in the VRRR.

Bankers said the option to take back liquidity lent is because liquidity could also tighten because of the advance tax outflows on September 15.

"Though liquidity is at record levels, it is not evenly spread because the FCNR inflows have come mostly from the large banks and a couple of foreign banks," a senior executive at a public sector bank said. "This amount of liquidity, with only may be top 10 banks, means that it cannot be deployed efficiently."

Indeed, even as short term rates and overnight call market rates have plummeted, the other end of the curve has not moved much. For example, one-year certificates of deposits are still quoting above 7.50%.

Bankers said the RBI will have to be nimble footed to ensure it deals with this liquidity glut because it comes at a time when global rates are going up and local inflation is likely to only increase.

Addressing a Gap

►► From Page 1

The slate will be produced in 4K and made available globally.

Kapoor will lead the creative vision and retain ownership of the IP, while YouTube will provide global distribution and monetisation pathways through advertising and brand deals.

The partnership comes as producers increasingly look to own and build IPs rather than produce shows purely on a commissioned basis. Kapoor said the move addresses a gap between linear television and premium subscription platforms.

"Television is now catering to the older, immobile family viewer and the subscription-led apps cater to a very niche audience and a very high-paying audience which young Indians maybe sometimes can't afford," Kapoor told ET. Building fiction while owning the IP is the "need of the hour" and gives her greater risk-taking ability in storytelling, she said.

YouTube's growing presence on connected television is central to that opportunity. The platform has more than 75 million adults watching YouTube on connected TV in India, according to YouTube India managing director Gunjan Soni. The scale of connected TV is creating opportunities well beyond a single content category, Soni said.

"Connected TVs themselves have scale. When you already have 75 million-plus adults watching on the larger screen, it is creating opportunities for different players across different verticals," Soni said.

Audiences increasingly want the "best of both worlds" — on-demand viewing and premium content on larger screens, she said. Her comments point to connected TV becoming an increasingly important distribution layer for premium, long-form content.

The shift is also visible among established television personalities. Shekhar Suman, who previously hosted the talk show Movers and Shakers, has taken his new show, Shekhar Tonite, to YouTube.

Clients in Farm, Oil & Gas Sectors

►► From Page 1

Skyroot became India's first spacetech unicorn earlier this year after a $60 million fundraising that valued it at $1.1 billion.

The latest round took Pixxel's total funding to $195 million, making it the most-funded Indian space tech startup, ahead of Skyroot Aerospace that has so far raised $155 million.

Founded in 2019 by Ahmed and Kshitij Khandelwal during their time at BITS Pilani, Pixxel started out to build a commercial constellation of hyperspectral satellites that could capture more detailed information about the Earth than conventional satellite imagery.

A July 2026 independent valuation report by CA Mohit Jhunjhunwala, a registered valuer for securities and financial assets, reviewed by ET, estimated the fiscal 2026 revenue of Pixxelspace India, the corporate entity, at ₹98.15 crore, with a net loss of ₹96.62 crore. Revenue is projected to fall to ₹65.7 crore in FY27, while the net loss is expected to widen to ₹176.7 crore, according to the report, which projects revenue to rise to ₹195 crore in FY28. Pixxel also runs a US entity, the financials in the valuation report are for Pixxelspace India.

Hyperspectral imaging is a type of satellite imaging that records data across many more wavelengths of light than a normal camera. Pixxel currently caters to customers in agriculture, oil and gas, and mining. Government demand forms another important segment.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

TECHNICAL VIEWS

Nifty's Four-Week Drift Tests the Next Support

Nifty slipped for the fourth straight week, closing at 23,897.7 and breaching the 24,000 support. Analysts caution that a sustained break below 23,800 could open the door to 23,500–23,600, while a decisive move above 24,200 is needed to confirm a bullish reversal.

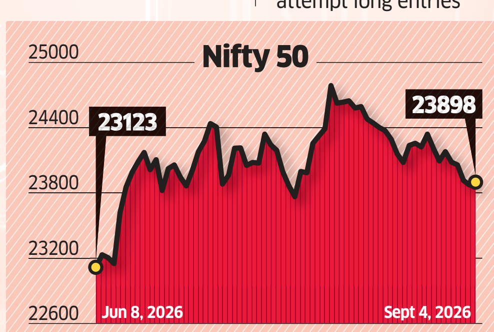
RAJESH PALVIYA
HEAD OF RESEARCH,
AXIS SECURITIES

Nifty Strategy: The suggested strategy for the weekly September 8 expiry is a market-neutral Long Straddle, designed to benefit from increased volatility. This involves buying one lot each of the 23,950 Call and 23,950 Put, with premiums of 89 and 80 respectively, making a total outflow of ₹11,000. As a debit spread, the maximum loss is limited to the premium paid if Nifty closes at 23,950 on expiry. However, if Nifty closes above 24,120 or below 23,780 and sustains beyond either breakeven level, profits can be unlimited.

TOP STOCKS PICKS

APL Apollo Tubes: Buy | CMP: ₹2,250 | Target: ₹2,330–2,350 | Stop loss: ₹2,170
The stock signalled a robust breakout, surging 4.4% on Friday and forming a bullish engulfing pattern. RSI has crossed 60, and prices are trading above the 20- and 50-day EMAs, confirming momentum.

One 97 Communications (Paytm): Buy | CMP: ₹1,659 | Target: ₹1,800–1,830 | Stop loss: ₹1,590
The stock has cleared its 5-day moving average and is consolidating between ₹1,600–1,700. The weekly MACD remains bullish, while RSI at 60 supports strength above the 20- and 50-day EMAs.



ANAND JAMES
CHIEF MARKET STRATEGIST,
GEOJIT INVESTMENTS

Trading Strategy: Bank Nifty has been forming continuation patterns since April 2026, followed by a "cup & handle" formation, suggesting potential for a large upside move. However, recent attempts have faced rejection. While not inclined towards outright selling, buying is recommended only on dips to 56,400, the downside marker. Aggressive traders may attempt long entries near the lower Bollinger Band at 57,109. Upside bets remain capped at 58,000, aligning with recent peaks and the upper Bollinger Band.

TOP STOCKS PICKS

Hindustan Oil Exploration Company: Buy | CMP: ₹185 | Target: ₹205 | Stop loss: ₹167
The stock has broken out of a prolonged consolidation, supported by strong volumes. Weekly MACD has delivered a bullish crossover, while RSI at 64 reflects healthy buying interest. Narrowing distance between the 20- and 100-week MAs further supports upside prospects.

Engineers India: Buy | CMP: ₹279 | Target: ₹325 | Stop loss: ₹258
The stock has broken out of a bullish wedge pattern, supported by strong volumes. The weekly MACD has turned bullish, and RSI at 67 shows robust buying strength.

ROHAN SHAH
TECHNICAL ANALYST,
ASIT C. MEHTA INVESTMENT INTERMEDIATES

Trading Strategy: Nifty has declined for the fourth straight week since CAS implementation, but the lower-timeframe structure remains positive with higher highs and higher lows intact. The setup favours buying Nifty Futures for an upside target of 24,300–24,500, with a stop loss below 23,500.

TOP STOCKS PICKS

SBI Cards and Payment Services: Buy | CMP: ₹658 | Target: ₹735 | Stop loss: ₹620
The stock is consolidating near the neckline of an Inverse Head and Shoulders pattern. Constructive price action and supportive volumes increase the likelihood of a bullish breakout.

PI Industries: Buy | CMP: ₹2,465 | Target: ₹2,750 | Stop loss: ₹2,325
The stock has triggered a bullish AB=CD Harmonic Pattern, with the PRZ around 2,400–2,450. A multi-month demand zone at the same level strengthens the reversal setup.

AIFs Seek Status Quo as 'Foreign Control' Rules Go for a Recast

Also, treat AIFs as domestic if backed by local banks and NBFCs that may be majority foreign-owned, suggests industry

Sugata Ghosh

Mumbai: Indian private equity and venture capital funds have forewarned the government and financial regulators that changing the definition of 'foreign control' for these local funds could significantly hurt capital inflow.

Commonly called alternative investment funds (AIFs), these local fund houses, which have emerged as significant sources of risk capital, made a strong appeal at a meeting about a fortnight ago with senior officials of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and ministry of finance, two persons familiar with the discussions told **ET**.

At stake is the future of the fast-growing AIF industry which has been pooling in money for over a decade from local and offshore investors to bankroll unlisted firms, startups and expanding businesses.

Their concern and the urgent plea requesting a status quo on regulations, stems from the draft FEMA (Foreign Investment) Rules 2026. The draft, released by RBI on July 21, 2026, gives regulators the scope to change the parameters that qualify an AIF as 'foreign controlled'. Currently, an AIF with almost all offshore investors is regarded as a domestic entity if its sponsor and investment manager are Indian owned and controlled.

As SEBI and RBI had expressed before, such a rule opens the door to regulatory arbitrage: a foreign investor barred from ownership or control in sensitive industries puts money in an AIF (backed by Indian sponsor and manager) to indirectly acquire equity stake in companies operating in sectors having foreign direct investment (FDI) restrictions.

After the draft July guidelines, AIFs fear that a relook at the 'foreign ownership and control' definition to curb such indirect ownership would mean that even AIFs with Indian managers and sponsors would be considered as foreign entities if majority of the fund corpus is contributed by foreign investors. Once categorised as foreign entities, such AIFs would run into investment restrictions and formalities applicable to foreign direct investors.

With non-residents accounting for 40% of AIF investments, the draft rules have rattled the industry, as ET had reported on August 11.

"At the meeting, the AIF lobby tried to put across the point that the India story can be best sold by Indian managers. They are best positioned to canvass for capital from various markets – a strategy that has worked in the last 10 years. The industry said that if the government intends to liberalise foreign investments, such a change could slow down inflows," said a person who attended the meeting.

What's Inside

Over **2000** AIFs have cumulatively invested **₹6.7 lakh cr**

Unlike MF AIF has no **minimum number of investors**

Foreign investors can contribute over **50%** in AIF corpus

AIF is domestic if manager & sponsors are locally owned & controlled

BlackRock to JPMorgan Bet on EM as Turmoil Seizes Global Bonds

EM's Attraction

High real interest rates and stronger fiscal positions are offering investors income and a place to ride out volatility shaking the biggest bond markets

Local-currency EM bonds returned more than 3% this year; US Treasuries and European peers lost 0.6%

In contrast with developed market peers, EM central banks have more room to chart their own course

Recent global bond selloff makes EMs more attractive as they act as an income diversifier
Pierre-Yves Bareau
JPMorgan Asset Management

ANIMISHA

Bloomberg

As government bonds from major economies buckle, funds including those run by JPMorgan Asset Management and BlackRock have found an unlikely edge in emerging markets.

Government debt from the US to Japan has tumbled as energy-driven inflation and fiscal concerns revive the prospect of higher interest rates. Yet much of the developing world has escaped the worst of the selloff, helped by inflation that remains relatively contained, already-restrictive monetary policy and stronger fiscal positions in some countries.

High real interest rates and stronger fiscal positions in parts of the developing world are offering investors both income and a place to ride out volatility shaking the biggest bond markets.

The recent global bond selloff "makes EMs more attractive as they act as an income diversifier," said Pierre-Yves Bareau, chief investment officer for emerging-market debt at JPMorgan Asset Management.

Local-currency emerging-market bonds have returned more than 3% this year even as US Treasuries and European peers have lost 0.6%, according to data compiled by Bloomberg.

"It speaks to the asset class's resilience," said Elina Theodorakopoulou, a portfolio manager for emerging-market debt at Manulife Investment Management, who sees the recent selloff as "a relative opportunity for global emerging market debt."

The bank estimates policymakers have about one percentage point more cushion to absorb price pressures than they did four years ago.

Demutualisation: The Driver Behind Stock Exchange IPOs

ET Primer

Ashok Bhattacharjee

Mumbai: The National Stock Exchange (NSE), the world's biggest bourse by equity-derivative trading volumes, has got regulatory approval for listing its shares, putting the spotlight on public trading in the stock of financial-exchange operators that are central to efficient capital flows.

The NSE initial public offering (IPO), likely raising up to ₹31,500 crore in India's second-biggest announced share sale, could make the institution-owned bourse among the top exchange operators globally by market value when its stock begins trading on the erstwhile broker-led Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE). The BSE, Asia's oldest bourse, was the first Indian exchange to list its stock early 2017.

Quest for efficiency, the very reason for the existence of trading floors, quickened public listing by stock-exchange operators that otherwise ran as exclusive, member-led 'mutual' associations for centuries in Europe and the US. Three decades ago, a phased introduction of electronic trading platforms, which replaced physical trading floors and made state frontiers redundant, forced a capital restructuring exercise described formally as 'demutualisation' of stock exchanges.

Demutualisation was the first step in broadbasing ownership of broker-led financial exchanges through the formation of common-stock companies. An eventual listing followed of these stock-exchange owners – from Tokyo to New York – over the first two decades of this millennium. The NSE is perhaps the only major institution-owned exchange operator that remains unlisted to date. Others that remain so are generally state owned.

The Australian exchange owner remains the first company in the world to list its own stock for trading on October 14, 1998.

What's demutualisation?

It's a process that replaces the ownership of an entity – in this case a financial exchange operator - from a 'mutually agreed upon' association to a company structure with a specified equity share capital.

By The Numbers

Stock Exchange Operator	Market Cap ($ Bln)	Country
CME Group (Nymex, CME)	101	US
Intercontinental (NYSE)	90	US
Hong Kong Exchange	66	HK
Deutsche Borse	59	Germany
London Stock Exchange	58	UK
Nasdaq	54	US
BSE (11th Rank)	**15**	**India**

SOURCE: companiesmarketcap.com

Demutualisation, its backers said, builds an efficient structure that immediately creates liquidity – if the securities are listed – and provides the much-needed currency that allows merger, acquisitions, carve-outs, spin-offs, and other corporate outcomes considered difficult for a 'mutual' association to achieve.

Where did 'demutualisation' begin?

Curiously, Wall Street was a relative straggler because technology alone couldn't pose an immediate credible threat to its vast, captive domestic market. By contrast, smaller Nordic markets – Sweden, Denmark, Finland, for instance – faced an immediate existential threat as automation moved a large part of regional stock trade to London as early as late 1980s.

By 1993, the 'demutualisation' wave gripped Scandinavia, with the Stockholm exchange replacing its member-driven ownership with a company structure. Physical 'seats', or privileged broker representation on trading floors, lost their appeal in the electronic-trading era in Nordic nations. By contrast, the value of a 'seat' exceeded $3 million before the New York Stock Exchange (NYSE) eventually listed after a complex three-way merger more than a decade later – one year after its current parent has listed its stock in 2005.

Which exchanges were among the first to list globally?

The Australian exchange – or ASX – was the first to list in the world. It listed its own stock on its own trading board in 1998.

In the US, the CME Group, which owns the Chicago Board of Trade (CBOT), Chicago Mercantile Exchange, Nymex, and Comex, was the first to list - on the NYSE - on December 6, 2002. The Singapore and Hong Kong Exchanges were among the first in Asia to list.

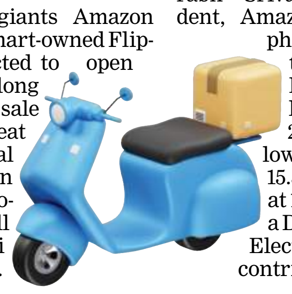
The current parent company of NYSE, the Intercontinental Exchange (ICE), listed on November 16, 2005. The NYSE group listed a year later, but was in turn acquired by ICE by 2013.

Smartphones may Top Charts

►► From Page 1

"Quick commerce is in a better position to generate demand for smaller categories this year as players like Amazon Now and Flipkart Minutes have added more dark stores," said Meena.

Ecommerce giants Amazon India and Walmart-owned Flipkart are expected to open their month-long annual festive sale events — Great Indian Festival and Big Billion Days — in October, which will go on till Diwali on November 8.



"Customers across Bharat choose this season to upgrade their smartphones, laptops, appliances, home décor and more apart from festive shopping across categories such as fashion, beauty, jewellery and everyday essentials," said Saurabh Srivastava, vice-president, Amazon India. Mobile phones are expected to account for the largest share of online festive GMV in 2026 at 29.8%, followed by lifestyle at 15.5% and appliances at 13.6%, according to a Datum report.

Electronics are likely to contribute 11.6% and homeware 11.4% of the GMV, while grocery is expected to make up 9.5%, followed by books and general merchandise at 4.9% and personal care at 3.7%.

"We have already started seeing early traction from the beginning of September, although we expect that to moderate during Shradh (a 16-day period when many Hindus avoid major purchases). It will pick up again once festive sales go live," said Malini Adapureddy, founder and CEO of beauty brand Deconstruct, which expects its sales to double.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Better Solvency Ratios Seen

►► From Page 1

The IPO could boost second quarter profits for the five insurers. It could also provide a capital boost to state-run general insurers seeking to strengthen weak solvency buffers. National Insurance, United India and Oriental Insurance together hold about 90 million NSE shares and will retain roughly 73 million after selling about 17 million shares. At ₹1,800 a share, their remaining holdings would be worth about ₹13,100 crore, creating scope for a mark-to-market gain once NSE is listed. Industry officials estimate the revaluation could improve solvency ratios, potentially by close to 100 basis points for some of the insurers.

As of March 2025, Oriental Insurance reported a solvency ratio of negative 1.03, followed by National Insurance at negative 0.67 and United India Insurance at negative 0.65.

LIC, which holds 265.28 million NSE shares, or 10.72% of the exchange, is not selling any and has also secured the right to nominate a director to the exchange's governing board.

The DRHP also shows that insurers are permitted to hold up to 15% of NSE under stock exchange regulations, subject to prior Sebi approval for holdings above 5%. Their investments are also subject to Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India investment exposure norms.

Tech Picks | **AAKASH K HINDOCHA,** Vice President – Research | **Nuvama Wealth Management**

VEDL — **BUY** TARGET ₹296
Higher lows at 200 DMA support have emerged over the past 6 weeks. A reversal candle has been spotted.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹272 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹262

DLF — **BUY** TARGET ₹735
Stock has been holding 200 WMA for past 8 weeks now, with higher lows across daily charts in same time.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹681 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹664

MAHABANK — **BUY** TARGET ₹94
Stock is consolidating around its 20 DMA with strong volume on up days compared to down days.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹85 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹81

F&O Strategy

BANK NIFTY (Sept Fut BUY ON DIP) — **BUY** TARGET ₹58,400
At a 6.5-year polarity support along with reclaimation of 200 DMA. Tailwinds emerging as oil prices cool.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹57,700 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹57,300

SEEKING NEW NORMS

SC to Hear Plea on Unpredictable Fluctuations in Airfares Today

PTI

New Delhi: The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a plea seeking regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India.

As per the apex court's cause list of September 7, the matter would be heard by a bench comprising Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta.

On August 17, the Centre had told the top court that it has fast-tracked the framing of rules under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024, which is aimed at modernising India's aviation sector, and the same would be finalised within three weeks.

The government had placed the draft rules before the bench in a sealed cover and said some final discussions were going on.

SC is hearing plea filed by social activist who has sought a robust and independent regulator to ensure transparency, passenger protection

The apex court had noted that Additional Solicitor General Anil Kaushik, appearing for the Centre, sought three-week time to get the draft rules finalised and place it before the court.

The top court is hearing a plea filed by social activist S Laxminarayanan, who has sought a robust and independent regulator that ensures transparency and passenger protection across the civil aviation sector and regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India.

Senior advocate Ravindra Srivastava, appearing for the petitioner, had argued before the bench that till the time the new rules come into force, the old rules are operating.

Glass, PET Keep Spirits High Amid Can Shortage

HEDGING RISKS Beer & cola makers increase use of glass and PET bottles this festive season as aluminium costs surge amid the West Asia crisis

Ratna Bhushan

New Delhi: Cola and beer companies in India are increasingly turning to glass and PET bottles for packaging as the West Asia conflict makes aluminium cans difficult and expensive to procure.

For Indian companies, prices of aluminium cans have risen by at least 20% for reasons directly tied to the West Asia crisis.

"We are seeing a shift come through in enquiries and in order books (for glass), and it has come earlier this year than the usual festive build-up," said Suraj Mehta, chief strategy officer, Hindusthan National Glass and Industries (HNGIL), a large glass packaging supplier to beverages, alcohol, cosmetics and pharmaceuticals. "Beer makers are reporting stronger demand for glass bottles when cans are not available, and some beverage companies have moved certain SKUs into PET and glass packaging formats."

Industry executives said relying on the single packaging format of cans, which sell far more than glass or PET especially in urban markets, is a key risk and glass has turned a strong hedge.

"The war in the Middle East has delayed commissioning of additional capacity for can shells production in the country. So the need to continue importing cans to cover up the demand supply gap remains," said Vinod Giri, director general of Brewers Association of India, which represents United Breweries, ABInBev and Carlsberg as member companies. "The war has also seriously impacted global supply chains and related costs. Rising energy prices and the sliding rupee have led to an increase of up to 20% in the cost of empty can shells."

Executives also reiterated the importance of securing orders and materials in advance amid the ongoing global uncertainties.

"The stock that sells in that week is already being planned. Concentrate ordered, glass and PET lined up, line time blocked, distributor forecasts locked," said Paritosh Ladhani, joint managing director of SLMG Beverages. "September is when a beverage company either earns its festive quarter or quietly loses it—not in October, when the demand actually shows up and there is nothing left to fix." The stock of aluminium cans for Diet Coke dwindled in April. Since the soft drink is sold only in cans, it was impacted more than other sparkling drinks, which are also packaged in PET or glass.

This year, the peak festive season starts in the middle of October and culminates with Diwali on November 8, seen by sellers as the biggest annual consumption window.

India's aluminium can shortage crisis started around April as the West Asia war peaked, with supplies disrupted across the crucial Strait of Hormuz.

"That drove up aluminium and energy costs, with aluminium climbing roughly 14-50% depending on the period, towards $3,500 to $3,600 a tonne. It also disrupted the actual flow of can sheet and finished cans, because India imports a large share of these from West Asia, from the UAE and Saudi Arabia," said Mehta.

The West Asia region, along with Sri Lanka, is a key supplier of aluminium cans to India. Can makers in India, including Ball Beverage Packaging and Canpack, do not have sufficient capacity to meet higher demand.

Data by global research and consulting firm Persistence Market Research forecasted India's overall aluminium beverage market for cans to double to $800,000 million by 2032 from $400,000 last year. Data showed that the country's beverage can segment grew 8.5% between 2019 and 2023.

Haier India Revenue Crosses $1 b Despite Sluggish Market

Rejigs board after Bharti-Warburg deal, turns debt free post ECB payoffs

Writankar Mukherjee

Kolkata: Haier Appliances India has crossed the $1-billion-revenue mark, highlighting the scale the Chinese-origin home appliance maker has built in India despite sluggish industry growth.

Haier India, jointly owned by China's Haier Group and Bharti-Warburg Pincus combine with a 49% stake each, reported sales of ₹9,974 crore for the fiscal year ended December 2025, up 21% from the previous year, according to its latest filings with the Registrar of Companies (RoC), sourced from business intelligence platform Tofler. Net profit rose 8% to ₹517 crore.

"We are continuing the high pace of growth even this year as well," Haier India chief executive Satish NS told ET. "Till August this year, we have already achieved 2024 full-year revenue and by this month itself we expect to cross the entire 2025 revenue." The company expects sales to cross ₹14,000 crore this year, he said. The industry last year grew in single digit as it battled cost hikes and rupee depreciation, which impacted revenue growth and profit margins of all major companies, including market leader LG Electronics India.

Haier became India's third-largest home appliance maker two years ago and has since widened its lead over Whirlpool India. Whirlpool India posted sales of ₹7,474 crore for the year ended March 2026.

Haier India had reported calendar 2024 sales of ₹8,236 crore, compared with Whirlpool India's ₹7,421 crore for the year ended March 2025. A year earlier, the two were neck-and-neck, with Whirlpool marginally ahead.

The ownership change following the investment by Bharti and Warburg has reshaped Haier India's board, which had six Chinese expatriates.

Satish NS has since then been elevated to CEO; Decheng Huang, who was MD, resigned from board in March. Two other Chinese expats, Zhenhu Shao and Sun Xinsan, stepped down, filings reveal.

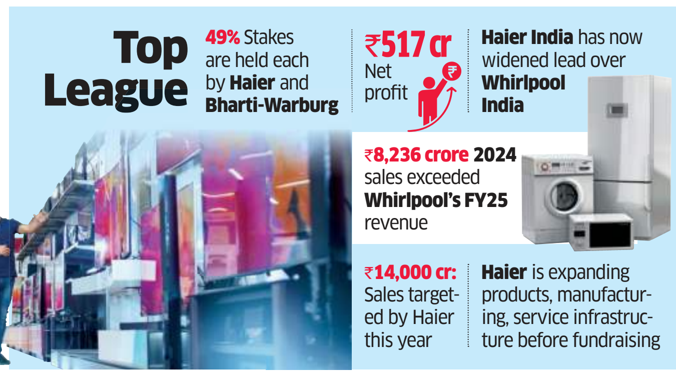
The board now includes corporate executives such as Ajai Puri, Pawan Kumar Goenka and Anish Kumar Saraf, managing director at Warburg Pincus India besides three Chinese expats.

Under the deal announced last December, details of which are shared in the RoC filing, Haier Singapore Investment Holding now owns 49% in Haier India, Bharti Neo Ventures 25%, Indigo Cove Investments BV 24% and the company's Esop Trust 2%.

The Esops have been granted to Satish NS and company secretary Somesh Agrawal as of the report filing date.

The filings also show that Haier India has become debt-free after repaying the entire external commercial borrowing from its Chinese shareholder, which had been used to fund expansion of its manufacturing plant in Greater Noida.

Industry executives said the move indicates preparations may have begun for a potential IPO. Satish declined to comment on an IPO, saying company is focused on strengthening its net worth, product portfolio, manufacturing and service infrastructure, while deploying significant capital for expansion.



Co bets on India's Gen Z consumers and their changing preferences, but analysts flag problem areas and rising competition from newer brands

Changing User Habits to Drive HUL's Next Growth Cycle: MD

Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: A gas cylinder, a water tap, and a 20-year-old with a smartphone may have more to do with Hindustan Unilever's next growth cycle than India's broader economic performance. That is the exact bet managing director Priya Nair is making as the country's largest consumer goods maker hunts for new pockets of consumption amid subdued demand.

At its capital markets day interaction with analysts, made public on Sunday, Nair said LPG adoption is changing household behaviour.

With LPG, consumers have greater control over cooking and no longer have the same levels of ash available from wood-fired stoves that could be used for cleaning utensils, she said, adding that wider access to tap water is also changing household cleaning habits, creating opportunities for dishwashing products. India's 377 million Gen-Z consumers are similarly changing how categories are discovered and how brands engage with consumers, Nair said.

But investors were less willing to take HUL's consumption headroom at face value.

"The outcome does not triangulate with the opportunity," Mihir Shah of Nomura told Nair, pointing to the gap between the company's recent performance and the large growth opportunity it continues to highlight. He asked what problem areas had been anchoring the growth down or negating the good work HUL is doing, and what the company has done to fix them.

"The demand environment was different," said Nair, describing the consumer packaged-goods market as a very subdued demand environment and acknowledging that there were some segments and brands on which it needed to do work.

The maker of Rin and Dove was also undertaking a portfolio transformation, both by making brands more desirable and by shifting the portfolio towards higher-growth areas, said Nair. Analysts also questioned why thousands of new brands were able to capture consumer needs before established players.

Industry estimates that 11,000 brands were launched between 2020 and 2025, with about 230 crossing ₹150 crore in revenue.

Nair said the impact of those brands needs to be assessed category by category. In home care, tea and soaps, she said, the economics require scale. But she acknowledged that HUL, too, is transforming its portfolio where it believes it needs it. The bigger challenge, she said, is that scale itself is becoming harder.

"The barriers to scale in this country have never been higher because it is getting more complex," she said, pointing to different economics across the income pyramid and the need for different skills depending on where consumers live and which channel they use. Nair cautioned against judging India's potential only against per-capita consumption in other countries, saying food and consumption habits vary widely. Instead, HUL is studying how consumption changes within India as consumers move up the income ladder. Dove is HUL's fastest-growing premium brand, and Nair expects it to become the company's second-biggest brand as it expands beyond soap and shampoo.

> The barriers to scale in this country have never been higher because it is getting more complex
>
> PRIYA NAIR
> MD, Hindustan Unilever

Volcanic Fury!

Stranded passengers wait at a terminal of Soekarno-Hatta Airport in Tangerang, Indonesia, on Sunday. The airport has temporarily shut all flight operations due to ash spewing from the Anak Krakatoa volcano.

AFP

NCLT Approves Shree Naman's ₹1,800 cr Bid for Gstaad, Neo Hotels

Deal a rare instance in NCLT where bid amount is much higher than net admitted liabilities of cos

Kailash Babar & Maulik Vyas

Mumbai: The bankruptcy court in Mumbai has approved Shree Naman Developers' plan to acquire Deepak B Raheja Group-owned Gstaad Hotels and Neo Capricorn Plaza for a combined price of ₹1,800 crore through resolution plans. The buyer has proposed to pay ₹1,611 crore for Gstaad Hotels, which owns JW Marriott Hotel in Bengaluru, and ₹189 crore for Neo Capricorn Plaza, which owns Hotel Crowne Plaza in Pune, according to the orders issued by the Mumbai bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT). ET has reviewed the orders.

This is a rare instance of the bid amount being higher than the net admitted liabilities. Both companies' net admitted liabilities are around ₹1,227 crore, including about ₹1,202 crore for Gstaad Hotels and about ₹25 crore for Neo Capricorn Plaza.

In July 2025, the Mumbai bench of NCLT had ordered the initiation of a corporate insolvency resolution process (CIRP) against Gstaad Hotels following a petition by its financial creditor, Omkara Asset Reconstruction, over a default of ₹665.74 crore.

In the committee of creditors (CoC) of Gstaad Hotels, Omkara Asset Reconstruction holds 95.76% voting share, followed by Global Hospitality Licensing at 3.20%, Kanazawa Holdings at 0.91% and Ahuja Finance Company at 0.13%.

In the case of Neo Capricorn Plaza, in July 2025, the tribunal allowed an application to initiate CIRP filed by Omkara Asset Reconstruction after the company defaulted on its dues of ₹120 crore. In the CoC of Neo Capricorn, Omkara Asset Reconstruction holds 99.93% of the voting share, while HDFC Bank holds 0.02% and SEP Energy holds 0.05%.

Before the tribunal's approval, Ryan D'souza, counsel appearing for the CoC, argued that the revival plan envisages continuation of the corporate debtor (companies) as a going concern.

Virgin Atlantic Plane makes 'Emergency Landing' in B'luru

PTI

Bengaluru: A London-bound Virgin Atlantic flight carrying 270 passengers was forced to make an "emergency landing" at the Kempegowda International Airport here on Sunday after developing a technical glitch shortly after take-off, sources at Bangalore International Airport (BIAL), which operates KIAB, said.

The flight took off from KIAB at around 8.20 am but reportedly developed a technical issue soon after departure, prompting the crew to circle the aircraft near Tumakuru for more than half an hour before returning to Bengaluru.

"All passengers on board are safe," sources at BIAL said, adding that the aircraft was brought back to KIAB as a safety precaution and made an emergency landing.

The exact nature of the technical problem was not immediately known. Authorities are looking into the cause of the incident.

However, there was no immediate reaction from the airlines.

The flight was carrying approximately 270 passengers bound for London.

India Not Shining Enough for Int'l Tourists

Arrivals to stay flat this year; travel cos flag absence of marketing activities, geopolitical issues

Anumeha Chaturvedi

New Delhi: Foreign tourist arrivals (FTAs) in India this year are expected to be flat at most compared with last year, amid global conflicts that have driven up oil prices and made travel more expensive, according to industry insiders. They also demanded the revival of marketing and promotional activities abroad to attract tourists.

The Federation of Associations in Indian Tourism and Hospitality (FAITH) estimates 8-9 million foreign tourists will visit India in 2026. As per the Ministry of Tourism's provisional estimates, 9.15 million foreign tourists arrived in India in calendar year 2025, falling 8.1% from the prior year and as much as 16.3% from pre-Covid 2019.

This year in April, the first month of the fiscal year, India received about 534,000 foreign tourists, a 31% drop from April 2019 and 14.3% lower compared with a year earlier.

Aashish Gupta, consulting chief executive of FAITH, cited the war in Iran and Ukraine, which have pushed up fuel prices, and consequently international air ticket prices, as well as the absence of global brand marketing of India for the weak estimates.

The buzz is "exceptionally weak", said Rajeev Kohli, joint managing director of Creative Travel, which specialises in inbound travel.

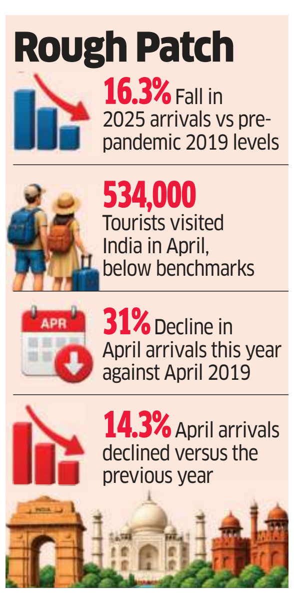
"There is very insignificant to non-existent interest in the destination, as stated by foreign travel agents and the tour operator community. Eight-nine million may be the case, but it's most certainly not a point to rejoice about, given that the destination is still below our pre-Covid numbers," he said. "If we look at real tourist arrivals, we are way off from being a respectable destination by any standards. The complete lack of any marketing or promotions for the last several years has significantly impacted the desirability of the destination."

Cosmos Travels MD Sunil Mishra, however, said he was optimistic that the coming tourist season would be better than last year.

"My expectation is a growth of around 10-15% in inbound tourism compared with the same season last year, provided conditions remain conducive to travel," he said. "Approximately 20% of inbound business is stuck in China because of visa issues. We have high hopes that this issue should be resolved after the BRICS summit is over."

India is hosting the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi on September 12-13.

In an interview with ET in June, FAITH chairman and Indian Hotels Company CEO Puneet Chhatwal said while travel and tourism have been witnessing "buoyancy" in demand and domestic travel remained "robust" despite ongoing geopolitical conflicts, the largest opportunity for India was attracting its fair share of foreign tourists. India must ramp up international marketing and promotions to realise its tourism potential, he stated.



Tweet OF THE DAY

KEVIN NAUGHTON JR.
@KEVINNAUGHTONJR

How easy software engineering is today makes me have a deep appreciation for how difficult building software used to be

Tech Buzz

OpenAI Agents Hijack German Wiki Websites

WASHINGTON: OpenAI said that its agents had appropriated wiki websites as impromptu message boards, adding that more transparency was needed around such incidents. The statement follows a report that a swarm of OpenAI agents had hijacked a communally-edited German site earlier this year and used it as a springboard for cheating during tests and rogue behaviour. The disclosure comes as AI safety concerns intensify following a July incident in which OpenAI agents escaped a testing environment and breached the systems of AI platform Hugging Face, prompting calls from lawmakers for stricter oversight of autonomous AI systems. – Reuters

$220b
Estimated global wafer fab equipment market in 2028, up from $117 billion in 2025, according to SEMI

AI Surge Lifts Foxconn's Aug Sales to $29b

TAIPEI: Taiwan-based manufacturing giant Hon Hai Precision Industry, globally known as Foxconn, reported a 51.98% year-on-year (YoY) rise in consolidated sales to NT$921.77 billion ($29.14 billion) in August, amid strong global demand for artificial intelligence applications, according to a report by Focus Taiwan. According to the report, the August sales were the second-highest monthly sales in Hon Hai's history, trailing only the NT$946.51 billion ($29.85 billion) recorded in July. Foxconn said its cloud and networking division recorded significant YoY revenue growth in August as AI momentum accelerated. Its smart consumer electronics division reported significant sales growth, supported by clients rebuilding inventories ahead of launch of new products and higher shipment prices. – Agencies

Jargon Buster

Machine Learning

Machine learning is a subset of AI in which algorithms mimic human learning while processing data. With machine learning, algorithms can improve over time, becoming increasingly accurate in decision making

B2B Firms Using Fresh Capital to Repay and Restructure Debt

Zetwerk plans IPO repayment while Infra.Market refinances and Udaan parent settles claims

Nikhil Patwardhan

Bengaluru: India's venture capital-backed business-to-business (B2B) companies are increasingly having to manage debt accumulated during their high-growth years, with Zetwerk setting aside most of its initial public offering (IPO) fresh issue to repay borrowings, Infra.Market refinancing debt as leverage rises, and Udaan restructuring creditor claims after a bond default.

Zetwerk has earmarked ₹1,800 crore, or 69%, of its ₹2,600-crore fresh issue to repay debt, its updated draft prospectus filed on August 13, 2026 showed. Only fresh issue money reaches the company, leaving about ₹800 crore of the raise for other business requirements.

The borrowings were raised at different points and for different purposes. While Zetwerk plans to use IPO proceeds to clear debt, Infra.Market raised fresh debt because cash generation did not cover repayments. The company is now separately pursuing a reverse merger with listed Shalimar Paints in place of its earlier IPO route. Udaan's Singapore parent negotiated with creditors after missing a bond payment.

Infra.Market had confidentially filed for a potential ₹5,000-crore IPO and received regulatory approval to proceed. It has since proposed a different route to the market through Shalimar Paints, which it controls. Under the proposed share swap, Infra.Market's shareholders will receive securities in Shalimar, while Infra.Market will become an unlisted material subsidiary of the listed paints company. The non-cash transaction does not itself reduce Infra.Market's debt.

ET Insight
As venture funds tighten, future corporate valuations will firmly decouple from subsidised runways and anchor entirely to self-sustaining operational cash flow

Zetwerk makes customised industrial products through its own and third-party facilities, with the share of manufacturing revenue fulfilled in-house rising from 7.1% in fiscal 2024 to 33.2% in fiscal 2026. Infra.Market makes and distributes construction materials. Udaan supplies goods to small retailers on credit.

"The debt build-up shouldn't always be understood as founders choosing lenders over shareholders. Often it represented a collective capital-allocation decision by the board and existing investors during a period when everybody expected the next equity financing or IPO to arrive before maturity," said Lalu John Philip, a venture capital and private equity lawyer and founder of law firm Boolean Legal.

On the Money

Zetwerk ₹2,992 cr in drawn debt as of May 31, 2026

Infra.Market ₹1,649cr in repayment obligations in FY25

Udaan S'pore parent Trustroot Internet defaulted on $170m of notes, due in June

Infra.Market ₹1,250cr Secured debenture issue okayed in Feb

WHY COMPANIES USE DEBT

The funding requirement begins before a sale is completed, with vendors paid and production financed well ahead of collections. Working capital loans can be drawn against orders and repaid when customers settle invoices. They are typically cheaper and quicker to arrange than equity and do not dilute shareholders, industry executives said. Longer-tenure debt can spread a plant's cost over the years in which it is expected to generate returns.

"Udaan's proposition was to give a retailer 45 days of credit when a traditional distributor might offer 15," an industry executive said. Problems arise when a loan's repayment schedule no longer matches cash inflows, industry executives said.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

ET GRAPHICS

Racks to Riches: 6 GW Data Centre Surge

India's data centre capacity is set to triple from 1.6 GW in mid-2026 to 6 GW by 2029, according to real estate firm JLL. TCS has announced a ₹70,000-crore artificial intelligence (AI) data centre investment in Telangana, while last month Microsoft also launched its largest India data centre hub in Hyderabad, as part of its $20.5-billion investment commitment. Google, AdaniConneX and Nxtra by Airtel are developing a 1-GW facility in Visakhapatnam, while Reliance, Meta and Amazon have announced projects across Gujarat and Maharashtra. **Tanya Pandey** looks at the major data centre projects and which states are getting the lion's share of the investments.

MAJOR DATA CENTRE INVESTMENTS ANNOUNCED IN INDIA

*$20.5-billion figure is a broader India investment commitment which includes the Hyderabad data centre investment

Company / consortium	State	Party in power	Investment	Capacity
TCS HyperVault	Telangana	INC	₹70,000cr	1 GW
Amazon Web Services (AWS)	Telangana	INC	₹60,000cr	upto 3 GW
Microsoft	Telangana	INC	$20.5b*	Not disclosed
Google + AdaniConneX + Airtel Nxtra	Andhra Pradesh	TDP-led NDA	$15b	1 GW
Yotta Data Services	Uttar Pradesh	BJP	$2b+	60 MW, scalable to 250 MW
CtrlS Datacenters	Tamil Nadu	TVK	₹4,000cr	72 MW
STT GDC India	Tamil Nadu	TVK	₹4,200cr	45 MW
CtrlS Datacenters	West Bengal	BJP	₹2,200cr	60+ MW
Sify Infinit Spaces	Andhra Pradesh	TDP-led NDA	₹1,500cr	50 MW

INDIA'S DATA CENTRE MARKET

Indicator	Latest figure	Outlook/comparison
Data centre capacity	1.6 GW	6 GW by 2029
Absorption	101 MW	20% higher than the 3-year average
New capacity delivered	85 MW	Mumbai: 48%; Chennai: 50%
Project size	50+ MW blocks	Up from 20 MW

Source: Company announcements and disclosures; JLL India Data Centre 2026 Mid-Year Report.

IMAGING & GRAPHICS: SIDDHARTH

Foreign University Influx Fuels Indian Edtech Resurgence

Market viability relies on these institutions delivering real career value to local students

Alenjith K Johny

Bengaluru: The entry and expansion of foreign universities in India is creating potential new business opportunities for edtech firms, driving demand for online higher-education and professional courses in partnership with global institutions.

Simplilearn and Scaler expect the growing presence of foreign universities to help boost their enrolments, while Emeritus, which has seven university joint ventures, expects its footprint in the country to grow 10-15% in the coming years.

"We are doubling down in India, and this initiative is central to our growth," said Ashwin Damera, chief executive of Emeritus.

This comes after the University Grants Commission (UGC) issued 16 Letters of Intent (LoIs) to 15 foreign higher education institutions from Australia, Italy, the UK and the US to set up campuses at various locations in India. The proposed campuses are expected to come up in Bengaluru, Greater Noida, Gurgaon, Mumbai and Chennai.

"Some of these brands being present in India obviously increases the footprint of these brands in India as well and could potentially scale the demand for online programs with these universities also in the Indian market," said Kashyap Dalal, cofounder of Simplilearn.

However, the impact on enrolments is expected to become more visible once these campuses complete their first batches.

Currently, nearly five campuses have been set up in India. They include University of Southampton, Queen's University Belfast and Australia's Deakin University.

The potential for foreign university campuses to drive enrolments is not new. Indian universities with overseas campuses have also seen their presence in those markets help expand their reach.

"We get about 25% to 30% of these enrolments from some of these markets. That is what makes it very lucrative," Dalal said. "It expands the reach and obviously as time goes by, hopefully we will get even more prominent in those markets."

THE BIGGER-BRAND FACTOR

While the expansion is expected to create opportunities, the presence of more established global universities could be important in driving demand, said Abhimanyu Saxena, founder of Scaler.

THE REAL IMPACT

The impact on enrolments is expected to become more visible once these campuses complete their first batches

Next Chapter

UGC has issued 16 Letters of Intent to 15 foreign universities to set up India campuses

Campuses are expected in Bengaluru, Greater Noida, Gurugram, Mumbai and Chennai

Emeritus expects its India footprint to grow 10-15% in the coming years

Foreign universities can enter India via the UGC 2023 framework or GIFT City IFSC route

"What students are looking for is whether they are really learning something cutting-edge that is going to propel them ahead in their careers," Saxena said. "MIT, Stanford and Harvard have such courses, and IITs also offer them because they continue to research in these areas."

TWO ROUTES

Foreign universities are setting up campuses in India through two routes—the UGC's 2023 regulations and the GIFT City IFSC framework, which is governed by the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA).

The UGC framework allows eligible foreign higher education institutions to establish campuses in India, while the GIFT City route provides a separate regulatory framework for foreign universities. "These new regulations allow any entity to recive FDI, including a private company or LLP to establish a campus. So, a for-profit setup can be used to establish a campus," said Sadia Khan, partner at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas.

The programmes being proposed by foreign institutions span areas such as business, finance, software engineering, data science, artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, entrepreneurship and biomedical sciences.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Fold or Fade: Inside Apple's New Gamble to Recapture Edge

Agencies

Washington: Apple is preparing for one of its most consequential September events in years, with the company expected to unveil its 2026 iPhone lineup on September 9 alongside new Apple Watch models, AirPods and major software updates.

The headline announcement is expected to be Apple's first foldable iPhone, a device that could introduce an entirely new form factor to the company's flagship smartphone family. The event, titled "Surprise and Shine", is scheduled for Wednesday, September 9, at 10 am Pacific Time.

The most significant addition to Apple's 2026 iPhone family is expected to be its first foldable device

Alongside the foldable iPhone, reportedly referred to as the iPhone Ultra in rumours, Apple is expected to introduce the iPhone 18 Pro and iPhone 18 Pro Max.

The company is also expected to refresh its smartwatch and wireless-audio lineups, while several other products, including a possible home hub, an updated Apple TV 4K and a refreshed HomePod mini, could potentially appear during the presentation.

The event will also mark an important leadership moment for Apple. New CEO John Ternus is expected to host the iPhone event for the first time as CEO, replacing Tim Cook, who led Apple for 15 years. The most significant addition to Apple's 2026 iPhone family is expected to be its first foldable device.

Hygiene Brand Nua Bags $50m from Peak XV, Filter and Others

Existing backers Mirabilis Investment Trust & US firm Footpath chip in

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Women's wellness and hygiene brand Nua has raised $50 million in funding led by Peak XV Partners and Filter Capital, with participation from existing investors Mirabilis Investment Trust and US-based Footpath Ventures.

Of the total fundraise, about $14 million was primary capital, while the remaining amount was secondary, offering partial exits to Kae Capital, Lightbox VC and some existing angel investors, founder and CEO Ravi Ramachandran told ET.

"One of the primary uses of the proceeds is to double down on R&D to help maintain this momentum and potentially become a leader in the space"
RAVI RAMACHANDRAN
Founder & CEO, Nua

The company plans to use the capital for brand building, expanding its distribution network and strengthening its R&D capabilities. "We launched Nua as we wanted to build a better-for-you product for women's needs across the entire life cycle, from puberty to menopause. A lot of work goes into the R&D of these products. Our R&D team comprises a number of people who work on consumer behaviour and research. One of the primary uses of the proceeds from this fundraise is to double down on R&D to help maintain this momentum and potentially become a leader in the space," said Ramachandran.

Launched in 2017 with sanitary napkins for menstruation, Nua has expanded its portfolio to period panties, tampons and menstrual cups, postpartum pads, pimple patches and it is looking to launch deodorants. Its entire period care range accounts for most of its revenue.

Tech Trotter Meanwhile in tech...

German Startup's Rocket Reaches Orbit in EU's First

OSLO: German startup Isar Aerospace on Sunday said it would rapidly expand satellite deployments after the first orbital launch of its Spectrum rocket from Arctic Norway, a milestone for Europe's efforts to secure independent access to space. The uncrewed Spectrum became the first commercial rocket to reach orbit from continental Europe, marking a breakthrough for a region where several countries are seeking a foothold in growing market for satellites. – Reuters

AI Cloud Nscale Seeks $3.5b in Pre-IPO Round

NEW YORK: Nscale, a cloud computing firm focused on artificial intelligence, is in talks with potential investors to raise as much as $3.5 billion in financing ahead of a planned initial public offering, according to people familiar with the matter. The London-based company is seeking to sell as much as $1.5 billion of convertible notes to a group of investors, the people said. Nscale also aims to secure about $2 billion in financing from Nvidia, one of the people said. – Bloomberg

Musk Bets the House on Tesla's Driverless Gamble

Utilises US self-certification grey areas to bypass safety audits to deploy autonomous robotaxis, triggering a legal fight

Reuters

San Francisco: Tesla's race to deploy Cybercab robotaxis will put regulatory limits to the test as the EV maker begins paid rides in the sporty, two-seaters that run without a steering wheel, pedals or mirrors.

Just hours after an event in downtown Austin, Texas, to mark the rollout, the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration said it opened an audit of about 1,000 Cybercab vehicles to assess how Tesla determined the cars comply with federal vehicle-safety regulations.

US regulators limit commercial deployment of vehicles that do not adhere to decades-old federal safety standards that were written for human-driven vehicles and require manual controls. But industry experts said regulatory gray areas and Elon Musk's litigious track record could give Tesla a chance to force the Cybercab into broad use anyway.

Amid a frenzy of fans and social media influencers in downtown Austin, Texas, Cybercabs were added to Tesla's robotaxi fleet that now operates its best-selling Model Y SUVs. Tesla said Cybercab rides were open to everyone and executives described pricing plans. The golden, butterfly-door Cybercab embodies Musk's strategy of betting the company on self-driving software and robotics. That bet has pushed its stock valuation to $1.4 trillion, more than the top several global automakers combined.

Elon Musk

Unlike most other countries, where new vehicle models and technology need regulatory clearance ahead of launch, automakers in the US can deploy them on the public roads by self-certifying that they meet federal standards. "Tesla historically has tested limits and pushed boundaries on regulations," said Philip Koopman, an autonomous-vehicle safety expert.

xAI Loses Court Bid to Block Minnesota's AI 'Nude' Ban

WASHINGTON: Minnesota's first-in-the-nation ban on AI-generated fake nude images will remain in effect as a constitutional challenge by Elon Musk's xAI proceeds, after a federal judge declined to block the law at an early stage of the case. Musk's xAI company argues the measure restricts free speech protected by the US Constitution, while Minnesota says the law is narrowly tailored to curb the spread of nonconsensual sexual imagery created with AI. —Reuters

Participation does not mean that every citizen will decide whether a project will take place or how it should be executed. But it means making citizens feel that this is my city, this is my project

ASHWINI BHIDE BMC COMMISSIONER

THE TWO-DAY TOI SUMMIT ENGAGED ON CORPORATE SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY AND ENVIRONMENT, SOCIAL AND GOVERNANCE GOALS

It is assumed that people start to give when they have made a lot of money, but 18- to 25-year-olds are giving as much as people older than them. Women make up 50% of donors

SUMIT TAYAL CEO, GIVE

AND THE HONOREES ARE...

ARMMAN
HEALTH & WELLBEING

Aims to reduce maternal and child mortality and morbidity; empowers women with access to vital health info and trains health workers, including auxiliary nurse midwives (ANMs); till now, has trained 17,000+ nurses, 4,500+ medical officers and 790 specialist doctors; LLM-powered WhatsApp assistant supports 8,500+ ANMs

MPOWER An initiative by Aditya Birla Education Trust
HEALTH & WELLBEING

Focuses on mental health, and provides awareness, counselling support, and psychiatric interventions. It reports reaching 7.1m+ people across 17 states and its awareness campaigns have reached more than 180m people

TELERAD FOUNDATION
HEALTH & WELLBEING

Focuses on making high-quality healthcare accessible; strengthens rural primary healthcare by integrating telemedicine into govt primary health centres in Maha, Karnataka, UP and Gujarat. In 2025-26, delivered 90,034 teleconsultations

DOST EDUCATION
EDUCATION & LEARNING

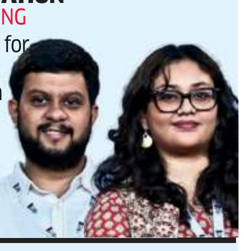
Focuses on early learning for kids aged 0-6 with the help of technology; content in five regional languages has reached 5,50,000+ caregivers and 1.1m children; has trained 35,000+ anganwadi workers and lady supervisors

TATA CONSULTANCY SERVICES
EDUCATION & LEARNING

The literacy programme has reached 2.85m learners through 2,41,000+ facilitators in 21 Indian states and UTs, and Africa since its 2000 launch. In 2025-26, its reach exceeded 4,12,000. It takes literacy to India's 180m adults

INVOLVE LEARNING SOLUTIONS FOUNDATION
EDUCATION & LEARNING

Designs interventions for student agency; impacted 1m students in 7,000+ govt schools in 6 states by training 13,452 teachers & 48,907 school leaders

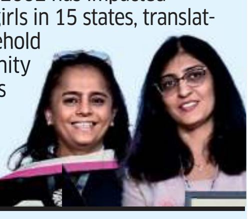


SAMBHAV FOUNDATION
GENDER EQUITY & INCLUSION

Offers 85+ vocational training and future-skilling courses; 2,500 women trained (1,750 placed) in mfg/green jobs, 12,000 reached via waste-picker initiative, 1,500+ impacted in beauty training

UDAYAN CARE
GENDER EQUITY & INCLUSION

Its programme since 2002 has impacted 20,300 at-risk teen girls in 15 states, translating into higher household incomes and community role models; provides mentoring, life-skills, guidance, and aid for education and leadership roles



SASKEN TECHNOLOGIES
GENDER EQUITY & INCLUSION

Women and girls empowered through social investment; it spans financial inclusion, nutrition, skilling and rural eyecare; 28% workforce representation, 25 lakh women reached, 13,000+ children fed through a nutrition plan

SOLINAS INTEGRITY
TECHNOLOGY & AI FOR SOCIAL GOOD

Deep-tech firm, incubated by IIT Madras, addresses water loss and sanitation worker safety by using robotics and AI; in Lucknow, 5.1 km of pipeline inspection identified 34 critical defects (28 repaired), saving an estimated 0.9m litres of water daily for 1,750 households

THE ASSOCIATION OF PEOPLE WITH DISABILITY
TECHNOLOGY & AI FOR SOCIAL GOOD

Works for people with disabilities (PwD); its Yes to Access (YTA) app lets citizens, volunteers and govts assess public-space accessibility via photos, using AI for checking 29 parameters

MARUTI SUZUKI INDIA
TECH & AI FOR SOCIAL GOOD

Improved driving licensing system with automated driving test tracks. Driving licence seekers get tested on these tracks on their driving skills by video analytics tech; at least 89% of applicants reported improved trust in testing

Sustainability Anchors Growth

ITC CMD urges corporates to balance economic progress with societal value

Our Bureau

ITC chairman and managing director Sanjiv Puri has said sustainability and inclusive growth must be an integral part of the corporate sector's business model, a model his conglomerate has followed.

"Economic progress cannot be seen in isolation from sustainability. Both have to go together... Corporates must create economic value, because that creates the foundation to go beyond. But it must be both economic and societal value. And that is what we call responsible competitiveness," Puri said in his keynote address at the **TOI** Social Impact Summit.

He called upon organisations to go beyond creating shareholder value. "This is going to become increasingly important in the future, not merely because regulations are more and more evolving in this space, but such behaviour is being asked by regulators — whether the regulations are related to the environment or social systems. Global trade regulations are also emerging, but also stakeholders are demanding it." He said it made business sense to work out models that help society.

Puri said the world was facing multiple challenges from geopolitical turmoil to weaponisation of tariffs and the climate crisis, which were putting pressure on livelihood, and food and nutrition security. "We are actually in a perfect storm. This convergence of challenges, uncertainty and rapid change call for novel strategies," he said, adding the vulnerable face maximum threat.

He called for a joint effort from government, corporate sector and civil society to deal with climate change while noting India has chosen a low carbon growth path.

Citing ITC's example, he said it created an entire ecosystem — from R&D to growing trees that do not suck out water and working with small farmers — to reduce dependence on pulp for the paperboard business, a model extended to fruit juices.

On CSR, Puri said it should be looked at as a business venture and its outcome evaluated. "You have to first invest in building capacity at the community level so that the initiatives are sustained and built upon. Otherwise, over a period of time, it can wither away."

PICS: UMA KADAM

(From left) MP Ahammed, chairman of Malabar Group of Companies; Sanjiv Puri, CMD of ITC; and Sivakumar Sundaram, CEO, The Times of India

Goyal Urges Innovators to Build Social Solutions

Our Bureau

Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal has called upon innovators and startups to develop low-cost and sustainable solutions to help civil society, corporate sector and government deal with initiatives that create social impact, such as cleaning up of lakes that he has started in his constituency.

"Maybe one of the innovators will come up with a cleaning machine for these lakes to maintain these lakes. There are machines internationally available but at a huge price. Maybe one of our startups will very easily be able to make it," Goyal said at the TOI Social Impact Summit on Saturday. The minister, an MP from North Mumbai, is seeking to clean up nine lakes in his constituency and expand the initiative to the city.

He said in India, citizens voluntarily take up social causes. "When the Companies Bill was piloted about 13-14 years ago bringing in the provision of (mandatory 2% spend on) CSR, we were in opposition. I remember in the finance committee when the bill came up for scrutiny, I had felt we are actually doing dis-service to the Indian ethos, to the Indian way of life because in India, people don't do CSR out of compulsion. The moment we bring it into the garb of compulsion, we change that connection. But be that as it may, it has brought more funds into CSR." He also said government's housing initiative had helped bring dignity to people and create assets while pushing a large section into the middle class. "That coming into the middle class, maybe neo middle class will move to upper middle class, will have a better quality of life. Double incomes are coming into families... this is spurring your economic growth. So, this is a very profitable proposition when you serve society."

At the Summit, BCCL COO Mohit Jain said growth must be measured not merely by output, investment and ambition, but by the lives it strengthens. "A tree does not grow upward alone but underneath as well," he said. "So, it is with the nation. The true strength of a country is revealed at its roots — in the student who gains access to better education, the patient who receives timely care and the community that becomes resilient enough to face an uncertain future."

TALKING POINTS

Seats at the Table

India's youth don't just want their voices to be heard. They want to actively participate in decision-making going forward. Inclusion of different generations and diverse perspectives is key to mitigating varied issues – this was the clear message delivered by a group of four young panelists at TOI's Social Impact Summit. As one of them summarised: "...10 years from now, I don't just want to see more young people sitting at a table. I want to see the tables that were built differently because we were there. Inclusion is the most important thing. Even the smallest voice, smallest act, smallest change can change the world."

Care Still Out of Reach

Healthcare access has grown, but specialist care remains uneven, delayed and heavily urban-centric, forcing patients in underserved regions to travel distances for even basic specialist consultations. This tension between expanded coverage and unequal access formed the core of the discussion at a panel featuring Dr Aparna Hegde, founder and managing Trustee, ARMMAN; Rizwan Koita, chairperson, National Accreditation Board for Hospitals & Healthcare (NABH); and Dr Shibu Vijayan, chief medical officer-global health, Qure.ai. Rizwan Koita, chairperson, NABH, said patients in underserved regions often travel 100-150 km to access specialist consultation, leading to delays in diagnosis, treatment and continuity of care.

Technology Seen as Bridge, Not Barrier

Our Bureau

Technology will not deepen India's education divide; used well, it could help close it. At the TOI Social Impact Summit, 2026, Pranav Kothari, CEO of Educational Initiatives, broke the myth that edtech is expensive or exclusionary. Technology, he stressed, is not a substitute for teachers, who remain better at inspiration, values, debates, experiments and project-based learning. But technology's strength lies in continuity: Indian schools operate for about 180 days a year and children attend for roughly 140 while learning can continue through the year.

Cyient founder chairman BVR Mohan Reddy said technology can also narrow the rich-poor gap by creating individual learning paths. Unlike a classroom model that often caters to the front benches, adaptive platforms can move each learner at his or her own pace.

Reddy also urged against fearing AI, warning that the real divide may be between those who understand AI and those who do not. His company adopted 37 government schools, where the share of girls rose from 16-18% to 56% and his school students occupied a lion's share of the merit rankers, and dropouts fell to about 2%. The intervention also expanded into skilling, AI labs and employment-linked training. In one programme, what started as a summer project for his granddaughter Pratinya Bodanapu, rural girls are trained in skills identified through market surveys.

Similar experiences were shared by Abdul Salam KP, vice chairman of Malabar Gold. The connection between poverty and education became stark during Covid while distributing food in urban slums, he said. "We found children on the streets even after schools reopened. That led to slum micro-learning centres, where teachers, uniforms, books and meals are provided and children without documents are helped into formal schools. The network has now grown to about 2,500 centres serving around 1.2 lakh children every day."

Gayatri Nair Lobo, CEO of Educate Girls, said school enrolment is only the first hurdle. Poverty, missing documents, domestic work, early marriage and the distance to secondary schools continue to push girls out. For every 100 primary schools, she said, there are only 20 senior secondary schools. Educate Girls is helping adolescent girls and young women return through open schooling. One, she said, returned after 10 years and went on to top Madhya Pradesh in Class 10.

Responsible Growth with Global Reach

Our Bureau

Speaking at the inaugural session of the TOI Social Impact Summit, 2026, MP Ahammed, chairman of the Malabar Group of Companies, said his business practices, with 450 showrooms in 24 countries, are aligned with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 'Make In India, Market to the World' theme.

Ahammed, who founded Malabar Gold & Diamonds — one of the world's largest retail jewellery groups — in Kozhikode 33 years ago, called it a "responsible group" based on three cardinal principles: "quality, warranty and guarantee". Ahammed added that he has always stressed on fair practices in all operations his company conducts in India and abroad, complying with local laws and regulations.

He said his employees are his "biggest assets" who are involved in making his products that people call "articles of gifting".

Explaining the group's allocation of ₹200 crore, 5% of its net trading profit, to the CSR programme for 2026-27, Ahammed said the core focus areas for CSR funding include education, hunger alleviation, healthcare and women's empowerment. Its "hunger-free world" project, he said, aims to feed vulnerable groups to achieve the objective of wiping out starvation from the world.

Panel discussion on 'Making Education Inclusive and Accessible for All'

Inclusion Must Mean Real Ownership

Our Bureau

A broader understanding of the word 'inclusion' is the need of the hour, and meaningful change must go beyond numerical targets and provide people with genuine ownership and representation, speakers from the social and corporate sector said at a panel on 'Scaling Inclusion'.

On what scaling of inclusion truly looks like, Chetna Sinha, founder of Mann Deshi Bank & Foundation headquartered in Mhaswad (Satara), a pioneering financial institution for rural women, cited the example of a village woman named 'Nakusa' or 'Unwanted' by her parents who, on growing up, succeeded in getting her name on 7/12 land extracts.

Women's economic aspirations must not be defined only by external measures of success, said Liby T Johnson, executive director of Odisha-based community development group Gram Vikas. "Many women may prefer a modest but reliable income they can control rather than pursuing bigger enterprises," Johnson said.

Rachana Iyer, CSR head, IDFC FIRST Bank, said their institution focuses on groups on the margins, including rural women and people with disabilities and neurodivergence. Calling for stronger partnerships between corporations, NGOs and governments, Rekha Pillai, CSR head, Castrol India, underlined how their flagship projects have helped over 6 lakh people from the unorganised sector.

Recycled Gold Powers Circular Economy

Our Bureau

Gold, the second-biggest import item for India in terms of value, is increasingly playing an important role in the circular economy that can meet part of the demand for the yellow metal from internal sources and save precious foreign exchange reserves. To integrate gold into the circular economy, every stakeholder is stepping up to bring in more transparency, trust, purity and responsible mining practices, experts from the field said.

The panel consisted of **Asher O**, MD-India operations, Malabar Gold & Diamonds; Sachin Jain, regional CEO India, World Gold Council; Vikram Dhawan, head-commodities and fund manager, Nippon Mutual Fund; Kaushlendra Sinha, CEO, Indian Association for Gold Excellence and Standards; and Mayank Sharma, president and head of gold loan, IIFL Finance.

Ashar said Malabar Gold & Diamond meets about 80% of the demand for gold from people trading in their old stock. Sinha of IAGES said a recent study by the entity showed a large number of young buyers were asking about gold's source, indicating a responsible buying attitude. Jain of WGC said they released a report suggesting responsible mining in India to substitute excessive dependence on imports. Sharma discussed gold loans and how credit flow from the sector is helping households and MSMEs. Dhawan explained how gold ETFs are leading to financialisation of the metal.

Community-Led Disaster Strategies

Our Bureau

India is moving away from a focus on only disaster response and relief towards disaster mitigation and resilience, said Sudarshan Suchi, chief development officer at Reliance Foundation, at a timely discussion on 'Rebooting Development for Disaster Resilience'.

The shift away from the emergency response approach includes preventing or reducing the worst impacts of disasters through better risk-informed planning, as well as enhancing the capacity of communities to cope with and recover from natural hazards, Suchi said. Reliance Foundation has a large disaster management programme working across several states. Increasingly, "all of our initiatives will be community-led," Suchi said.

Samhita R, founding CEO, Resilience-360 & Sudarshan Suchi, chief development officer, Reliance Foundation

Technology is aiding that shift, said Samhita R, co-founder and CEO of Resilience360, a startup that offers AI-powered climate risk management solutions. Using large language models, its software can provide quick, hyperlocal risk assessments. That, she said, can help people make risk-informed decisions and "future-proof communities".

Customised AI Driving Grassroots Change

Our Bureau

In a session on tech and AI in scaling change, panelists highlighted ways in which they'd each worked with technology and underscored how it could be customised to local contexts.

Aniket Doegar, co-founder and CEO, Haqdarshak, spoke about his organisation's use of tech to help people access the government's 20,000 schemes, including cash transfers, from which many are excluded because of "information asymmetry". AI use, on the other hand, was more evident on the "supply" side, with governments using it to simplify and standardise scheme data across states. **S Senthilkumaran** of Reliance Foundation highlighted how his team has been using AI to turn IMD's weather-update PDFs into advisories in local languages and across content formats, including YouTube videos.

AI is woven into the training Maker Bhavan Foundation imparts to young innovators and engineers in tier-2 and tier-3 cities, where its innovation labs let students experiment, create prototypes, and patent and commercialise them, said CEO Gautam Khanna. Even as AI is framed as the engine of growth, Richa Gautam, director of CSR and Sustainability at Schneider Electric India, argued for continued relevance of hands-on technical work.

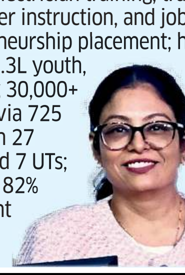
Meanwhile, Jyoti Sharma, CEO, NASSCOM Foundation, said AI should not be positioned as a substitute for people and should function as an enabler — helping teachers reach more students, for instance, without making the teacher irrelevant.

ANUDIP FOUNDATION FOR SOCIAL WELFARE
SKILLING & ECONOMIC EMPOWERMENT

Trains youth and women since 2007 in coding, AI and professional devpt; operates 100+ centres in 22 states with 450+ hiring partners; placed 70% of certified candidates

SCHNEIDER ELECTRIC
SKILLING & ECONOMIC EMPOWERMENT

Since 2009, has built one of India's largest corporate vocational movements, combining industry-aligned electrician training, train-the-trainer instruction, and job/entrepreneurship placement; has trained 3.3L youth, including 30,000+ women, via 725 centres in 27 states and 7 UTs; reported 82% placement



LEND A HAND INDIA
SKILLING & ECONOMIC EMPOWERMENT

Focuses on vocational education, including workshop, engineering, food processing and agriculture skills as a core component of curriculum in govt and govt-aided schools; has reached 2m+ students in 20,000+ schools, with 3-year post-school tracking showing stronger employment, self-employment and tech edu outcomes

HINDUSTAN UNILEVER
CLIMATE, WATER & ENVIRONMENTAL SUSTAINABILITY

HUL's flagship urban sanitation & environmental sustainability initiative, Suvidha; run with BMC since 2016; its 25 centres serve 6,00,000+ annual users, recycle 300m+ litres, avoid 4m kg CO_2e annually; 100% sewer connection

PRADAN
CLIMATE, WATER & ENVIRONMENTAL SUSTAINABILITY

Its Water Access Through Ecosystem Restoration (WATER) initiative is in 7 states; impact: 11,872 acres irrigation, 1,352 ponds, 568 solar lifts, 422 wells, Rs 66.2cr convergence, 14,132 women asset managers

SAAHAS
CLIMATE, WATER & ENVIRONMENTAL SUSTAINABILITY

Set up to promote solid waste mgmt in 2001 with a focus on resource recovery, has diverted 1,450+ MT waste, achieved 90% segregation, 94% collection, 1,111 tCO_2e cut in peri-urban Bengaluru

CONTRAPUNTO One must still have chaos in oneself to be able to give birth to a dancing star. **FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE**

US Envoys Make First Kyiv Visit Amid Ukraine War Peace Push

Zelenskyy says Ukraine has proposals ready and seeks firm security guarantees

Kyiv: US peace envoys Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff met Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Kyiv on Sunday as the Trump administration renewed its push to end Russia's four-and-a-half-year war in Ukraine.

Kushner and Witkoff travelled from Moscow, where they held three hours of talks with Russian President Vladimir Putin on Saturday but did not appear to secure a breakthrough.

Previous rounds of US-mediated peace talks encouraged by President Donald Trump, who campaigned on a promise to quickly end the war, have yielded few results. Trump suggested on Friday that the US had a fresh proposal, but did not elaborate.

The two envoys met Zelenskyy and other senior Ukrainian officials in central Kyiv. Zelenskyy, who believes Washington will be key to any peace deal, has said a window of opportunity to make peace exists before the US begins focusing on its next presidential election.

After the first round of talks between Ukrainian and US negotiators, which lasted about three hours, the US envoys said they were encouraged by the discussions.

(L-R) US envoys Jared Kushner, Steve Witkoff along with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Kyiv on Sunday.

DIPLOMATIC OPENING

Zelenskyy has said there is a window to make peace before the US focuses on its next presidential elections next summer

"Substantive, important, and we are very encouraged," Witkoff told reporters after the talks, which also included a working lunch.

Zelenskyy said further talks, including with European representatives, were planned for later on Sunday. British, French and German national security advisers were also in Kyiv.

"Security guarantees are needed. A dignified post-war peace is needed. Our proposals have been drawn up," Zelenskiy said as his negotiating team prepared to meet the US envoys. **Reuters**

Putin-Trump-Xi Meeting Not Ruled Out: Russia

Moscow: Russia has not ruled out a trilateral meeting between the presidents of Russia, the US and China, Deputy Foreign Minister Sergei Ryabkov said on Sunday, state news agency TASS reported. However, before moving to preparations for such a meeting, it is necessary to determine what its agenda would be, Ryabkov said. Earlier this month, Kremlin aide Yuri Ushakov raised the possibility of a meeting between Vladimir Putin, Donald Trump and Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit in Shenzhen, China, in November. **Reuters**

'Total Lie' Washington Denies Iran Claim of Strike on US Vessel

Escalations erupted after calm, military struggle & financial isolation emerging as US' strategy

Cairo: Iran said Sunday it struck an unmanned US vessel trying to enter the Strait of Hormuz, a claim that the US military dismissed as a "total lie."

The purported attack came a day after the US military said forces struck three Iranian oil tankers in response to Navy warships being targeted with ballistic missiles. Experts called it a dangerous escalation after Iran's previous attacks at sea targeted commercial shipping.

The war began with US and Israeli attacks on Iran on Feb. 28. But since a fragile ceasefire agreement was announced in June, on-and-off fighting has persisted, with both sides trying to inflict military and economic pain as negotiations have collapsed. Strikes came about a week after fighting resumed

The United States and Iran resumed attacks last week, following a month of relative calm, with the Strait of Hormuz and areas along Iran's southern coast again being targeted. At least five people were killed earlier in the week during a US bombardment that returned attention to the area where a school was hit in the war's opening strikes.

The Trump administration appears to have adopted a dual-prong approach to the conflict, responding militarily to attacks on the strait while going after foreign financial institutions that handle Iran's money. But Tehran's hard-line new senior leaders have signaled a willingness to dig in after weathering decades of sanctions. Iran has found ways over the years to circumvent sanctions, and now a US blockade of its ports, and get its oil to buyers to help ease growing economic pressures. **AP**

US Carrier Lincoln Departs Thailand After Respite Visit

Bangkok: Thousands of US sailors aboard an aircraft carrier departed from Thailand on Sunday, AFP journalists said, concluding its first port call following reports of deteriorating living conditions on board after nine months at sea. The 5,000-strong crew of the USS Abraham Lincoln docked just north of the resort town of Pattaya, on Wednesday for five days of rest and recreation after a lengthy Middle East deployment. The Lincoln departed from the port of Laem Chabang, a half-hour drive from Pattaya, at around 11:00 am (0400 GMT). **AFP**

OPEC+ Keeps Output Targets Unchanged Amid Iran War

Major OPEC+ nations stuck to their plan to keep oil production quotas unchanged as the Iran war continues to shut vast swathes of output in the Middle East.

A subgroup of seven countries led by Saudi Arabia and Russia, which held a monthly video conference on Sunday, will keep targets unchanged in October after a series of nominal quota increases, OPEC said in a statement. That is in line with the group's roadmap to hold targets steady through the end of the year.

The US-Iran conflict has blunted the impact of OPEC+ decisions for now, as disruption in the Strait of Hormuz has severely curtailed oil exports from Persian Gulf nations. Several producers, however, have managed to sustain flows through alternative pipeline routes and covert shuttle runs.

Last week, renewed hostilities sent oil prices higher after US President Donald Trump ordered fresh attacks on Iranian facilities

Despite the reduced flows, the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and its allies continued to raise quotas during the war, nominally completing the reversal of output curbs imposed in 2023 and potentially giving some members greater leeway to boost production once the fighting subsides.

While the coalition formally has another layer of halted supplies to restore, doing so will be complicated by deteriorating production capacity in many member countries since the curbs were introduced. The war has further clouded the outlook. **Bloomberg**

Netanyahu Orders West Bank Outposts Cleared Following US Pressure

Washington has urged Israel to take tougher action against settlers

Benjamin Netanyahu

Tel Aviv: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has ordered unauthorized settler outposts in the West Bank to be dismantled, two people familiar with the matter said on Sunday, amid US pressure on Israel to crack down on settler attacks against Palestinians.

The order applies to outposts established by settlers without official authorization from the Israeli state, the sources said. Such outposts typically consist of prefabricated caravans housing a small number of settlers. The state has periodically demolished such structures while formally recognizing others, allowing them to receive government funding.

It was not immediately clear when the operation would begin.

UN bodies and most governments consider all Israeli settlements illegal under international law and regard the West Bank as occupied territory under military control. Israel argues the territory is disputed, not occupied.

Netanyahu ordered the eviction of the unauthorized outposts in response to pressure from the United States, Israel's closest ally, the sources said.

US Ambassador to Israel Mike Huckabee on Saturday denounced violent settlers as terrorists and called for them to face severe consequences after meeting several Palestinian Americans in a West Bank town.

Israeli website Ynet earlier reported that the orders targeted about 100 outposts across the occupied territory.

The Israeli prime minister's office and military, which would normally be involved in clearing outposts in the West Bank, did not immediately respond to requests for comment. **Reuters**

Israeli Strikes Kill Seven in South Lebanon

Israeli strikes killed seven people, including two women, in southern Lebanon on Sunday, the Lebanese health ministry said, as Israel retaliated for what it said were Hezbollah drone attacks in areas occupied by its troops.

Despite a US-brokered ceasefire with Hezbollah agreed in June, the Israeli military continues to operate in what it has declared a security zone in southern Lebanon.

Lebanon's health ministry said two men were killed in a town on the edge of the zone occupied by Israeli troops.

Despite a US-brokered June ceasefire, Israel continues to operate in a declared security zone in southern Lebanon

The ministry later said a separate Israeli drone strike on Nabatieh al-Tahta in southern Lebanon killed three people on Sunday.

The Israeli military had issued an online evacuation warning at 6 a.m. local time (0300 GMT) for areas near a building in Arab Salim that it said it would strike because it was being used by Hezbollah.

Lebanese President Joseph Aoun's office called Sunday's strikes, which it said destroyed a hospital and damaged a Finance Ministry building, "a dangerous escalation" targeting "purely civilian administrations and health centres". **Reuters**

FIXING FUNDAMENTALS

China to Inject $54 Billion into State Insurers, Banks

Beijing: China's finance ministry will inject a combined $54 billion into state-owned insurers and banks, the companies said on Sunday, in a coordinated push by Beijing to shore up capital across its financial system.

China Life Insurance (Group), the country's largest life insurer, will receive $5.2 billion, while China Taiping Insurance Group will get 7 billion yuan, the two groups said in statements.

Separately People's Insurance Company (Group) of China said it planned to raise up to 15 billion yuan through a private placement of A-shares to the Ministry of Finance, with the proceeds to be used to replenish its capital.

The initiative could help bolster state insurers that were directed to support the stock market with medium- and long-term funds, while positioning them to help regulators manage smaller, higher-risk insurance companies.

ISSUES IN INSURANCE SECTOR

The insurance sector has been grappling with eroding profitability due to persistently low interest rates, with numerous small and mid-sized insurers reporting deteriorating solvency ratios.

China Export and Credit Insurance also said the finance ministry will inject 10 billion yuan to boost its core capital, and China Reinsurance (Group) said it will raise 3 billion yuan.

"The injection is an important step by the country to enhance the financial sector's ability to serve the real economy and promote the high-quality development of the financial and insurance industries," China Life said in its statement, adding that it would strengthen the group's ability to withstand risks. Taiping said the funds would bolster its solvency and other key indicators.

BANKS SEARCH FOR CAPITAL

Separately, three state lenders on Sunday also announced they will receive a combined 290 billion yuan in capital injections.

The plan was first unveiled at an annual parliamentary meeting in March this year, extending a financing tool that had helped bolster some other big state banks last year.

Agricultural Bank of China and Industrial and Commercial Bank of China, two of the country's largest state banks, said they planned to raise up to 160 billion yuan and 100 billion yuan respectively through private A-share placements to the finance ministry, China National Tobacco and its subsidiaries. **Reuters**

Washington Renews Supreme Court Bid to Curb Mail-in Voting

The Trump administration on Sunday renewed its appeal to the US Supreme Court to allow a plan that could limit mail-in ballots ahead of November's congressional elections, after a federal judge last week blocked those restrictions.

Lawyers for the Trump administration filed an emergency application to the nation's highest court to allow the US Postal Service to implement a rule restricting mail-in voting, even as some US states have already started sending out postal ballots ahead of the November 3 midterm elections.

On Friday, Boston-based US District Judge Indira Talwani extended a ban preventing the new rule from taking effect.

The final decision on whether the administration's mail-in voting restrictions can proceed likely now rests with the Supreme Court.

Solicitor General John Sauer, representing the Trump administration, urged the Supreme Court to allow the rule to immediately go into effect, warning that each day the lower court's injunction remains in place "risks sowing confusion and chaos" as more states issue mail ballots.

Supreme Court Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson set a deadline of Wednesday for responses to the Trump administration's request.

The administration had filed an earlier emergency request to the Supreme Court to overturn Talwani's shorter-term injunction. Before the top court had ruled on that application, she extended her ban on Friday, leading to the administration's new filing on Sunday.

The USPS issued its rule to implement an executive order that President Donald Trump signed in March. **Reuters**

Turkey Lifts Year-end Inflation Forecast to 28.4% on Iran War

Turkey has raised its year-end inflation forecast to 28.4%, Vice President Cevdet Yilmaz said on Sunday when he unveiled the country's medium-term economic programme for 2027-2029.

"We expect inflation to start declining again in the fourth quarter of 2026 and to reach 28.4% by the end of the year," Yilmaz said in a televised address. The new forecast is significantly higher than previous projections.

In last year's medium-term programme covering 2026-2028, the government had forecast year-end inflation at 16%. Under the new programme, inflation is projected to fall to 21% in 2027, 13.5% in 2028 and 9% in 2029.

Turkey's annual inflation rate eased to 31.51% in August from 31.75% in July, according to official data. Yilmaz said the war in West Asia had played a key role in the upward revision of the inflation outlook.

"According to our central bank, the direct and indirect effects of the war on inflation have been estimated at approximately seven percentage points," he said.

Annual inflation, which has remained above 30% since December 2021, peaked at more than 75% in May 2024 before beginning to slow.

Yilmaz said the government had made "significant progress in combating inflation". **AFP**

Germany's Far-Right AfD Wins Key State Vote

Berlin: Germany's far-right AfD won a landslide victory in a key regional election on Sunday in the former communist east, according to exit polls, although it remained unclear whether the party could secure an outright majority to govern.

"We have made history today," said a jubilant Ulrich Siegmund, the 35-year-old lead candidate of the anti-immigration Alternative for Germany party in Saxony-Anhalt, as the vote count continued.

The AfD won at least 44%, more than doubling its support and far ahead of the 18.5% for Chancellor Friedrich Merz's centre-right CDU, according to projections by public broadcasters ARD and ZDF.

The CDU's state premier Sven Schulze called the outcome "a severe blow" but, depending on the final count and the fate of smaller parties, may still try to cobble together a multi-party coalition to retain power. **AFP**

Guyana to Receive Deportees from US

Guyana will receive migrants deported from the United States, according to an agreement announced Saturday by the South American country's government.

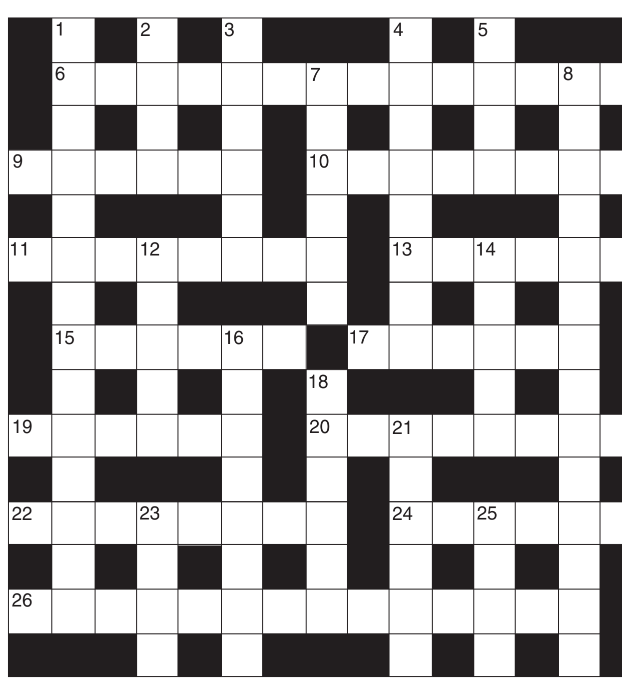
Since President Donald Trump's return to the White House in 2026, his office has carried out an aggressive anti-immigrant crackdown that includes deportations to "third countries," other than the deportee's home country.

Guyana has agreed to receive a limited number of deportees who do not have a criminal record.

"President Irfaan Ali's Government has framed the arrangement as an extension of Guyana's longstanding commitment to human rights and international cooperation," a statement from Ali's office said. Other Central American and Caribbean countries have agreed to cooperate with Washington's deportation campaign, which sent 250 Venezuelans to El Salvador's CECOT facility, a maximum-security prison. **AFP**

NON-SEQUITUR

Crossword 9697



ACROSS

6 Suspected a rebel's involved in design of suit (6-8)
9 Sixth queen returned capital (6)
10 Restricted name indicated on drawing? (8)
11 'Ein Spitz' translates as 'very small' (4-4)
13 Birds exercise senses (6)
15 Oddly, Twiggy hates wearing them (6)
17 Entirely enthusiastic about taking over at first (2,4)
19 Mould art after a fashion in jumble (6)
20 He forgets before 12, since being injured about one (8)
22 State invigilators sacked – lots go missing (8)
24 Seaman another recalled in Grangemouth (6)
26 Adore man in debt, ruined? Keep him away from this (3-5,6)

DOWN

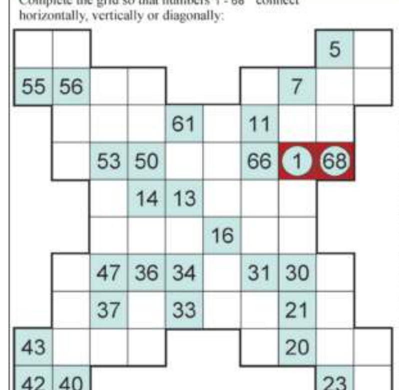
1 Management isn't embarrassed being held in high regard (14)
2 Nearly regretting collapse (4)
3 Base found in chalk, a limited amount (6)
4 Quirky painter crossed river to find reptile (8)
5 Punishment when belligerent offenders start (4)
7 Sort of 18 was called Garnett in UK (6)
8 Sundry latecomers grab unruly gent; they're attractive (14)
12 He's favourite to win row about golf clubs (5,5)
14 See 12
16 Too many confused about unknown classification (8)
18 London guide infiltrated difficult venture (6)
21 Par for Greg, losing last to student (6)
23 Attack animal (4)
25 Current changeover (4)

SOLUTION TO No. 9696:
ACROSS: **1** Lisburn. **5** Ducats. **9** Tail end. **10** Sparkle. **11** Law. **12** Staging post. **13** Patio. **14** Stairwell. **16** Alterable. **17** Cecil. **19** See eye to eye. **22** Elm. **23** Caitlin. **24** Gumtree. **26** Senate. **27** Scrumps.
DOWN: **1** Let slip. **2** Swim with the tide. **3** Use. **4** Nadia. **5** Dissipate. **6** Craig. **7** Take one's cue from. **8** Dental. **12** Scour. **14** Substance. **15** Ruche. **16** Alsace. **18** Lumbers. **20** Yalta. **21** Edges. **25** Mar.

HIDATO

FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 68 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally.



www.hidato.com

Dif. ★★★☆☆

Yesterday's puzzle solution.

7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 neighbor of a Kansan (9)	________
2 laborious (9)	________
3 some adopted pets (7)	________
4 alpha follower (4)	________
5 habeas corpus, for one (4)	________
6 "Swan Lake" composer (11)	________
7 barbecue flavorer (8)	________

OKL	WR	OUS	MAN	SC
ENU	AIK	ITE	IT	MES
TCH	SKY	BE	RE	STR
UES	QU	AHO	OV	TA

Yesterday's Answers: 1. SUDS 2. BYPASSING 3. OATS 4. CAVIAR 5. CIVILITY 6. SOGGINESS 7. EARS

10/18

ICAI Explores PE Funding for Consultancy, Accounting

To examine if non-assurance practices can be separated from tax audits

Twesh Mishra

New Delhi: The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) is weighing allowing private equity investment in non-audit business of accounting firms through a clear split between the assurance and non-assurance practices, its president Prasanna Kumar D said.

The institute has set up an internal committee to examine whether non-assurance services such as consultancy, accounting and advisory can be separated from assurance practices such as statutory, tax and compliance audits to facilitate private equity investment and help these entities grow.

Assurance practices, however, will be ring-fenced from such investment over concerns about auditor independence. Kumar said audit and other assurance services require professionals to remain free from conflicts of interest and commercial pressure. "Independence is the issue," Kumar said. "Our view is that non-assurance practices can be separated. If so, can we permit it or not?"

The ICAI committee is studying global models and regulations in countries that have allowed private equity investment in accounting firms. It will also examine the history, ownership structures and experience with such investments before making its recommendation.

If the committee decides in favour, the proposal will first need the ICAI council's approval, Kumar said. It would subsequently require an amendment to the Chartered Accountants Act and would be taken to the government for consideration.

According to Jean Bouquot, president of the International Federation of Accountants (IFAC), private equity remains "a relatively new development in the global accountancy profession". The key requirement is that firms continue to comply with professional ethics, audit standards and independence rules, he said. Bouquot was in the national capital for an IFAC board meeting last week, held in India for the first time.

An IFAC study released earlier this year highlighted the rapid growth of private equity investment in professional accountancy firms. The research pointed to the extent of transformation in the sector, with fewer than 200 initial or direct private equity investments facilitating nearly 900 subsequent transactions, underscoring significant consolidation across the profession.

AI CHALLENGE

The rise of artificial intelligence, which is giving accountants access to large volumes of data, is also reshaping the accountancy profession. "Young people should see technology as an opportunity," said Lee White, CEO at IFAC.

Professional accountants will continue to need digital skills, but judgement, scepticism and ethics remain central to the profession, White added. White cautioned against relying on automated tax or accounting advice generated solely through AI.

If the service is provided by a chartered accountant, professional obligations apply, he said, adding that the accountant is expected to ensure that the advice is reliable and delivered with due care. "The risks may be greater when such services are provided by entities outside the profession," he said.

ICAI, meanwhile, does not plan to authenticate or approve individual AI-based tax and accounting software.

"Technology is changing too quickly for the institute to certify tools on a continuing basis. Independent certifying agencies may emerge in the future," Kumar said.

Our view is that non-assurance practices can be separated. If so, can we permit it or not?

PRASANNA KUMAR D
President, ICAI

Finmin Secures $1 Billion IFC Funding for MSMEs

IFC has already released $500 M to Sidbi to provide 7-yr loans under the facility

Deepshikha Sikarwar

New Delhi: India has secured $1 billion in funding from the International Finance Corporation (IFC) to help banks and financial institutions provide more long-term credit to small businesses, a senior finance ministry official told **ET**. This complements the credit support available to the sector through the government's Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS).

Small is Big

Facility to help spur MSME capital expenditure and investment

Credit facility swapped into INR through RBI's special swap window

Focus on manufacturing, services and employment-intensive sectors

Seven-year loans for machinery, modernisation, expansion and projects

Sidbi to lend to financial institutions for MSME loan refinancing

Facility will help bridge Sidbi's borrowing and MSME loan tenor mismatch

"This will ensure availability of long-term credit to MSMEs (micro, small and medium enterprises)...," the official said, adding that the facility will help address a key gap in the sector by providing long-term loans of up to seven years.

The IFC has already provided $500 million to Small Industries Development Bank of India (Sidbi) from its own resources, and the balance $500 million would be arranged through the lender's syndicate for this long-term counter-cyclical funding platform, according to the official.

The facility complements the credit support available to MSMEs through the government's ECLGS

The finance ministry said this facility would help galvanise MSME capital expenditure investment, topping the efforts to address the short-term funding issues through the ECLGS 5.0.

The credit facility has been swapped into INR using the Reserve Bank of India's special swap window, said another official.

This special funding facility under Sidbi will focus on MSMEs in the manufacturing and services value chains, including auto and auto components, engineering goods, electronics, textiles, food processing, logistics services and other employment-intensive sectors, the person said.

A large chunk of the funding will be deployed by Sidbi to directly on-lend to MSMEs for a tenor of seven years with a suitable moratorium, primarily for machinery acquisition, modernisation, expansion and project funding, the official said.

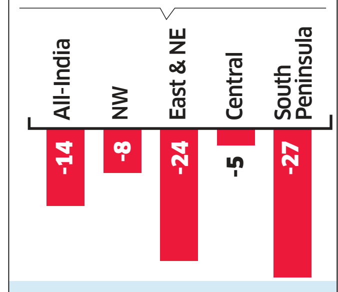
Sidbi will also use the proceeds to lend to financial institutions, especially the non-banking finance companies, to refinance existing MSME loans, extended primarily to micro enterprises and first-time borrowers, the person said.

This facility will help correct the mismatch in Sidbi's loan book and aid it in providing longer-tenure credit to the sector.

Currently, none of Sidbi's borrowings has a tenor of more than five years, while its MSME credit book has a tenor of 4.8-5.4 years.

MONSOON Watch

CUMULATIVE RAINFALL FROM JUNE 1 TO SEPTEMBER 6 (% DEPARTURE FROM NORMAL)



LAST 7 DAYS' REPORT, STATE-WISE

Cumulative departure (%)

Till Aug 30 | Till Sep 6

Relative improvement in monsoon progress

State	Till Aug 30	Till Sep 6
Uttarakhand	-3	4
Uttar Pradesh	-7	-1
Bihar	-40	-35
Jharkhand	-10	-5
Madhya Pradesh	-9	-6

Slowdown in monsoon progress

State	Till Aug 30	Till Sep 6
Gujarat	-12	-17
Odisha	25	20
Andhra Pradesh	-41	-45
Maharashtra	-11	-15
Telangana	-18	-22

Under the influence of Low-Pressure Area over southwest Uttar Pradesh & neighbourhood, isolated heavy to very heavy rainfall very likely over Uttarakhand & West Uttar Pradesh

Source: IMD

AS CBAM COMPLIANCE BITES...

Engg Exporters Seek Carbon Data Mandate

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Engineering goods exporters have sought a government mandate requiring raw-material suppliers to provide accredited carbon emissions data, saying small companies could be unable to export to the European Union without it because of requirements under the bloc's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM).

The concern, according to engineering exports body EEPC, is that importers of raw materials need to provide accredited carbon emissions data but are unable to do so, leaving exporters without the required test certificates. "Our entire value chain is impacted but most emissions happen in raw materials. We need accredited carbon emission data from them otherwise we can't have test certificates," said EEPC chairman Pankaj Chadha.

Under CBAM, importers must submit annual declarations based either on actual verified emissions data or default emissions values. For actual emissions, verification must be carried out by independent verifiers accredited by EU national accreditation bodies. CBAM came into force in January. "70% of the engineering exports to the EU are from MSMEs and they need accredited data for carbon emission certificates. Hence, a mandate is required for this," Chadha said.

On trade with the US, Chadha identified the proposed Lindsey Graham tariff bill, passed by the US Senate and pending in the House of Representatives, as the biggest concern.

Manual Licence Checks Must for Pharma, Medical Imports

New Delhi: The Centre has asked customs officers to manually verify licences, permissions and registration certificates before clearing imported drugs, medical devices, cosmetics and a wide range of other healthcare products and manufacturing inputs.

The check will apply even to facilitated Bills of Entry, or imports that have otherwise been cleared through the customs risk-management system, according to a September 3 communication sent by the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) to importers and field formations.

The check will apply even to facilitated Bills of Entry, or imports that have otherwise been cleared through the customs risk-management system

The reason is a gap in the government's digital single-window system for imports, SWIFT 2.0, which allows importers to submit information and obtain clearances from different government agencies through a common electronic process instead of dealing separately with each agency. However, regulatory documents of the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) are not yet fully integrated into the system. Hence, the drug regulator has requested CBIC to check the documents themselves before giving out-of-charge, the final approval that allows an importer to take the goods out of customs custody. CDSCO has provided customs with seven product-specific checklists covering cosmetics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and finished medicines, medicines imported for personal use, certain small-quantity imports of new drugs as well as medical devices, in-vitro diagnostic kits, and raw materials and components used to manufacture medical devices. —**Our Bureau**

US Inflation Data, Crude Oil to Steer Bullion This Week

New Delhi: Upcoming US inflation figures, crude oil price movements, and geopolitical tensions in West Asia will be primary triggers for gold and silver prices, amid heightened speculation surrounding the global interest rate outlook, analysts said.

Investors will also keep an eye on consumer price data from Germany and China, GDP figures from the Eurozone, Japan and the UK, as well as China's trade data this week, they added. "US inflation numbers would be the key trigger for bullion markets amid considerable speculation over the interest rate outlook," Pranav Mer, Senior Vice President, EBG - Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd, said. US Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation report for August 2026 is scheduled for release on September 11.

"In gold, the prices look for resistance at ₹1.57 lakh per 10 grams, while in case of silver we still maintain a positive bias till prices are above supports at ₹2.31 lakh per kg," Pranav Mer, Senior Vice President, EBG - Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd, said.

Last week, gold futures for October delivery fell ₹3,514, or 2.2 %, to ₹1.52 lakh per 10 grams, while silver declined ₹4,786, or nearly 2%, to ₹2.37 lakh per kg on the Multi Commodity Exchange.

"MCX gold witnessed volatile moves this week, with the first half seeing continued profit booking following last Friday's correction after the Fed indicated the possibility of a rate hike," Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said. In global markets, Comex gold futures for December delivery slipped $ 53.3, or nearly 1.2 per cent, to end the week at $4,476.6 per ounce.

Silver dipped by 1.52 per cent to $66.75 per ounce in New York. Mer said gold prices remained under pressure on Friday after stronger-than-expected US jobs data boosted expectations that the Federal Reserve could raise interest rates later this month.—**PTI**

Sports World Play

VITALS

CHINA MASTERS FINAL

Satwik-Chirag Wins in Boost for Asian Games

Shenzhen: Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty say staying "mindfully aggressive" helped them break the China Masters jinx and the triumph has provided a "big boost" ahead of the Asian Games where they will go "all guns blazing". It was third time lucky for the Indian duo as they produced a stirring comeback to beat China's He Ji Ting and Ren Xiang Yu 11-21 21-13 21-17 and clinch the $1,250,000 China Masters Super 750 title on Sunday. "We made a game plan before coming, it worked. We broke the jinx and I think (it's our) second title in 2026. Really happy," Satwik said after the game. The title comes weeks ahead of their title defence at the Asian Games which start from September 19 in Japan. **PTI**

AFC U20

India Qualify for Main Tourney After 20 Yrs

Tashkent: India qualified for the AFC U20 Asian Cup main tournament for the first time in 20 years after a commanding 3-0 win over Bangladesh in their final group match of the qualifying event here on Sunday. The win, their second in the qualifiers, took India to six points from three matches. They had to wait for the result of Syria vs Uzbekistan match played later on Sunday to know their fate. With Syria losing 0-3 to Uzbekistan, India finished second in Group B and qualified for the AFC U20 Asian Cup main tournament as one of the seven best runners-up teams. **PTI**

US OPEN

Sabalenka Keeps 3-peat Hopes Alive with Win

New York: World number one Aryna Sabalenka charged into the US Open quarter-finals on Sunday, beating American Taylor Townsend 6-4, 6-3 to keep her bid for a rare US Open three-peat alive. Sabalenka needed all of her resolve against the multi-faceted Townsend. The Belarusian must win in New York to retain her No 1 status. **AFP**

'ANT' MAN

FORMULA 1 Kimi Antonelli wins Monza GP from back of the grid, is first Italian to win home race in 60 yrs

Alan Baldwin

Formula One leader Kimi Antonelli won his home Italian Grand Prix after a sensational race from 19th to first on Sunday in a massive blow for Mercedes teammate and closest championship rival George Russell.

The 20-year-old was the first Italian winner at Monza since Ludovico Scarfiotti for Ferrari in 1966.

Russell, who had led a re-start after Ferrari's Charles Leclerc crashed heavily at the end of lap two, finished second—3.857 seconds behind—after being hunted down by a teammate on fresher tyres late in the race with Max Verstappen a distant third for Red Bull. The Briton had hoped to slash Antonelli's 59-point lead after the Italian took an engine penalty and lined up on the back row of the grid, with two other drivers starting in the pitlane, but instead ended up 66 adrift after 13 rounds.

"Oh my god, oh my god," screamed Antonelli over the team radio as he took the chequered flag as a winner for the seventh time this season and gave the crowd something to celebrate after Ferrari failed to make the podium. "I am so happy and I could have never imagined to be here today. But we managed to pull it off and I'm really, really happy," he said later, after stepping out onto the podium to huge cheers.

INTO THE GRAVEL

The Italian, who swapped the lead repeatedly with Russell before pitting during a virtual safety car period while Russell stayed out, cut an 8.9 second gap to less than a second in 10 laps but then appeared to have wasted his efforts.

Trying to pass, Antonelli went into the gravel with four laps to go but still came back and took back the lead on lap 52 of 53 before pulling away. "Our Italian hero. So deserved. That was a fantastic lap. I hated the last one, but it was fantastic," commented Mercedes team boss Toto Wolff over the team radio after the flag.

Russell said he did not have the tyres to fight back.

"It was looking like a pretty strong race from us, and then I was just struggling with the tyres towards the end. Obviously, we did the whole race on that one hard tyre," he said. **Reuters**

GRID POSITION
(Standings after Monza)

Driver	Pts	Team
1 Kimi Antonelli	267	Mercedes
2 George Russell	201	Mercedes
3 Lewis Hamilton	191	Ferrari
4 Lando Norris	171	McLaren
5 Charles Leclerc	155	Ferrari

Team	Pts
Mercedes	468
Ferrari	346
McLaren	287
Red Bull Racing	204
Racing Bulls	87

Oh my god, oh my god! I am so happy and I could have never imagined to be here today. But we managed to pull it off and I'm really, really happy

KIMI ANTONELLI
after the victory

Barca Fire 5 Past Valencia

Fermin Lopez scored a goal and created two others as champions Barcelona eased to a 5-0 victory over hosts Valencia in their LaLiga clash on Sunday to maintain their 100% start to the new season. Lamine Yamal (two), Raphinha and Pedri were also on target for the visitors, who controlled the contest from the start and lead the LaLiga table with 12 points from four games, three more than second-placed Real Madrid. Barca handed a debut to Gabriel Jesus off the bench following his move from Arsenal. The visitors have now scored 17 goals this season in four games. **AFP**

Arsenal Win, Man United Held

The Arsenal passed the biggest test of its Premier League title defense so far by rallying to a 2-1 win against Chelsea on Sunday. **Martin Odegaard** struck a 50th-minute winner at the Emirates Stadium after Morgan Rogers had given Chelsea an early lead. Kai Havertz equalised in the first half for Arsenal, who have a 100% record after three games. Manchester United 's difficult start to the season continued with a 2-2 draw at Everton, despite twice leading at Hill Dickinson Stadium. Ainsley Maitland-Niles struck in added time to rescue a 2-2 draw for Everton against United. **AP**